

NONSOFIC GROUPS EXIST

ANONYMOUS

ABSTRACT. We prove that nonsofic groups exist: for every $m \geq 1$, the group $\mathrm{EL}_{m+1}(L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2))$ of elementary matrices over the binary Leavitt algebra is infinite, finitely generated, has Kazhdan’s property (T) , and is not sofic. The proof is engineered for verification: the two auxiliary matrices on which the construction turns are explicit products of elementary matrices, the remaining memberships reduce to one Whitehead identity and exhibited commutators of units, and no K -theory is used.

The engine is a compression–centralizer criterion. If a Kazhdan group is generated by an infinite Kazhdan subgroup Γ together with finitely many elements that conjugate Γ into itself, then in a hypothetical sofic approximation the expander decompositions supplied by Kun’s theorem, for Γ and for the ambient group, can be matched almost bijectively: a median normalization of component sizes is almost monotone along compressor arcs, exact conservation under permutations makes the estimate two-sided, and an ℓ^1 co-area inequality pins the normalized sizes at their median. Localizing to one matched component yields a sofic approximation of $K \times J$ whose K -edges expand, and the Kun–Thom obstruction forces the commuting subgroup J to be locally embeddable into finite groups (LEF). The Leavitt relations realize the scheme with J a two-generator subgroup of a corner copy of Thompson’s group V that is not LEF for a finite reason: in a finite group the two F -relators force commutation, and the witness pair does not commute.

Self-similarity spreads the conclusion: over every finite field k , the unit group of $L_k(1, 2)$, every GL_r , and every EL_r with $r \geq 2$ are mutually isomorphic Kazhdan nonsofic groups. Every finitely generated nonsofic group is a quotient of an infinite finitely presented nonsofic group, Kazhdan whenever the original is; so not every finitely presented group is sofic, and neither soficity, local embeddability, nor residual finiteness is closed under quotients. The published proofs of the two decomposition theorems are audited: two local gaps are repaired, and the spectral implication of a published equivalence is refuted by counterexample. An appendix gives an elementary and effective proof, apparently the first, that $K_1(L_k(1, 2)) = 0$ over every field.

CONTENTS

1. Introduction

3

Date: August 2026.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 20F65, 20E26, 20F05, 05C48, 16S88, 19B99.

Key words and phrases. sofic groups, property (T) , expander graphs, Leavitt algebras, Thompson’s group, elementary groups.

Main results	3
Strategy	4
External inputs, and how to verify this paper	6
Organization	7
2. Sofic approximations, expanders, and LEF groups	8
2.1. Sofic approximations	8
2.2. Generator graphs and edit distance	9
2.3. Expansion and an ℓ^1 co-area estimate	10
2.4. LEF groups	10
2.5. The theorems of Kun and Kun–Thom	11
3. Conservative component matching: the toolkit	12
3.1. Expander refinement	13
3.2. Permutation conservation	13
3.3. Median pinning	13
3.4. Weighted selection	14
3.5. Localization by completion	15
4. The compression–centralizer criterion	15
4.1. Statement	16
4.2. The two component partitions	16
4.3. One-sided refinement along a compressor	17
4.4. Median normalization and conservation	18
4.5. Almost-bijective matching	20
4.6. Selection, localization, and the proof of Theorem 4.1	21
4.7. Two remarks on the mechanism	24
5. Leavitt algebras, elementary groups, and Thompson’s group V	24
5.1. Leaf sets and matrix self-similarity	25
5.2. Elementary groups over rings	26
5.3. Characteristic-two block factorizations	28
5.4. Thompson’s group V in a Leavitt corner	29
6. The compression scheme in adjacent ranks	32
6.1. The comb compressor	32
6.2. The involution z and generation	33
6.3. The commuting corner witness	34
6.4. The Leavitt-corner theorem	36
7. The explicit realization: no K -theory	37
8. Rank two and the full panorama	39
8.1. The two-by-two realization	39
8.2. K_1 vanishes and $GL = EL$	41
8.3. Finite fields: all ranks and the unit group	43
9. Finitely presented nonsofic covers	43
10. Concluding remarks	45
Appendix A. An elementary and effective proof of $K_1(L_k(1, 2)) = 0$	47
A.1. The Whitehead class group	47
A.2. Code moves	49
A.3. The degree filtration and width reduction	50

A.4. Windows die	51
A.5. The pencil and the elimination loop	53
A.6. Consequences and effectivity	56
References	57

1. INTRODUCTION

A countable discrete group is *sofic* if every finite portion of its multiplication table admits arbitrarily accurate and asymptotically faithful models by permutations of finite sets. The notion arose in Gromov’s work on symbolic dynamics [10]; Weiss introduced the term and asked whether every countable group is sofic [21]. The class contains all amenable and all residually finite groups, and it is stable under a long list of standard constructions; see [7, 18]. Whether every group is sofic has remained a central open problem of modern group theory; for a recent account of its status, see [8].

We answer the question in the negative. Two consequences follow at once: not every finitely presented group is sofic (Theorem C), and none of the classes of sofic, LEF, or residually finite groups is closed under quotients (Remark 10.6).

Main results. Let k be a field and let

$$(1) \quad L = L_k(1, 2) = k\langle s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 \mid t_i s_j = \delta_{ij}, s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1 = 1 \rangle$$

be the binary Leavitt algebra [15]. For a unital ring A and $r \geq 2$, write

$$x_{ij}(a) = I_r + aE_{ij} \in \mathrm{GL}_r(A), \quad a \in A, \quad i \neq j,$$

and let $\mathrm{EL}_r(A) \leq \mathrm{GL}_r(A)$ be the subgroup generated by these elementary matrices.

Theorem A. *Let $R = L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$. For every $m \geq 1$, the group*

$$\mathrm{EL}_{m+1}(R)$$

is infinite, finitely generated, has property (T), and is not sofic. In particular $G = \mathrm{EL}_4(R)$ is not sofic, and not every countable discrete group is sofic.

The proof of Theorem A is engineered for audit. The two auxiliary matrices of the construction are exhibited as explicit products of elementary matrices; every remaining elementary membership follows from one explicit Whitehead identity together with explicit commutator certificates—every cylinder transposition is a single commutator of units; the ranks below four are reached by an explicit isomorphism between the elementary groups of any two ranks ≥ 2 over R (Proposition 5.8); and no K -theory is used.

Theorem B. *Let k be a finite field and let $L = L_k(1, 2)$.*

- (i) *The unit group $L^\times$ is infinite, finitely generated, has property (T), and is not sofic.*

Endpoint/MainResults
universalLeavittEL4_not_
isSofic
universalLeavitt_profile
ambient_profile
ambient_full_profile
Countability of the witness,
which the final clause needs,
is the first conjunct of
ambient_full_profile.
Endpoint/MainResults
binaryLeavitt_finiteField_
profile
binaryLeavittUnits_not_
isSofic
binaryLeavittGL_not_isSofic
Leavitt/UnitsGLProfile
binaryLeavittUnits_profile
binaryLeavittGL_profile
 Θ_C is prefixRingEquiv in
Leavitt/PrefixCode, cited
with the panorama in
Section 8.

- (ii) For every $r \geq 1$, every ordered complete binary leaf set $\mathcal{C} = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_r)$ induces an explicit group isomorphism

$$(2) \quad \Theta_{\mathcal{C}} : \mathrm{GL}_r(L) \xrightarrow{\cong} L^\times, \quad (a_{ij}) \mapsto \sum_{i,j=1}^r \alpha_i a_{ij} \alpha_j^*.$$

For $r \geq 2$ one has $\mathrm{GL}_r(L) = \mathrm{EL}_r(L)$. Hence all the groups $\mathrm{GL}_r(L)$, $r \geq 1$, and $\mathrm{EL}_r(L)$, $r \geq 2$, are mutually isomorphic, and each is an infinite finitely generated property (T) nonsofic group.

Theorem C. Every finitely generated nonsofic group is a quotient of an infinite finitely presented nonsofic group. Every nonsofic group with property (T) is a quotient of an infinite finitely presented nonsofic group with property (T). In particular, there is an infinite finitely presented property (T) group H that is not sofic; H may be chosen to surject onto $L^\times$, and hence to have a quotient isomorphic to every group listed in Theorem B.

Strategy. The proof has three independent layers.

The first layer is analytic.

Theorem D (Kazhdan compression–centralizer criterion). Let G be a finitely generated property-(T) group, and let $\Gamma \leq G$ be an infinite finitely generated property-(T) subgroup. Suppose there is a finite set $Q \subseteq G$ with

$$G = \langle \Gamma, Q \rangle \quad \text{and} \quad q\Gamma q^{-1} \leq \Gamma \quad (q \in Q).$$

Fix $q_0 \in Q$, put $K = q_0\Gamma q_0^{-1}$, and let $J \leq \Gamma$ be finitely generated with

$$[K, J] = 1, \quad K \cap J = \{1\}.$$

If G is sofic, then J is LEF.

The point of departure is the tension between the two theorems that govern sofic approximations of Kazhdan groups. Kun’s theorem [13] proves Bowen’s conjecture: every sofic approximation of an infinite property-(T) group is essentially a vertex-disjoint union of uniformly expanding components. The Kun–Thom theorem [14] requires more: if the restriction of a sofic approximation of $\Lambda \times \Delta$ to a Kazhdan factor Λ is essentially *one* expander, then Δ is locally embeddable into finite groups (LEF). A disjoint union of equal-sized expanders is not enough, because the commuting factor may permute the components—this is exactly what happens in a product approximation.

Compression closes the gap. A hypothetical sofic approximation of G yields a Kun decomposition for Γ and another for G . Transporting the Γ -components by a compressor q gives one-sided inclusions into other Γ -components. Write $s(y)$ for the size of the Γ -component containing y ; on each ambient G -component, normalize by a vertex-weighted median m of the sizes and set

$$(3) \quad f(y) = \frac{s(y)}{s(y) + m}.$$

Endpoint/MainResults
exists_finitelyPresented_
nonsofic_group
exists_infinite_
finitelyPresented_nonsofic_
ambient_cover
Covers/KazhdanCover
exists_kazhdan_
finitelyPresented_cover_of_
not_isSofic
Criterion/CriterionAssembly
isLEF_of_isSofic
not_isSofic_of_not_isLEF

The one-sided inclusions make f almost monotone along compressor arcs. But a compressor acts by a permutation, so total increase equals total decrease *exactly*. The resulting small ℓ^1 edge variation, fed into an elementary co-area inequality on the ambient expanders, pins f at its median value $1/2$. Hence transported and target components have asymptotically equal sizes, and one-sided containment becomes almost-bijective matching. A weighted diagonal selection extracts a single matched component on which every multiplication, faithfulness, invariance, conjugacy, and graph-edit error is negligible. Restricting and completing the permutations yields a sofic approximation of $K \times J$ whose K -edges form an essential expander sequence, and the Kun–Thom obstruction forces J to be LEF. Theorem D is proved in Section 4 as a corollary of a local statement, Theorem 4.1, which isolates the exact graph-theoretic hypotheses and records precisely what property (T) is used for. Remarks 4.6 and 4.7 test the criterion against sofic examples and show that each hypothesis earns its place.

The second layer is algebraic, and it is where the Leavitt relations enter. Fix $m \geq 2$ and a nontrivial unital ring A carrying a binary Leavitt family—four elements satisfying the two Leavitt relations; no copy of L is assumed. A left-comb binary partition with $m+1$ leaves produces a compressor $u \in \mathrm{GL}_{m+1}(A)$ that conjugates the block subgroup $\Gamma \cong \mathrm{EL}_m(A)$ into the corner $a \mapsto s_0 a t_0$ of itself. A block involution z centralizes the compressed image K , so $v = zu$ is a second compressor with the same image, and $vu^{-1} = z$ generates every elementary matrix involving the last coordinate; whenever u and z lie in $\mathrm{EL}_{m+1}(A)$, it follows that $G = \mathrm{EL}_{m+1}(A) = \langle \Gamma, u, v \rangle$. The complementary corner $a \mapsto p_0 + s_1 a t_1$ carries a commuting copy of Thompson’s group V , and inside it the witness: the two-generator standard copy of Thompson’s F , which is not LEF for a finite reason—in a finite group the two F -relators force their two elements to commute, and the witness pair does not commute. The witness is elementary over every ambient ring: its two generators are products of explicitly exhibited commutators of units—every cylinder transposition is a single commutator—and the Whitehead lemma places diagonal products of commutators of units in EL_2 . The only membership hypotheses of the general theorem therefore concern u and z . Over $\mathbb{F}_2$ they are discharged by explicit four-term elementary factorizations, and an explicit rank equivalence between the elementary groups of any two ranks ≥ 2 —block flattening along the self-similarity of the Leavitt relations—then spreads the conclusion from rank four to every rank, which gives Theorem A with no K -theory. Over every finite field the memberships also follow from $K_1(L) = 0$ and the GE property of purely infinite simple rings; the K_1 input itself admits an elementary, effective proof, written out in full in Appendix A. Matrix self-similarity $M_r(L) \cong L$ then spreads nonsoficity and property (T) to the unit group and to all GL_r , and a separate two-by-two realization shows that the scheme already closes in rank two.

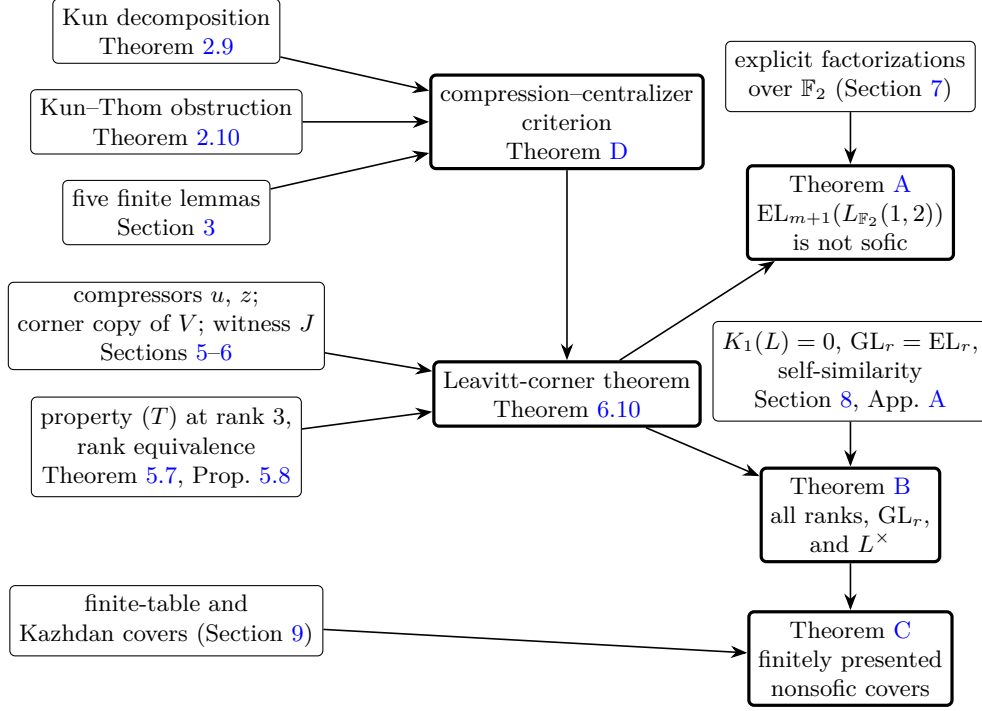


FIGURE 1. The architecture of the proof. The analytic layer (top left) produces the criterion; the algebraic layer (middle left) realizes its hypotheses over any ring carrying a binary Leavitt family; the memberships are discharged twice, explicitly in characteristic two and K -theoretically over every finite field; and the finite-table layer converts nonsoficity into finitely presented covers.

The third layer is a finite multiplication-table construction. Every finitely generated nonsofic group G has a finite table fragment that admits no sufficiently accurate permutation model. Imposing precisely that finite table as relators gives a finitely presented group mapping onto G ; the map proves infinitude and preserves distinctness of the named elements, while the forbidden finite table proves nonsoficity directly. When G is Kazhdan, Shalom’s finite-presentation theorem first supplies a finitely presented Kazhdan cover, and imposing the same table inside its kernel produces a finitely presented Kazhdan nonsofic cover. The covers are proved nonsofic directly, from the forbidden table itself; quotient closure of soficity—which in fact fails outright once nonsofic groups exist (Remark 10.6)—plays no role.

Figure 1 charts how the three layers assemble.

External inputs, and how to verify this paper. The proof is organized so that its trust surface is explicit and a skeptical reader can audit it efficiently.

Theorems A and D rest on the following external inputs: Kun’s expander decomposition theorem [13], cited in one-way form and with two proof repairs recorded in Remark 2.11; the Kun–Thom centralizer obstruction [14], with the repair recorded there as well; property (T) at rank three [9], stated and used in the finite-field case; and, for context only, the classical facts about Thompson’s group V [11, 6, 5]—the main line replaces them by the two-relator obstruction of Lemma 5.12 and the explicit commutator certificates of Lemma 6.6. Everything else is self-contained. In the proof of Theorem A, the two auxiliary matrices u and z are factored explicitly into elementary matrices, and every remaining elementary membership follows from the explicit Whitehead identity of Lemma 5.5 together with the commutator certificates of Lemma 6.6. The analytic sections use no spectral theory: the only analytic inequality proved and used in the matching argument is the ℓ^1 co-area estimate of Lemma 2.7, established in a few lines from the layer-cake formula, while the approximation-theoretic depth is confined to the cited theorems of Kun and Kun–Thom.

Theorem B additionally needs $K_1(L) = 0$, the collapse $\mathrm{GL}_r = \mathrm{EL}_r$, and the perfectness of $L^\times$, classically consequences of [1, 3, 2]. None remains a dependency: Appendix A proves all three elementarily and effectively— K_1 by the two-exit elimination, the collapse at every rank, and perfectness through the three-leaf self-similarity—so the K -theoretic citations are retained purely as independent confirmation.

Theorem C is self-contained apart from Shalom’s finitely presented Kazhdan covers [19], used only for the Kazhdan refinement.

A reader who wants to check the headline claim should verify, in order: the five finite lemmas of Section 3, each elementary and a few lines long; the proof of Theorem 4.1 in Section 4, which assembles them and invokes Kun’s theorem twice and the Kun–Thom theorem once, in exactly the forms stated in Section 2.5; the matrix identities of Sections 5 and 6, each a finite computation from the two Leavitt relations; and the two explicit factorizations of Section 7. That path proves Theorem A in full. Sections 8 and 9 lie downstream and can be audited separately.

Organization. Section 2 fixes the sofic, expander, and LEF vocabulary and states the theorems of Kun and Kun–Thom in the forms used. Section 3 isolates the five elementary lemmas of the matching mechanism. Section 4 proves the local compression–centralizer theorem and deduces Theorem D. Section 5 develops Leavitt leaf calculus, matrix self-similarity, the elementary rank equivalence, the Whitehead lemma, the characteristic-two block factorizations, and the corner realization of V . Section 6 presents the compression scheme in adjacent ranks over an arbitrary ring carrying a binary Leavitt family and proves the Leavitt-corner theorem. Section 7 discharges all memberships explicitly over $\mathbb{F}_2$ and proves Theorem A. Section 8 proves the

two-by-two theorem, the equality $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$, and Theorem B. Section 9 proves Theorem C. Section 10 collects concluding remarks. Appendix A proves $K_1(L_k(1, 2)) = 0$ elementarily and effectively.

2. SOFIC APPROXIMATIONS, EXPANDERS, AND LEF GROUPS

2.1. Sofic approximations. For $\sigma, \tau \in \text{Sym}(Y)$, let

$$d_H(\sigma, \tau) = \frac{1}{|Y|} |\{y \in Y \mid \sigma(y) \neq \tau(y)\}|$$

denote the normalized Hamming distance.

Definition 2.1. Let G be a countable discrete group. A *sofic approximation* of G is a sequence of maps $\sigma_n : G \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$, with $|Y_n| \rightarrow \infty$, such that

- (a) $d_H(\sigma_n(g)\sigma_n(h), \sigma_n(gh)) \rightarrow 0$ for all $g, h \in G$;
- (b) $d_H(\sigma_n(g), \text{id}) \rightarrow 1$ for all $g \in G \setminus \{1\}$.

The group G is *sofic* if it admits a sofic approximation.

The maps σ_n are not assumed to be homomorphisms. Property (b) self-improves: for a sofic group one may always pass to a sofic approximation in which each $\sigma_n(g)$, $g \neq 1$, moves *every* point of a set of density $1 - o(1)$, and it is standard that (a) and (b) force $d_H(\sigma_n(1), \text{id}) \rightarrow 0$. We will use the following exact normalization.

Lemma 2.2 (Finite normalization). *Let $\sigma_n : G \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ be a sofic approximation and let $F \subseteq G$ be a finite symmetric set. Then there is a sofic approximation $\sigma'_n : G \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ with $d_H(\sigma_n, \sigma'_n) \rightarrow 0$ pointwise, such that for all n :*

$$\sigma'_n(1) = \text{id}, \quad \sigma'_n(g^{-1}) = \sigma'_n(g)^{-1} \quad (g \in F).$$

Proof. Set $\sigma'_n(1) = \text{id}$, and note that $d_H(\sigma_n(1), \text{id}) \rightarrow 0$: applying (a) with $g = h = 1$ gives $d_H(\sigma_n(1)^2, \sigma_n(1)) \rightarrow 0$, and composing with the permutation $\sigma_n(1)^{-1}$ preserves d_H .

Choose one representative from each pair $\{g, g^{-1}\} \subseteq F \setminus \{1\}$ with $g \neq g^{-1}$; put $\sigma'_n(g) = \sigma_n(g)$ and $\sigma'_n(g^{-1}) = \sigma_n(g)^{-1}$. Then $d_H(\sigma_n(g^{-1}), \sigma_n(g)^{-1}) \rightarrow 0$, because $\sigma_n(g^{-1})\sigma_n(g)$ is d_H -close to $\sigma_n(1)$, hence to id , and d_H is invariant under composition with the permutation $\sigma_n(g)^{-1}$ on the right.

If $g = g^{-1} \in F \setminus \{1\}$ is an involution, let $A_n = \{y \mid \sigma_n(g)^2 y = y\}$. Since $\sigma_n(g)^2$ is d_H -close to $\sigma_n(g^2) = \sigma_n(1)$, hence to id , we have $|Y_n \setminus A_n| = o(|Y_n|)$. The set A_n is $\sigma_n(g)$ -invariant—if $\sigma_n(g)^2 y = y$, then applying $\sigma_n(g)$ gives $\sigma_n(g)^2(\sigma_n(g)y) = \sigma_n(g)y$ —and $\sigma_n(g)$ restricts to an involution of A_n . Define $\sigma'_n(g)$ to be $\sigma_n(g)$ on A_n and the identity on $Y_n \setminus A_n$; this is an involution of Y_n differing from $\sigma_n(g)$ on $o(|Y_n|)$ points.

Outside $F \cup \{1\}$ put $\sigma'_n = \sigma_n$. Each $\sigma'_n(g)$ differs from $\sigma_n(g)$ on $o(|Y_n|)$ points, so properties (a) and (b) persist. $\square$

The next lemma is the bridge, used many times below, between statements about products of letter permutations and statements about the permutation of the product.

Sofic/Sofic
SoficApproximation
IsSofic

Sofic/Normalization
normalize
normalize_map_one
normalize_map_inv
normalize_close
exists_normalization
perturb
involutionNormalize
halfOrbit
Sofic/Sofic
map_one_close
Matching/InverseNormalizati
on
inverseError_negligible
 σ' is normalize, on the same
finite models: perturb keeps a
Hamming-close reassignment
sofic, involutionNormalize
makes each tested involution
exact, and halfOrbit chooses
the representatives. The
sequel consumes the two
error bounds directly.

Lemma 2.3 (Word approximation). *Let $\sigma_n : G \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ be a sofic approximation, let $g \in G$, and let $g = t_1 t_2 \cdots t_\ell$ be any fixed factorization with $t_1, \dots, t_\ell \in G$. Then*

$$|\{y \in Y_n \mid \sigma_n(t_1)\sigma_n(t_2) \cdots \sigma_n(t_\ell)y \neq \sigma_n(g)y\}| = o(|Y_n|).$$

Proof. Induction on ℓ , the case $\ell = 1$ being trivial. For $\ell \geq 2$ put $h = t_2 \cdots t_\ell$. Composing with the permutation $\sigma_n(t_1)$ on the left does not change disagreement sets, so $\sigma_n(t_1) \cdots \sigma_n(t_\ell)$ agrees with $\sigma_n(t_1)\sigma_n(h)$ outside the $o(|Y_n|)$ points supplied by the inductive hypothesis; and $\sigma_n(t_1)\sigma_n(h)$ agrees with $\sigma_n(t_1 h) = \sigma_n(g)$ outside $o(|Y_n|)$ points by Definition 2.1(a). The union of the two sets has size $o(|Y_n|)$. $\square$

Whenever an element of a subgroup is written below as a word in a generating set and a property is verified letter by letter, Lemma 2.3 is what transfers the conclusion from the product of the letter permutations to the permutation of the element itself; it is cited explicitly at each such point.

2.2. Generator graphs and edit distance. Let $T \subseteq G$ be a finite set and $\sigma : G \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y)$ a map. The T -generator graph $X(Y, \sigma, T)$ is the multigraph on the vertex set Y with one edge $\{y, \sigma(t)y\}$ for each pair $(y, t) \in Y \times T$ with $\sigma(t)y \neq y$; parallel edges are retained, fixed points contribute no edge, and every vertex has degree at most $2|T|$. An *arc* of $t \in T$ is an ordered pair $(y, \sigma(t)y)$.

Conventions. All graphs in this paper are finite multigraphs without loops, and all edge counts—degrees, boundaries, edit distances, and sums over $E(X)$ —count edges with multiplicity. For multigraphs X, X' on the same vertex set Y , the *edit distance* $\text{ed}(X, X')$ is the minimal number of edge insertions and deletions, with multiplicity, transforming X into X' . A sequence of graphs X_n on Y_n is *edit-equivalent* to a sequence X'_n if $\text{ed}(X_n, X'_n) = o(|Y_n|)$.

For a finite multigraph X and $\emptyset \neq U \subseteq V(X)$, write ∂U for the multiset of edges with exactly one endpoint in U , and

$$h(X) = \min \left\{ \frac{|\partial U|}{|U|} \mid \emptyset \neq U \subseteq V(X), |U| \leq \frac{1}{2}|V(X)| \right\}$$

for the Cheeger constant; for a one-vertex graph the minimum runs over the empty set, and we set $h(X) = +\infty$. A sequence of bounded-degree graphs X_n with $|V(X_n)| \rightarrow \infty$ is an *expander sequence* if $\inf_n h(X_n) > 0$.

Remark 2.4 (Robustness of the conventions). The conventions are robust in exactly the two directions in which they interface with the cited external theorems. Loops are immaterial: a loop lies in no boundary ∂U , so inserting or deleting loops changes no Cheeger constant, no component, and no estimate below; arcs with $\sigma(t)y = y$ are accordingly discarded once and for all in the definition above. Multiplicities are controlled by a uniform bound: in a T -generator graph every unordered pair carries at most $2|T|$ parallel edges, one per arc. For multigraphs of multiplicity at most M : forgetting multiplicities preserves components and connectivity; boundary sizes change by a factor

between 1 and M , so a componentwise Cheeger bound h in one convention yields at least h/M in the other; and one simple-graph edit lifts to at most M multigraph edits, so $o(|Y_n|)$ edit-distance statements transfer in both directions. We do not assert any comparison for arbitrary multigraphs—two multigraphs can share an underlying simple graph and differ by linearly many parallel copies; the transfer above uses the multiplicity bound, which holds for every graph in this paper. Consequently every statement below, and each of the two external theorems of Section 2.5, may be read in either convention with constants adjusted; we fix the multiplicity-counting convention throughout.

Criterion/Criterion

ExpanderDecomposition

The Lean structure is

stronger than the printed

definition: it also records the

block structure, an edge-edit

witness, and the almost

invariance (6), supplied by

Theorem 2.9 and consumed

in Section 4.

Criterion/Criterion

IsEssentialExpanderSequence

MatchingCertificate

isEssentialExpanderSequence

Matching/EssentialExpander

Repair

induced_expands_eventually

repairedActualGraph_expands_

eventually

The matching certificate is

proved to exhibit one, and

the repair supplies its

expander sequence.

Matching/FiniteGraph

coarea

coarea_mul

Matching/DirectedCoarea

nonnegative_coarea

The Lean statement holds for

every finite multigraph: the

proof uses only the Cheeger

lower bound.

Definition 2.5. Let (X_n) be a sequence of graphs of uniformly bounded degree on vertex sets Y_n with $|Y_n| \rightarrow \infty$. An *expander decomposition* of (X_n) consists of graphs $\tilde{X}_n$ on Y_n , of uniformly bounded degree, with $\text{ed}(X_n, \tilde{X}_n) = o(|Y_n|)$, together with a constant $h > 0$ such that every connected component of every $\tilde{X}_n$ has Cheeger constant at least h .

Definition 2.6. A sequence of bounded-degree graphs (X_n) is an *essential expander sequence* if it is edit-equivalent to an expander sequence.

2.3. Expansion and an ℓ^1 co-area estimate. The single analytic inequality used in this paper is the following co-area estimate.

Lemma 2.7 (ℓ^1 co-area estimate). *Let X be a finite connected graph and $f : V(X) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Let $c \in \mathbb{R}$ be such that*

$$|\{x \mid f(x) > c\}| \leq \frac{1}{2}|V(X)| \quad \text{and} \quad |\{x \mid f(x) < c\}| \leq \frac{1}{2}|V(X)|.$$

Then

$$\sum_{x \in V(X)} |f(x) - c| \leq \frac{1}{h(X)} \sum_{\{x,y\} \in E(X)} |f(x) - f(y)|.$$

Proof. If X has a single vertex, the median hypotheses force $f \equiv c$ and both sides vanish (with $1/h(X) = 0$ by convention); assume $|V(X)| \geq 2$. Replacing f by $f - c$ we may assume $c = 0$. Write $f = f_+ - f_-$ with $f_{\pm} \geq 0$. For $t > 0$, the level set $U_t = \{x \mid f_+(x) > t\}$ satisfies $|U_t| \leq \frac{1}{2}|V(X)|$, so $|\partial U_t| \geq h(X)|U_t|$ whenever $U_t \neq \emptyset$. By the layer-cake formula,

$$\sum_x f_+(x) = \int_0^\infty |U_t| dt \leq \frac{1}{h(X)} \int_0^\infty |\partial U_t| dt \leq \frac{1}{h(X)} \sum_{\{x,y\} \in E(X)} |f_+(x) - f_+(y)|,$$

since an edge $\{x, y\}$ lies in ∂U_t exactly for t in an interval of length $|f_+(x) - f_+(y)|$. The same bound holds for f_- , and $|f_+(x) - f_+(y)| + |f_-(x) - f_-(y)| \leq |f(x) - f(y)|$ pointwise on edges, because f_+ and f_- have disjoint supports. Adding the two estimates gives the claim. $\square$

2.4. LEF groups. A group J is *LEF* (locally embeddable into finite groups) [20] if for every finite subset $F \subseteq J$ there are a finite group P and a map $\varphi : F \rightarrow P$ that is injective and satisfies $\varphi(g)\varphi(h) = \varphi(gh)$ whenever $g, h, gh \in F$. Every LEF group is sofic; finite and residually finite groups are LEF.

Lemma 2.8. *A finitely presented LEF group is residually finite.*

Proof. Let $J = \langle T \mid W \rangle$ with T, W finite and T symmetric, and let $g \in J \setminus \{1\}$; fix a word w_g in T representing g . Let $F \subseteq J$ be the finite set consisting of 1, the elements of T , all partial products $t_1 \cdots t_i$ of every relator $t_1 \cdots t_\ell \in W$, and all partial products of w_g ; in particular $g \in F$. Let $\varphi : F \rightarrow P$ be a local embedding into a finite group. First, $\varphi(1)\varphi(1) = \varphi(1)$ gives $\varphi(1) = 1_P$. Next, the assignment $t \mapsto \varphi(t)$ kills every relator: its partial products $p_i = t_1 \cdots t_i$ lie in F along with the letters, so $\varphi(p_{i+1}) = \varphi(p_i)\varphi(t_{i+1})$ by multiplicativity, and induction gives $\varphi(t_1) \cdots \varphi(t_\ell) = \varphi(p_\ell) = \varphi(1) = 1_P$. Hence $t \mapsto \varphi(t)$ extends to a homomorphism $\psi : J \rightarrow P$. The same induction along the partial products of w_g , all of which lie in F , gives $\psi(g) = \varphi(g)$, and $\varphi(g) \neq \varphi(1) = 1_P$ by injectivity of φ . Thus g survives in a finite quotient, and J is residually finite. $\square$

2.5. The theorems of Kun and Kun–Thom. We use two structure theorems for sofic approximations of Kazhdan groups.

Theorem 2.9 (Kun [13]). *Let Γ be an infinite finitely generated property-(T) group with a finite symmetric generating set S , and let $\sigma_n : \Gamma \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ be a sofic approximation. Then the S -generator graphs $X(Y_n, \sigma_n, S)$ admit an expander decomposition. Moreover, the modified graphs $\tilde{X}_n$ may be chosen of degree at most d , with the Cheeger constants of all components bounded below by a single constant $h > 0$; the constants d and h depend only on (Γ, S) .*

Kun’s theorem proves Bowen’s conjecture: sofic approximations of infinite Kazhdan groups are essentially disjoint unions of expanders. Theorem 2.9 is deliberately a *one-way* statement: the four-way equivalence of [13, Theorem 3] contains a spectral implication that fails as written and is not imported anywhere in this paper; Remark 2.11 records this precisely, together with two local repairs to the published proofs of the theorems of this subsection. The companion result of Kun and Thom is an obstruction for centralizers.

Theorem 2.10 (Kun–Thom [14]). *Let Λ be an infinite finitely generated property-(T) group with finite symmetric generating set S_Λ , and let Δ be a finitely generated group. Suppose $\Lambda \times \Delta$ admits a sofic approximation $\pi_n : \Lambda \times \Delta \rightarrow \text{Sym}(D_n)$ such that the S_Λ -generator graphs $X(D_n, \pi_n|_\Lambda, S_\Lambda)$ form an essential expander sequence. Then Δ is LEF.*

Theorem 2.10 states the theorem of [14] in its *essential* form, which is exactly how it is invoked in Section 4. The statement in [14] assumes that the Λ -graphs form a genuine expander sequence; the essential form is nonetheless the published theorem’s: the published proof opens under the weaker hypothesis that the sequence is essentially expanding and is carried out under that hypothesis throughout. The heuristic content: a genuine expander is essentially connected, so the commuting factor Δ cannot shuffle components and is forced to act almost by automorphisms of finite structures, which yields LEF approximations.

Sofic/FinitelyPresentedLEF
finitelyPresented_isLEF_
residuallyFinite
For any generator set and
finitely many relators, with
an explicit finite
symmetric-group quotient.

Kun/KunDecomposition
exists_expanderDecomposition
Kun/KunFixedDecomposition
expanderDecomposition
Proved internally, in the
full-sequence one-way form
used here. The Lean
statement normalizes the
generating set to contain 1
and holds for every Γ , finite
or not.

KunThom/KunThomTheore
m
isLEF_of_
exactProductExpansion
KunThom/KunThomEssentia
l
isLEF_of_matchingCertificate
Proved internally, with the
matching-core repair; the
generating set is normalized
to contain 1, as in
Theorem 2.9.

Interface. The proof in [14] is carried out for *regularly labeled* graphs: each generator label has exactly one outgoing directed edge at every vertex. An approximation normalized as in Lemma 2.2 supplies this structure. Every generator acts by a genuine permutation, and an inverse pair of generators acts by an inverse pair of permutations, so the two directed arcs of a pair combine into one undirected labeled edge; identity loops are discarded by the conventions of Section 2.2. Distinct labels rarely collide: for generators g, h with $h \neq g^{\pm 1}$, a collision $\sigma_n(g)y = \sigma_n(h)y$ makes y a preimage under the permutation $\sigma_n(h)$ of a fixed point of $\sigma_n(h)^{-1}\sigma_n(g)$, which agrees with $\sigma_n(h^{-1}g)$ outside a vanishing fraction of points by approximate multiplicativity and has a vanishing fraction of fixed points by asymptotic faithfulness. These properties are verified for the localized approximation at the end of the proof of Theorem 4.1.

Remark 2.11 (Audit of the two cited proofs). Because the two theorems above carry the entire approximation-theoretic weight of this paper, their published proofs were audited line by line, with three findings; we record them here both to delimit exactly what is imported and to credit the arguments of [13, 14], which survive intact.

First, Theorem 3 of [13] is stated as a four-way equivalence, and its spectral implication (4) $\Rightarrow$ (1) fails as written: it invokes the Cheeger–Alon–Milman bound, which separates the nonconstant Markov spectrum from $+1$ but not from -1 , and near-bipartite uniform expanders (a two-edge switch in each graph of a bipartite expander family, repeated) satisfy (2)–(4) while violating (1). This does not affect the present paper, nor Theorem 1 of [13]: the decomposition theorem needs only the forward implications, and Theorem 2.9 above is exactly that one-way statement—the only form used here.

Second, the proof of the forward direction in [13] normalizes a Markov defect (Lemma 10) without first excluding the degenerate case in which that defect vanishes; the repair separates the zero-defect case, where the displacement estimate holds for homogeneous reasons, before dividing.

Third, the centralizer argument of [14] constructs a correspondence between finite models and later treats it as the graph of a permutation, which it need not yet be; the repair measures the row and column fibers of the correspondence, extracts its injective matching core, and completes that core to a genuine permutation, after which the argument proceeds as published.

Both repairs are local to the proofs; a reader auditing this paper by hand should read [13, 14] with the three points above in mind.

3. CONSERVATIVE COMPONENT MATCHING: THE TOOLKIT

This section isolates five elementary lemmas about finite graphs, permutations, and sequences. They are stated once, in the exact quantitative forms used in Section 4; the only genuinely group-theoretic input of the paper appears there.

Kun/KunSpectralCounterexample
mple
switched
rayleigh_testVector
not_isBipartite
The near-bipartite
counterexample to the
spectral implication,
formalized.

3.1. Expander refinement.

Lemma 3.1 (Expander refinement). *Let X be a finite graph, every connected component of which has Cheeger constant at least $h > 0$. Let $V(X) = A_1 \sqcup \cdots \sqcup A_r$ be a partition, and let e be the number of edges of X whose endpoints lie in different parts. Then there is an assignment $C \mapsto i(C)$ of a part to each component of X , with $|C \cap A_{i(C)}|$ maximal, such that*

$$\sum_C |C \setminus A_{i(C)}| \leq \frac{4e}{h}.$$

Proof. Every edge of X lies inside a component, so the crossing edges distribute among the components; let e_C be the number inside C , with $\sum_C e_C = e$. Fix a component C , let $a_1 \geq a_2 \geq \cdots \geq a_k$ be the sizes of its nonempty intersections with the parts, and let $A_{i(C)}$ realize a_1 . We claim

$$|C| - a_1 \leq \frac{4e_C}{h},$$

which proves the lemma upon summation. If C meets only one part, then $C \setminus A_{i(C)} = \emptyset$ and the claim is trivial; assume C meets at least two parts. If a subset $W \subseteq C$ is a union of part-intersections with $|W| \leq \frac{1}{2}|C|$, then every edge of $\partial_{X[C]}W$ joins different parts, so $e_C \geq |\partial_{X[C]}W| \geq h|W|$.

If $a_1 \geq \frac{1}{2}|C|$, apply this to $W = C \setminus A_{i(C)}$, a union of part-intersections of size $|C| - a_1 \leq \frac{1}{2}|C|$; this gives $|C| - a_1 \leq e_C/h$.

If $a_1 < \frac{1}{2}|C|$, accumulate part-intersections in any order until the running total first reaches at least $\frac{1}{4}|C|$; the resulting union W satisfies $\frac{1}{4}|C| \leq |W| < \frac{1}{4}|C| + a_1 < \frac{3}{4}|C|$, so $\min(|W|, |C \setminus W|) \geq \frac{1}{4}|C|$, and whichever of W , $C \setminus W$ has size at most $\frac{1}{2}|C|$ is again a union of part-intersections. Applying the boundary bound to it gives $e_C \geq \frac{h}{4}|C| \geq \frac{h}{4}(|C| - a_1)$. $\square$

3.2. Permutation conservation.

Lemma 3.2 (Permutation conservation). *Let Y be a finite set, $\pi \in \text{Sym}(Y)$, and $f : Y \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Then*

$$\sum_{y \in Y} (f(y) - f(\pi y))_+ = \sum_{y \in Y} (f(\pi y) - f(y))_+ = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{y \in Y} |f(\pi y) - f(y)|.$$

Proof. Both $\sum_y f(y)$ and $\sum_y f(\pi y)$ equal the same number, so $\sum_y (f(y) - f(\pi y)) = 0$; split into positive and negative parts. $\square$

This exact identity is what converts a one-sided (monotonicity) estimate along the arcs of a permutation into a two-sided ℓ^1 estimate.

3.3. Median pinning.

Lemma 3.3 (Median pinning). *Let Z be a finite graph in which every connected component B satisfies $h(Z[B]) \geq h > 0$. Let $f : V(Z) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, and*

Matching/Refinement
exists_dominant_cell
le_crossing_of_cell
Matching/ComponentRefinement
refineComponent
Stated per component:
exists_dominant_cell is the
assignment $C \mapsto i(C)$ with
its bound on one component,
and refineComponent applies
it componentwise, as
Section 4 consumes it.

Matching/PermutationConservation
permutation_conservation_full

Matching/Pinning
median_pinning
Matching/ComponentPinning
normalized_pinning_global

suppose that on every component at most half of the vertices satisfy $f > \frac{1}{2}$ and at most half satisfy $f < \frac{1}{2}$. Then

$$\sum_{x \in V(Z)} \left| f(x) - \frac{1}{2} \right| \leq \frac{1}{h} \sum_{\{x,y\} \in E(Z)} |f(x) - f(y)|.$$

Proof. Every edge of Z lies within a component. Apply Lemma 2.7 with $c = \frac{1}{2}$ on each component and sum. $\square$

3.4. Weighted selection.

Lemma 3.4 (Weighted selection). *For each n , let $\{D_{n,i}\}_{i \in I_n}$ be disjoint nonempty subsets of a finite set Y_n , $|Y_n| = N_n \rightarrow \infty$, with $\sum_{i \in I_n} |D_{n,i}| \geq (1 - o(1))N_n$. Suppose that for every fixed M ,*

$$\sum_{i: |D_{n,i}| \leq M} |D_{n,i}| = o(N_n).$$

Let, for each $r \in \mathbb{N}$, nonnegative error weights $E_{n,i}^{(r)}$ be given with

$$\sum_{i \in I_n} E_{n,i}^{(r)} = o(N_n) \quad \text{for every fixed } r.$$

Then there exist indices $i(n) \in I_n$, for all n in a cofinite set, such that $|D_{n,i(n)}| \rightarrow \infty$ and, for every fixed r ,

$$E_{n,i(n)}^{(r)} = o(|D_{n,i(n)}|).$$

Proof. Replacing $E_{n,i}^{(r)}$ by $\max_{r' \leq r} E_{n,i}^{(r')}$ —which only increases the weights, preserves the hypothesis for each fixed r because the maximum of finitely many families, each of total weight $o(N_n)$, has total weight at most their sum, and only strengthens the conclusion—we may and do assume that $E_{n,i}^{(r)}$ is nondecreasing in r .

For $k \in \mathbb{N}$, call an index $i \in I_n$ k -bad if $|D_{n,i}| \leq k$ or $E_{n,i}^{(k)} > \frac{1}{k}|D_{n,i}|$, and k -good otherwise; let

$$q_k(n) = \frac{1}{N_n} \sum_{i \text{ } k\text{-bad}} |D_{n,i}|.$$

For each fixed k ,

$$q_k(n) \leq \frac{1}{N_n} \left(\sum_{i: |D_{n,i}| \leq k} |D_{n,i}| + k \sum_{i \in I_n} E_{n,i}^{(k)} \right) \xrightarrow{n \rightarrow \infty} 0,$$

the second summand bounding the mass of the second kind of badness by Markov's inequality, and both summands being $o(N_n)$ by hypothesis. Moreover the set of k -bad indices is nondecreasing in k : $|D_{n,i}| \leq k$ implies $|D_{n,i}| \leq k+1$, and $E_{n,i}^{(k)} > \frac{1}{k}|D_{n,i}|$ implies $E_{n,i}^{(k+1)} \geq E_{n,i}^{(k)} > \frac{1}{k+1}|D_{n,i}|$, using monotonicity in r . Hence $q_k(n)$ is nondecreasing in k for each fixed n .

Now make one simultaneous choice. Since $q_k(n) \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$ for each fixed k , there are integers $n_1 < n_2 < \dots$ with $q_k(n) \leq \frac{1}{k}$ for all $n \geq n_k$. For

Matching/Selection

exists_selection

exists_selection_diverging

diagonalLevel_diverges

diagonalLevel_error

exists_selection_diverging is

the form carrying the

divergence $|D_{n,i(n)}| \rightarrow \infty$;

exists_selection is the same

selection without it.

$n \geq n_1$ put $k_n = \max \{k \mid n_k \leq n\}$, a finite maximum since the n_k strictly increase; then $k_n \rightarrow \infty$ and, by the definition of n_{k_n} , $q_{k_n}(n) \leq \frac{1}{k_n} \rightarrow 0$.

For n large, the k_n -bad indices carry mass $q_{k_n}(n)N_n \leq N_n/k_n = o(N_n)$, while all indices together carry mass at least $(1 - o(1))N_n$; hence some k_n -good index $i(n)$ exists. Then $|D_{n,i(n)}| > k_n \rightarrow \infty$, and for every fixed r : as soon as $k_n \geq r$, monotonicity in r gives

$$E_{n,i(n)}^{(r)} \leq E_{n,i(n)}^{(k_n)} \leq \frac{1}{k_n} |D_{n,i(n)}| = o(|D_{n,i(n)}|). \quad \square$$

3.5. Localization by completion.

Lemma 3.5 (Localization by completion). *Let H be a countable group and $\sigma_n : H \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ maps. Suppose $D_n \subseteq Y_n$ are subsets with $|D_n| \rightarrow \infty$ such that, for every fixed $g, h \in H$:*

- (i) $|\{y \in D_n \mid \sigma_n(g)y \notin D_n\}| = o(|D_n|)$;
- (ii) $|\{y \in D_n \mid \sigma_n(g)\sigma_n(h)y \neq \sigma_n(gh)y\}| = o(|D_n|)$;
- (iii) $|\{y \in D_n \mid \sigma_n(g)y = y\}| = o(|D_n|)$ whenever $g \neq 1$.

For $g \in H$ define $\pi_n(g) \in \text{Sym}(D_n)$ by letting $\pi_n(g)$ agree with $\sigma_n(g)$ on $\{y \in D_n \mid \sigma_n(g)y \in D_n, \sigma_n(g)y \neq \sigma_n(g)y' \forall y' \neq y \in D_n\}$ and extending the resulting partial injection of D_n into itself to a permutation of D_n arbitrarily. Then $\pi_n : H \rightarrow \text{Sym}(D_n)$ is a sofic approximation of H . Moreover, if $g, g^{-1} \in H$ satisfy $\sigma_n(g^{-1}) = \sigma_n(g)^{-1}$, the completions may be chosen with $\pi_n(g^{-1}) = \pi_n(g)^{-1}$, and then

$$|\{y \in D_n \mid \pi_n(g)y \neq \sigma_n(g)y\}| = o(|D_n|).$$

Proof. Since $\sigma_n(g)$ is injective on Y_n , the described set consists precisely of the points of D_n sent into D_n by $\sigma_n(g)$, and its complement in D_n has size $o(|D_n|)$ by (i); the partial map is an injection, and any extension to a permutation of D_n differs from $\sigma_n(g)$ on $o(|D_n|)$ points of D_n . Then (ii) transfers: for fixed g, h , the points of D_n where $\pi_n(g)\pi_n(h)y \neq \pi_n(gh)y$ are contained in the union of the $o(|D_n|)$ -sized exceptional sets for g, h, gh (points where $\pi \neq \sigma$, including the $\sigma_n(h)$ -preimage of the exceptional set of g and the set in (ii); similarly (iii) transfers faithfulness. When $\sigma_n(g^{-1}) = \sigma_n(g)^{-1}$ and $g \neq g^{-1}$, the two partial injections attached to g and to g^{-1} are mutually inverse, so a completion of one can be transported to the other. When $g = g^{-1}$, so that $\sigma_n(g)^2 = \text{id}$, the set $A_{n,g} = \{y \in D_n \mid \sigma_n(g)y \in D_n\}$ is $\sigma_n(g)$ -invariant—if y and $\sigma_n(g)y$ both lie in D_n , then so do $\sigma_n(g)y$ and $\sigma_n(g)^2y = y$ —so $\sigma_n(g)$ restricts to an involution of $A_{n,g}$; extending by the identity on $D_n \setminus A_{n,g}$ yields an involutive completion $\pi_n(g) = \pi_n(g)^{-1}$ that differs from $\sigma_n(g)$ on $o(|D_n|)$ points of D_n by (i). $\square$

4. THE COMPRESSION-CENTRALIZER CRITERION

This section proves the analytic core of the paper. We first state a local version that isolates the exact graph-theoretic hypotheses; property (T) of the ambient group is a sufficient condition for the second hypothesis, and the local statement records precisely what it is used for.

Matching/Localization
exists_completion
involutiveCompletion
Criterion/LocalizedApproximation
toSoficApproximation

4.1. Statement.

Theorem 4.1 (Local compression–centralizer theorem). *Let G be a finitely generated group and let $\Gamma \leq G$ be an infinite finitely generated property-(T) subgroup with finite symmetric generating set S . Let $Q \subseteq G$ be a finite set with*

$$(4) \quad G = \langle \Gamma, Q \rangle \quad \text{and} \quad q\Gamma q^{-1} \leq \Gamma \quad (q \in Q).$$

Fix $q_0 \in Q$, put $K = q_0\Gamma q_0^{-1}$, and let $J \leq \Gamma$ be finitely generated with

$$(5) \quad [K, J] = 1, \quad K \cap J = \{1\}.$$

Put $A = S \cup Q \cup Q^{-1}$. Suppose G admits a sofic approximation $\sigma_n : G \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ such that

- (i) *the S -generator graphs $X(Y_n, \sigma_n, S)$ admit an expander decomposition, and*
- (ii) *the A -generator graphs $X(Y_n, \sigma_n, A)$ admit an expander decomposition.*

Then J is LEF.

Corollary 4.2 (Kazhdan compression–centralizer criterion; Theorem D). *In the setting of (4) and (5), suppose in addition that G and Γ have property (T). If G is sofic, then J is LEF. Equivalently: if J is not LEF, then G is not sofic.*

Proof. Suppose G is sofic and fix a sofic approximation σ_n . By (4) the finite symmetric set $A = S \cup Q \cup Q^{-1}$ generates G , and G is infinite, containing the infinite subgroup Γ . The restriction $\sigma_n|_{\Gamma}$ is a sofic approximation of the infinite Kazhdan group Γ , so Theorem 2.9 yields hypothesis (i); applying Theorem 2.9 to G itself with the generating set A yields hypothesis (ii). Theorem 4.1 concludes. $\square$

Remark 4.3. Only the componentwise ℓ^1 median inequality of Lemma 3.3 is extracted from hypothesis (ii); that hypothesis may accordingly be weakened to any decomposition of the A -generator graphs, up to $o(|Y_n|)$ edge edits, into components satisfying a uniform ℓ^1 Poincaré inequality around medians. This separates the approximation-theoretic input, which property (T) supplies through Kun’s theorem, from the compression mechanism, which is combinatorial.

The remainder of the section proves Theorem 4.1. Write $N_n = |Y_n|$. All $o(N_n)$ estimates are uniform over the fixed finite data (S, Q, q_0) and the decomposition constants; the set Q itself is never symmetrized inside the compression steps, since the compression hypothesis $q\Gamma q^{-1} \leq \Gamma$ is assumed only for $q \in Q$.

4.2. The two component partitions. Put $S_K = q_0 S q_0^{-1}$, a finite symmetric generating set of K , and fix a finite symmetric generating set S_J of the

Criterion/LocalCriterion
LocalCriterionData
Criterion/CriterionAssembly
isLEF_of_soficApproximation

Criterion/CriterionAssembly
isLEF_of_isSofic
not_isSofic_of_not_isLEF

finitely generated group J . By Lemma 2.2 we may and do assume the exact identities

$$\sigma_n(1) = \text{id}, \quad \sigma_n(g^{-1}) = \sigma_n(g)^{-1} \quad (g \in A \cup S_K \cup S_J),$$

after a pointwise $o(N_n)$ modification; each relevant generator graph changes by $o(N_n)$ edges, so hypotheses (i) and (ii) persist.

By hypothesis (i), fix an expander decomposition of the S -generator graphs: graphs $\tilde{X}_n$ on Y_n of degree at most d_Γ , with

$$\text{ed}(X(Y_n, \sigma_n, S), \tilde{X}_n) = o(N_n),$$

such that every component of $\tilde{X}_n$ has Cheeger constant at least $h_\Gamma > 0$. Let $\mathcal{P}_n$ denote the partition of Y_n into the components of $\tilde{X}_n$, and write $P_n(y)$ for the block containing y . We refer to the blocks of $\mathcal{P}_n$ as Γ -components.

By hypothesis (ii), fix likewise an expander decomposition $\tilde{Z}_n$ of the A -generator graphs, with all components of Cheeger constant at least $h_G > 0$ and uniformly bounded degree; let $\mathcal{B}_n$ be the partition of Y_n into the components of $\tilde{Z}_n$, with blocks $B_n(y)$, the G -components.

Both partitions are almost invariant in the following sense. For every $s \in S$,

$$(6) \quad |\{y \in Y_n \mid P_n(\sigma_n(s)y) \neq P_n(y)\}| = o(N_n),$$

because apart from the $o(N_n)$ edge edits, every arc $(y, \sigma_n(s)y)$ is an edge of $\tilde{X}_n$ or a loop, and edges of $\tilde{X}_n$ do not cross $\mathcal{P}_n$. For every $a \in A$,

$$(7) \quad |\{y \in Y_n \mid B_n(\sigma_n(a)y) \neq B_n(y)\}| = o(N_n),$$

for the same reason applied to $\tilde{Z}_n$.

Both partitions stay fixed from here on: $\mathcal{P}_n$ and $\mathcal{B}_n$ are the exact component partitions of $\tilde{X}_n$ and $\tilde{Z}_n$, and every block keeps its connectivity and its Cheeger constant. This is deliberate—the final step of the proof selects a block of $\mathcal{P}_n$ and uses precisely that it is a genuine component of $\tilde{X}_n$. The two partitions are related only pointwise, in two ways: through the almost-invariance estimates (6) and (7), and through the median normalization of Section 4.4, which compares a point with its compressor image exactly when the two lie in the same G -component; the $o(N_n)$ points where this fails are carried as explicit exceptional sets through every estimate below. In particular, neither partition is assumed to refine the other.

4.3. One-sided refinement along a compressor. Fix $q \in Q$. The group identity $qs = (qsq^{-1})q$ and approximate multiplicativity give, for each $s \in S$, the *conjugacy defect* bound

$$(8) \quad |\{y \in Y_n \mid \sigma_n(q)\sigma_n(s)y \neq \sigma_n(qsq^{-1})\sigma_n(q)y\}| = o(N_n).$$

Indeed, $\sigma_n(q)\sigma_n(s)$ agrees with $\sigma_n(qs)$ outside $o(N_n)$ points, and $\sigma_n(qs) = \sigma_n((qsq^{-1})q)$ agrees with $\sigma_n(qsq^{-1})\sigma_n(q)$ outside $o(N_n)$ points, both by

Definition 2.1(a); here qsq^{-1} belongs to the fixed finite set $qSq^{-1} \subseteq \Gamma$, by the compression hypothesis (4).

Transport the graphs $\tilde{X}_n$ by the permutation $\sigma_n(q)$: the transported graph $\sigma_n(q)\tilde{X}_n$ has vertex set Y_n and one edge $\{\sigma_n(q)x, \sigma_n(q)y\}$ for each edge $\{x, y\}$ of $\tilde{X}_n$, multiplicities preserved; its components are $\{\sigma_n(q)C \mid C \in \mathcal{P}_n\}$, with the same component Cheeger constants $\geq h_\Gamma$ and degree bound d_Γ . By (8) and the edit bounds, apart from $o(N_n)$ edge occurrences the edges of the transported graph are of the form $\{\sigma_n(q)y, \sigma_n(\gamma)\sigma_n(q)y\}$ with $\gamma \in qSq^{-1} \subseteq \Gamma$; for each of the finitely many $\gamma \in qSq^{-1} \subseteq \Gamma$, fix a word in S representing it; by Lemma 2.3, $\sigma_n(\gamma)$ agrees with the product of the letter permutations outside $o(N_n)$ points, and by (6) applied to each letter in turn, that product preserves the block $P_n(\cdot)$ outside $o(N_n)$ points. Hence all but $o(N_n)$ of the transported edges lie inside blocks of $\mathcal{P}_n$.

Apply Lemma 3.1 to the transported graph with the partition $\mathcal{P}_n$. This produces a map

$$\Phi_{q,n} : \mathcal{P}_n \rightarrow \mathcal{P}_n, \quad \Phi_{q,n}(C) = \text{the block meeting } \sigma_n(q)C \text{ in maximal size,}$$

with total leakage

$$(9) \quad \sum_{C \in \mathcal{P}_n} e_{q,n}(C) = o(N_n), \quad \text{where} \quad e_{q,n}(C) := |\sigma_n(q)C \setminus \Phi_{q,n}(C)|.$$

Thus each transported Γ -component is almost contained in a single target Γ -component. The containment is a priori one-sided: a large target could still absorb several small transported components. Ruling this out is the business of the median normalization.

4.4. Median normalization and conservation. For $y \in Y_n$, let $s_n(y) = |P_n(y)|$ be the size of its Γ -component. For a G -component $B \in \mathcal{B}_n$, let $m_n(B) \geq 1$ be a *vertex-weighted median* of s_n on B : a value such that

$$|\{y \in B \mid s_n(y) > m_n(B)\}| \leq \frac{1}{2}|B| \text{ and } |\{y \in B \mid s_n(y) < m_n(B)\}| \leq \frac{1}{2}|B|.$$

Define the *median normalization*

$$(10) \quad f_n(y) = \frac{s_n(y)}{s_n(y) + m_n(B_n(y))} \in (0, 1).$$

Since $t \mapsto t/(t+m)$ is strictly increasing, on every G -component B at most half the vertices satisfy $f_n > \frac{1}{2}$ and at most half satisfy $f_n < \frac{1}{2}$; that is, $\frac{1}{2}$ is a median of f_n on every component of $\tilde{Z}_n$.

Variation along S . For $s \in S$,

$$(11) \quad \sum_{y \in Y_n} |f_n(\sigma_n(s)y) - f_n(y)| = o(N_n),$$

since the summand vanishes unless $P_n(\sigma_n(s)y) \neq P_n(y)$ or $B_n(\sigma_n(s)y) \neq B_n(y)$, a set of size $o(N_n)$ by (6) and (7), and $0 < f_n < 1$.

One-sided variation along $q \in Q$. Call $y \in Y_n$ a *good point for q* if

$$(12) \quad \sigma_n(q)y \in \Phi_{q,n}(P_n(y)) \quad \text{and} \quad B_n(\sigma_n(q)y) = B_n(y).$$

Let y be good, $C = P_n(y)$, $D = \Phi_{q,n}(C)$, and $e = e_{q,n}(C)$; then

$$s_n(\sigma_n(q)y) = |D| \geq |\sigma_n(q)C \cap D| = |C| - e = s_n(y) - e.$$

Since both y and $\sigma_n(q)y$ lie in the same G -component B , they are normalized by the same median $m = m_n(B) \geq 1$. For $a \geq (1 - \delta)a' \geq 0$ and $m \geq 1$,

$$(13) \quad \frac{a'}{a' + m} - \frac{a}{a + m} \leq \frac{a'}{a' + m} - \frac{(1 - \delta)a'}{(1 - \delta)a' + m} \leq \delta,$$

where the first inequality is monotonicity of $t \mapsto t/(t + m)$ and the second is a direct computation: the difference equals $\delta a' m / ((a' + m)((1 - \delta)a' + m)) \leq \delta$. Applying (13) with $a' = |C|$, $a = |D| \geq |C| - e$, $\delta = e/|C|$ gives, for every good point y ,

$$(f_n(y) - f_n(\sigma_n(q)y))_+ \leq \frac{e_{q,n}(P_n(y))}{|P_n(y)|}.$$

Summing over Y_n —good points of a block C contribute at most $e_{q,n}(C)$ in total, points with $\sigma_n(q)y \notin \Phi_{q,n}(P_n(y))$ number $e_{q,n}(C)$ per block and contribute at most 1 each, and points whose arc crosses $\mathcal{B}_n$ contribute at most 1 each—we obtain

$$(14) \quad \begin{aligned} \sum_{y \in Y_n} (f_n(y) - f_n(\sigma_n(q)y))_+ &\leq 2 \sum_{C \in \mathcal{P}_n} e_{q,n}(C) + |\{y \mid B_n(\sigma_n(q)y) \neq B_n(y)\}| \\ &= o(N_n) \end{aligned}$$

by (9) and (7). The compressed image can only grow—but growth is globally impossible:

Conservation. Since $\sigma_n(q)$ is a permutation of Y_n , Lemma 3.2 upgrades (14) to the two-sided estimate

$$(15) \quad \sum_{y \in Y_n} |f_n(\sigma_n(q)y) - f_n(y)| = 2 \sum_{y \in Y_n} (f_n(y) - f_n(\sigma_n(q)y))_+ = o(N_n) \quad (q \in Q),$$

and the change of variables $y = \sigma_n(q)x$, legitimate because $\sigma_n(q^{-1}) = \sigma_n(q)^{-1}$, extends (15) to all $q \in Q \cup Q^{-1}$.

Pinning. Every edge of the A -generator graph $X(Y_n, \sigma_n, A)$ arises from an arc $(y, \sigma_n(a)y)$ with $a \in A = S \cup Q \cup Q^{-1}$, and each edge arises from at most $2|A|$ arcs. Hence (11) and (15) give

$$\sum_{\{x,y\} \in E(X(Y_n, \sigma_n, A))} |f_n(x) - f_n(y)| = o(N_n).$$

Since $0 < f_n < 1$, editing $o(N_n)$ edges changes this sum by at most $o(N_n)$; therefore the same bound holds over $E(\tilde{Z}_n)$. As $\frac{1}{2}$ is a median of f_n on every component of $\tilde{Z}_n$ and all component Cheeger constants are at least h_G , Lemma 3.3 yields the concentration estimate

$$(16) \quad \sum_{y \in Y_n} \left| f_n(y) - \frac{1}{2} \right| = o(N_n).$$

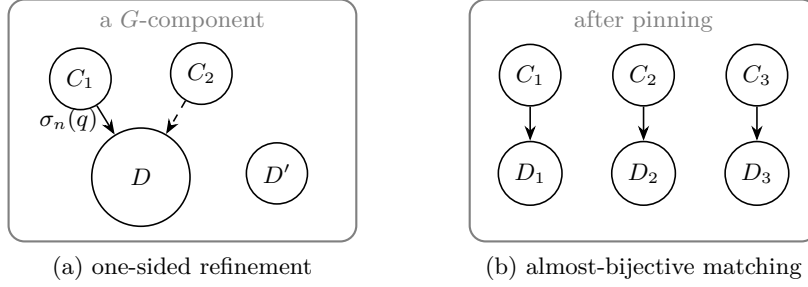


FIGURE 2. Conservative component matching. (a) Transporting a Γ -component by a compressor almost lands it inside a single target component, but a priori a large target could absorb several small sources (dashed). (b) Exact conservation and median pinning force transported and target sizes to agree asymptotically, so the assignment $\Phi_{q,n}$ becomes injective on almost all mass (Proposition 4.4).

In words: after median normalization, almost every Γ -component has size asymptotically equal to the median size on its G -component, because $s/(s+m) \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}$ exactly when $s/m \rightarrow 1$.

4.5. Almost-bijjective matching. The mechanism of this subsection is drawn in Figure 2.

Proposition 4.4 (Matching). *Fix $q \in Q$. There are subcollections $\mathcal{G}_{q,n} \subseteq \mathcal{P}_n$ such that:*

- (i) $\sum_{C \in \mathcal{P}_n \setminus \mathcal{G}_{q,n}} |C| = o(N_n)$;
 - (ii) for every $C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n}$, with $D = \Phi_{q,n}(C)$,
- $$(17) \quad |\sigma_n(q)C \triangle D| = o(1) \cdot |C| \quad \text{uniformly over } C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n};$$
- (iii) for n large, $\Phi_{q,n}$ is injective on $\mathcal{G}_{q,n}$;
 - (iv) $\sum_{C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n}} |\Phi_{q,n}(C)| = (1 - o(1)) N_n$.

Proof. Choose $\eta_n \downarrow 0$ so slowly that the three global errors—in (7) for the element q , in (9), and in (16)—are all $o(\eta_n^2 N_n)$. Let $W_n \subseteq Y_n$ be the union of the four sets

$$\begin{aligned} & \left\{ y \mid |f_n(y) - \tfrac{1}{2}| > \eta_n \right\}, \quad \sigma_n(q)^{-1} \left\{ y \mid |f_n(y) - \tfrac{1}{2}| > \eta_n \right\}, \\ & \{ y \mid B_n(\sigma_n(q)y) \neq B_n(y) \}, \quad \{ y \mid \sigma_n(q)y \notin \Phi_{q,n}(P_n(y)) \}. \end{aligned}$$

Markov's inequality applied to (16) bounds the first set by $\eta_n^{-1} \cdot o(\eta_n^2 N_n) = o(\eta_n N_n)$; the second is a bijective preimage of the first; the last two have sizes $o(\eta_n^2 N_n)$ by the choice of η_n . Hence $|W_n| = o(\eta_n N_n)$.

Discard from $\mathcal{P}_n$ every block C with $e_{q,n}(C) > \eta_n |C|$ or $|C \cap W_n| > \eta_n |C|$, and call the remaining collection $\mathcal{G}_{q,n}$. The discarded mass is at most $\eta_n^{-1} \sum_C e_{q,n}(C) + \eta_n^{-1} |W_n| = o(N_n)$, proving (i).

Matching/MedianNormalizati
on
medianNormalize
Matching/MatchingPreparati
on
acceptable_symmDiff_le
Criterion/Criterion
symmDiff_le_of_pinned
matching_injective
Stated per component:
acceptable_symmDiff_le is
(17) for a single acceptable
component, and
matching_injective is the
injectivity clause.

Let $C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n}$ and pick $y \in C \setminus W_n$, possible since $\eta_n < 1$. Put $D = \Phi_{q,n}(C)$ and $B = B_n(y) = B_n(\sigma_n(q)y)$, and write $m = m_n(B)$. Since $y \notin W_n$, we have $\sigma_n(q)y \in D$, so $s_n(\sigma_n(q)y) = |D|$, and

$$\left| \frac{|C|}{|C| + m} - \frac{1}{2} \right| \leq \eta_n, \quad \left| \frac{|D|}{|D| + m} - \frac{1}{2} \right| \leq \eta_n.$$

Solving $\left| \frac{a}{a+m} - \frac{1}{2} \right| \leq \eta$ gives $\frac{1-2\eta}{1+2\eta} m \leq a \leq \frac{1+2\eta}{1-2\eta} m$; applying this to $a = |C|$ and to $a = |D|$ and dividing,

$$(18) \quad |D| = (1 + O(\eta_n)) |C| \quad \text{uniformly over } C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n}.$$

With $e = e_{q,n}(C) \leq \eta_n |C|$,

$$\begin{aligned} |\sigma_n(q)C \triangle D| &= |\sigma_n(q)C \setminus D| + |D \setminus \sigma_n(q)C| \\ &\leq e + (|D| - |C| + e) \leq 2e + ||D| - |C|| = O(\eta_n)|C|, \end{aligned}$$

proving (ii).

For (iii): if $C \neq C'$ in $\mathcal{G}_{q,n}$ had $\Phi_{q,n}(C) = \Phi_{q,n}(C') = D$, the disjoint sets $\sigma_n(q)C \cap D$ and $\sigma_n(q)C' \cap D$ would, by (17) and (18), each occupy a fraction $1 - o(1)$ of D , uniformly—impossible for n large.

For (iv): by (i), (ii), and (18),

$$\sum_{C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n}} |\Phi_{q,n}(C)| = (1+o(1)) \sum_{C \in \mathcal{G}_{q,n}} |C| = (1+o(1))(1-o(1))N_n = (1-o(1))N_n.$$

□

Thus one-sided refinement, conservation, and pinning together force the compressor to permute the Γ -components almost bijectively, with asymptotically equal sizes. One more observation is needed before selecting a single matched pair.

Lemma 4.5. *For every fixed M , $\sum \{|C| : C \in \mathcal{P}_n, |C| \leq M\} = o(N_n)$.*

Matching/ComponentDivergence
smallBlockVertices_
negligible

Proof. Let $g_1, \dots, g_{M+1} \in \Gamma$ be distinct elements; they exist since Γ is infinite. For all but $o(N_n)$ points y the points $\sigma_n(g_1)y, \dots, \sigma_n(g_{M+1})y$ are pairwise distinct: for $i \neq j$, $\sigma_n(g_i)$ agrees with $\sigma_n(g_j)$ outside $o(N_n)$ points by Definition 2.1(a), and $\sigma_n(g_i g_j^{-1})$ moves $1 - o(1)$ of all points by Definition 2.1(b). Moreover, fixing a word in S representing each g_i , Lemma 2.3 together with (6) applied along its letters shows that for all but $o(N_n)$ points y all these points lie in $P_n(y)$. A point y satisfying both conditions has $|P_n(y)| \geq M + 1$; hence the mass of blocks of size at most M is $o(N_n)$. □

4.6. Selection, localization, and the proof of Theorem 4.1.

Proof of Theorem 4.1. Apply Proposition 4.4 with $q = q_0$. For n large this gives a collection of *matched pairs*

$$(19) \quad \{(C, D) : C \in \mathcal{G}_{q_0,n}, D = \Phi_{q_0,n}(C)\},$$

with pairwise distinct sources, pairwise distinct targets, target mass $(1 - o(1))N_n$, and $|\sigma_n(q_0)C \triangle D| = o(1)|C|$ uniformly.

Fix an exhaustion $L_1 \subseteq L_2 \subseteq \dots$ of the countable group $KJ \leq \Gamma$ by finite subsets with $\bigcup_r L_r = KJ$, each L_r containing 1, the finite sets S_K and S_J , and closed under inverses, and such that $L_r \cdot L_r \subseteq L_{r+1}$. To each matched pair (C, D) and each r attach the error weight $E^{(r)}(C, D)$, the sum of:

- (a) $|\sigma_n(q_0)C \triangle D|$;
- (b) the number of edges of $\tilde{X}_n$ with an endpoint in C or D that are edited relative to the S -generator graph, plus the number of edges of the transported graph $\sigma_n(q_0)\tilde{X}_n$ with an endpoint in $D \cup \sigma_n(q_0)C$ that are edited relative to the transported S -generator graph;
- (c) $|\{y \in C \mid \sigma_n(q_0)\sigma_n(s)y \neq \sigma_n(q_0sq_0^{-1})\sigma_n(q_0)y \text{ for some } s \in S\}|$;
- (d) $|\{y \in D \mid \sigma_n(g)\sigma_n(h)y \neq \sigma_n(gh)y \text{ for some } g, h \in L_r\}|$;
- (e) $|\{y \in D \mid \sigma_n(g)y = y \text{ for some } g \in L_r \setminus \{1\}\}|$;
- (f) $|\{y \in D \mid P_n(\sigma_n(g)y) \neq P_n(y) \text{ for some } g \in L_r\}|$.

For every fixed r , the sum of $E^{(r)}$ over the matched pairs is $o(N_n)$: (a) by Proposition 4.4(ii) and (i); (b): the sources are pairwise disjoint, the targets are pairwise disjoint, and a fixed block can occur at most once as a source and at most once as a target; hence each endpoint of an edge lies in at most one source and at most one target, and, an edge having two endpoints, each edited edge is counted for at most four matched pairs—likewise in the transported graph, where the sets $\sigma_n(q_0)C$ are pairwise disjoint images of the disjoint sources—while the global edit counts are $o(N_n)$; (c) by (8) over the finite set S , the sources being disjoint; (d) and (e) by soficity of σ_n over the finite set $L_r \cup L_r^2$, the targets being disjoint; (f) by Lemma 2.3 together with (6) applied along the letters of a fixed word in S representing each $g \in L_r \subseteq \Gamma$, the targets being disjoint.

The targets D are pairwise disjoint blocks of $\mathcal{P}_n$ with total mass $(1 - o(1))N_n$, and by Lemma 4.5 the total mass of targets of size at most M is $o(N_n)$ for every fixed M . Lemma 3.4 therefore produces matched pairs (C_n, D_n) with

$$(20) \quad |D_n| \rightarrow \infty, \quad E^{(r)}(C_n, D_n) = o(|D_n|) \quad \text{for every fixed } r.$$

Put $U_n = \sigma_n(q_0)C_n$, so $|U_n \triangle D_n| = o(|D_n|)$ and $|U_n| = |C_n| = (1 + o(1))|D_n|$. Define

$$(21) \quad D'_n = U_n,$$

a set of size $|C_n| \rightarrow \infty$ that agrees with D_n up to $o(|D_n|)$ points. Every error weight in (20) transfers from the pair (C_n, D_n) to D'_n at a cost of $o(|D'_n|)$, by separate accounting: the point-counted errors (d), (e), (f) are counted over D_n , and replacing D_n by D'_n changes each count by at most $|D_n \triangle D'_n| = o(|D'_n|)$; the error (c) is counted over C_n , which is unchanged; the edge-counted errors (b) concern graphs of degree at most $\max(d_\Gamma, 2|S|)$, so replacing D_n by D'_n in the incidence condition changes those counts by

at most that degree bound times $|D_n \triangle D'_n| = o(|D'_n|)$; and the quantity (a) does not change.

Localization. Consider the countable group $H = KJ \leq \Gamma$. By (5), K and J commute and intersect trivially, so

$$H = KJ \cong K \times J.$$

For every fixed $g \in H$, the transferred error (f) shows that $\sigma_n(g)$ maps all but $o(|D'_n|)$ points of D'_n into D_n . Injectivity upgrades D_n to D'_n : since $\sigma_n(g)$ is a permutation of Y_n , at most $|D_n \setminus D'_n| = o(|D'_n|)$ points of D'_n can land in $D_n \setminus D'_n$, so $\sigma_n(g)$ maps all but $o(|D'_n|)$ points of D'_n into D'_n itself. The transferred errors (d) and (e) give multiplicativity and faithfulness on D'_n for every fixed pair $g, h \in H$, by choosing r with $g, h \in L_r$. Lemma 3.5, with completions on the symmetric set $S_K \cup S_J$ chosen compatibly with the exact inverse identities of Section 4.2, yields a sofic approximation

$$\pi_n : K \times J \longrightarrow \text{Sym}(D'_n)$$

with $|\{y \in D'_n \mid \pi_n(g)y \neq \sigma_n(g)y\}| = o(|D'_n|)$ for every fixed g , and $\pi_n(g^{-1}) = \pi_n(g)^{-1}$ for $g \in S_K \cup S_J$.

The K -edges expand. Restrict $\tilde{X}_n$ to C_n and transport by $\sigma_n(q_0)$: the resulting graph Ξ_n on $D'_n = \sigma_n(q_0)C_n$ is connected with Cheeger constant at least h_Γ and degree at most d_Γ , because C_n is a component of $\tilde{X}_n$. We claim that Ξ_n and the S_K -generator graph $X(D'_n, \pi_n, S_K)$ differ by $o(|D'_n|)$ edges. Indeed, an edge of either graph that fails to be an edge of the other must involve one of the following, each affecting $o(|D'_n|)$ edge occurrences by (20):

- (1) an edge of $\tilde{X}_n[C_n]$ edited relative to the S -generator graph on C_n , or conversely (error (b));
- (2) an arc $(y, \sigma_n(s)y)$, $y \in C_n$, whose $\sigma_n(q_0)$ -transport disagrees with the $\sigma_n(q_0 s q_0^{-1})$ -arc at $\sigma_n(q_0)y$ (error (c));
- (3) a point of D'_n where $\pi_n(g) \neq \sigma_n(g)$ for some $g \in S_K$ (localization defect);
- (4) an arc of some $g \in S_K$ leaving D'_n (transferred error (f) and the symmetric difference (a)).

Hence the S_K -generator graphs of $\pi_n|_K$ form an essential expander sequence in the sense of Definition 2.6.

Conclusion. The group $K = q_0 \Gamma q_0^{-1} \cong \Gamma$ is an infinite finitely generated property-(T) group with symmetric generating set S_K , the group J is finitely generated, and π_n is a sofic approximation of $K \times J$ whose S_K -generator graphs form an essential expander sequence. The regular-labeling requirements recorded after Theorem 2.10 hold for π_n as well: each $\pi_n(g)$ is a genuine permutation of D'_n , with $\pi_n(g^{-1}) = \pi_n(g)^{-1}$ for $g \in S_K \cup S_J$; and for $g, h \in S_K \cup S_J$ with $h \neq g^{\pm 1}$, the collision set $\{y \in D'_n \mid \pi_n(g)y = \pi_n(h)y\}$ has size $o(|D'_n|)$, by the transferred errors (d) and (e) applied to the pair (h^{-1}, g) and the element $h^{-1}g \in L_2 \setminus \{1\}$, together with the $o(|D'_n|)$ agreement between π_n and σ_n on $S_K \cup S_J \cup \{h^{-1}g\}$. Theorem 2.10 applies and shows that J is LEF. $\square$

4.7. Two remarks on the mechanism.

Remark 4.6 (The product obstruction). The compression hypothesis cannot be deleted from Theorem D. For a direct product $\Lambda \times \Delta$ of an infinite Kazhdan group with a residually finite Kazhdan group, product sofic approximations exist whenever Λ is sofic, and in them the Δ -factor genuinely permutes the Λ -components: the Λ -component partition has all blocks of equal size, and no single component is almost invariant under the second factor. The role of the compressors $q \in Q$, through (4), is to generate the whole ambient group while conjugating Γ into itself, so that the ambient expansion of hypothesis (ii) couples the component structure of Γ to itself across all of G and forbids exactly this shuffling.

Remark 4.7 (The hypothesis $J \leq \Gamma$ is essential). The subgroup J is required to lie in Γ , and this is used twice: through (6) in error (f), which keeps the J -arcs inside the matched component, and through the localization step, which restricts σ_n on elements of $KJ \leq \Gamma$. The hypothesis cannot be dropped in favor of $J \leq G$. Indeed, groups satisfying all the remaining hypotheses with a non-LEF subgroup $J \leq G$ commuting with K exist in abundance among sofic groups—already $J = \text{BS}(2, 3) = \langle a, t \mid ta^2t^{-1} = a^3 \rangle$ is a finitely presented group that is known to be sofic and is non-Hopfian [4], therefore not residually finite, therefore not LEF by Lemma 2.8. The criterion is calibrated exactly so that the commuting subgroup rides inside the compressed expander, and this is what the Leavitt corner construction of Sections 6–7 arranges algebraically.

5. LEAVITT ALGEBRAS, ELEMENTARY GROUPS, AND THOMPSON’S GROUP V

Throughout, k is a field and $L = L_k(1, 2)$ is the binary Leavitt algebra (1), with generators s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 and relations $t_i s_j = \delta_{ij}$, $s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1 = 1$. Everything in this section is a consequence of the two relations alone.

Definition 5.1. A *binary Leavitt family* in a unital ring A is a quadruple (s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1) of elements of A satisfying

$$t_i s_j = \delta_{ij} \quad (i, j \in \{0, 1\}) \quad \text{and} \quad s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1 = 1.$$

The generators of L form a binary Leavitt family in L , and a unital homomorphic image of L carries one; but a family is strictly less than a copy of L —no injectivity is assumed—and the statements below that mention only a family are correspondingly stronger than their specializations to L . Fix a unital ring A carrying a binary Leavitt family, and write

$$p_0 = s_0 t_0, \quad p_1 = s_1 t_1,$$

a pair of orthogonal idempotents summing to 1: $p_i p_j = \delta_{ij} p_i$, since $p_0 p_1 = s_0(t_0 s_1)t_1 = 0$ and $p_i^2 = s_i(t_i s_i)t_i = p_i$. For a binary word $w = w_1 \cdots w_\ell \in \{0, 1\}^*$, put $s_w = s_{w_1} \cdots s_{w_\ell}$ and $s_w^* = t_{w_\ell} \cdots t_{w_1}$, so that $s_w^* s_{w'} = \delta_{w, w'}$

whenever $|w| = |w'|$, and more generally $s_w^* s_{w'}$ vanishes unless one of w, w' is a prefix of the other.

Two remarks on size. The algebra L itself is infinite-dimensional over k : the elements $s_0^i s_1$, $i \geq 0$, are killed on the left by mutually orthogonal projections and are linearly independent. And a family forces infinitude with no reference to L :

Lemma 5.2. *A nontrivial unital ring A carrying a binary Leavitt family is infinite.*

Leavitt/Leavitt
infinite
s0_pow_injective

Proof. The idempotents $e_i = s_0^i t_0^i$, $i \geq 0$, are pairwise distinct. Indeed, suppose $e_i = e_j$ with $i < j$. Multiplying on the left by t_0^i and on the right by s_0^i , and using $t_0^i s_0^i = 1$, gives $1 = s_0^d t_0^d$ with $d = j - i \geq 1$. Then $t_1 = t_1 \cdot 1 = (t_1 s_0) s_0^{d-1} t_0^d = 0$, whence $1 = t_1 s_1 = 0$, contradicting nontriviality. $\square$

5.1. Leaf sets and matrix self-similarity. A finite set of binary words $\mathcal{C} = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_r)$ (we use the same symbols for the words and for the corresponding elements $s_{\alpha_i} \in A$) is a *complete leaf set* if the words are the leaves of a finite full rooted binary tree; equivalently, if they are pairwise prefix-incomparable and the cylinders they define partition the boundary $\{0, 1\}^{\mathbb{N}}$.

Lemma 5.3 (Leaf identities). *Let $\mathcal{C} = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_r)$ be a complete leaf set. Then in every unital ring A carrying a binary Leavitt family:*

Leavitt/LeavittWords
wordT_mul_wordS_self
wordT_mul_wordS_of_
incomparable
cylinder_split

$$\alpha_i^* \alpha_j = \delta_{ij} \quad \text{and} \quad \sum_{i=1}^r \alpha_i \alpha_i^* = 1.$$

Proof. Prefix-incomparability and the relations $t_i s_j = \delta_{ij}$ give the first identity. The second holds by induction on the tree: for the trivial tree it reads $1 = 1$; replacing a leaf α by its two children $\alpha 0, \alpha 1$ changes the sum by

$$s_{\alpha 0} s_{\alpha 0}^* + s_{\alpha 1} s_{\alpha 1}^* - s_{\alpha} s_{\alpha}^* = s_{\alpha} (s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1 - 1) s_{\alpha}^* = 0. \quad \square$$

Leavitt/MatrixSelfSimilarity
ringEquivMatrix
Leavitt/LeavittSelfSimilarity
binaryMatrixRingEquiv

Proposition 5.4 (Matrix self-similarity). *Let A be a unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family and let $\mathcal{C} = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_r)$ be an ordered complete leaf set. Then*

Leavitt/PrefixCode
prefixRingEquiv
prefixRingEquiv_apply
prefixUnitsEquiv
Leavitt/SelfSimilarityAlgebra
matrixAlgEquiv
prefixAlgEquiv

$$\Theta_{\mathcal{C}} : M_r(A) \longrightarrow A, \quad (a_{ij}) \longmapsto \sum_{i,j=1}^r \alpha_i a_{ij} \alpha_j^*,$$

is an isomorphism of unital rings—of unital k -algebras when A is a k -algebra—with inverse $x \mapsto (\alpha_i^* x \alpha_j)_{ij}$. It restricts to group isomorphisms $\mathrm{GL}_r(A) \cong A^{\times}$ for all $r \geq 1$. In particular $M_r(L) \cong L$ for every $r \geq 1$.

Every positive rank, with an explicit inverse;
prefixRingEquiv is $\Theta_{\mathcal{C}}$ for an arbitrary leaf set,
prefixUnitsEquiv its restriction to unit groups, and prefixAlgEquiv the k -algebra refinement.

Proof. The map $\Theta_{\mathcal{C}}$ is additive—and k -linear when A is a k -algebra—sends the identity matrix to $\sum_i \alpha_i \alpha_i^* = 1$ by Lemma 5.3, and is multiplicative:

$$\Theta_{\mathcal{C}}(a) \Theta_{\mathcal{C}}(b) = \sum_{i,j,l,m} \alpha_i a_{ij} \alpha_j^* \alpha_l b_{lm} \alpha_m^* = \sum_{i,m} \alpha_i \left(\sum_j a_{ij} b_{jm} \right) \alpha_m^* = \Theta_{\mathcal{C}}(ab),$$

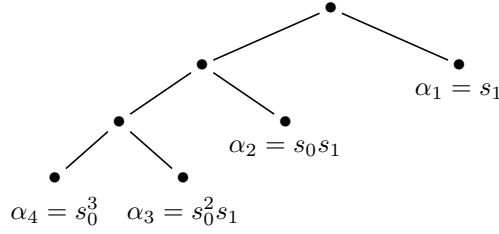


FIGURE 3. The left comb $\mathcal{C}_4$: every left child is subdivided. Reading left edges as s_0 and right edges as s_1 , each leaf spells its word along the path from the root; the ordering lists the leaves by depth, with the leftmost branch last.

using $\alpha_j^* \alpha_l = \delta_{jl}$. The displayed inverse is two-sided by the same identities: $\alpha_i^* \Theta_{\mathcal{C}}(a) \alpha_j = a_{ij}$, and $\sum_{i,j} \alpha_i (\alpha_i^* x \alpha_j) \alpha_j^* = 1 \cdot x \cdot 1 = x$. An algebra isomorphism restricts to an isomorphism of unit groups, and $\mathrm{GL}_r(L) = M_r(L)^\times$. $\square$

For every $r \geq 2$ there is a canonical choice, the *left comb*

$$(22) \quad \mathcal{C}_r = (s_1, s_0 s_1, s_0^2 s_1, \dots, s_0^{r-2} s_1, s_0^{r-1}),$$

the leaf set of the tree in which every left child is subdivided; the ordering lists the leaves by depth with the leftmost branch last (Figure 3).

5.2. Elementary groups over rings. Let A be a unital ring. Recall $x_{ij}(a) = I_r + aE_{ij}$ for $i \neq j$, the relations $x_{ij}(a)x_{ij}(b) = x_{ij}(a+b)$, and the Steinberg commutator relation

$$[x_{il}(a), x_{lj}(b)] = x_{ij}(ab) \quad (i, j, l \text{ distinct}),$$

where $[g, h] = ghg^{-1}h^{-1}$.

Lemma 5.5 (Whitehead commutator lemma). *Let A be a unital ring and $a, b \in A^\times$. Put*

$$w(a) = x_{12}(a) x_{21}(-a^{-1}) x_{12}(a) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & a \\ -a^{-1} & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then

$$\mathrm{diag}(a, a^{-1}) = w(a) w(-1) \in \mathrm{EL}_2(A),$$

and

$$\mathrm{diag}(aba^{-1}b^{-1}, 1) = \mathrm{diag}(a, a^{-1}) \mathrm{diag}(b, b^{-1}) \mathrm{diag}((ba)^{-1}, ba) \in \mathrm{EL}_2(A).$$

Consequently, for every $m \geq 2$, every product of commutators of units $c \in [A^\times, A^\times]$, and every diagonal position, the matrix with c at that position and 1 elsewhere on the diagonal lies in $\mathrm{EL}_m(A)$.

Proof. First, $x_{12}(a)x_{21}(-a^{-1}) = \begin{pmatrix} 1-aa^{-1} & a \\ -a^{-1} & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & a \\ -a^{-1} & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, and multiplying by $x_{12}(a)$ on the right adds the first column, multiplied on the right by a , to

Leavitt/Whitehead
whitehead_commutator
whitehead_diagonal
Leavitt/MatrixDiagonalization
exists_elementary_whitehead
Leavitt/DiagonalElementary
firstDiagonalUnit_mem_of_
mem_commutator
The two displayed identities
are the Whitehead pair; the
closing clause—a product of
commutators of units at a
diagonal position lies in
 EL_m —is firstDiagonalUnit_
mem_of_mem_commutator, stated
at the rank the argument
uses.

the second, giving $w(a) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & a \\ -a^{-1} & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Then

$$w(a)w(-1) = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & a \\ -a^{-1} & 0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} a & 0 \\ 0 & a^{-1} \end{pmatrix}.$$

The displayed product of three diagonal matrices has first entry $ab(ba)^{-1} = aba^{-1}b^{-1}$ and second entry $a^{-1}b^{-1}(ba) = 1$. For the last statement, embed $\text{EL}_2(A) \hookrightarrow \text{EL}_m(A)$ in any chosen pair of coordinates and multiply the resulting matrices for the commutator factors of c . $\square$

Lemma 5.6. *Let A be a finitely generated unital ring and $r \geq 3$. Then $\text{EL}_r(A)$ is finitely generated: if A is generated as a unital ring by the finite set T , then $\text{EL}_r(A)$ is generated by the finitely many matrices $x_{ij}(1)$ and $x_{ij}(t)$, $t \in T$, $i \neq j$.*

Proof. Let E be the subgroup generated by the listed matrices, and let $A_0 \subseteq A$ be the set of a with $x_{ij}(a) \in E$ for all $i \neq j$. By the addition relation, A_0 is an additive subgroup containing 1 and T ; by the Steinberg relation with a third index $l \notin \{i, j\}$ (here $r \geq 3$ is used), $a, b \in A_0$ implies $ab \in A_0$, since $x_{ij}(ab) = [x_{il}(a), x_{lj}(b)]$ and $x_{il}(a), x_{lj}(b) \in E$. Hence A_0 is a unital subring containing T , so $A_0 = A$ and $E = \text{EL}_r(A)$. $\square$

Theorem 5.7 (Property (T) at rank three; Ershov–Jaikin-Zapirain [9]). *Let A be a finite-type algebra over a finite field. Then $\text{EL}_3(A)$ has Kazhdan’s property (T).*

This is the case of the Ershov–Jaikin-Zapirain theorem that this paper consumes: [9] proves property (T) for EL_r of *every* finitely generated associative unital ring and every $r \geq 3$ —their statement is for the universal rings $\mathbb{Z}\langle x_1, \dots, x_d \rangle$, and the general case follows since EL_r of a quotient ring is a quotient group of EL_r of the ring and property (T) passes to quotients. We deliberately state only the finite-field, rank-three case: over rings carrying a binary Leavitt family it is all that is ever needed, because the rank equivalence below spreads property (T) from rank three to every rank ≥ 2 . Where a statement over an arbitrary finitely generated ring is wanted, the full theorem of [9] may be substituted; we flag each such use.

Over a ring carrying a binary Leavitt family, the rank of an elementary group is immaterial: matrix self-similarity collapses all ranks at the level of the *elementary* groups themselves, with no K -theory and no GE input. This is the engine that will spread every property of one rank to all ranks.

Proposition 5.8 (Elementary rank equivalence). *Let A be a unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family and let $n, m \geq 2$. Then there is an explicit group isomorphism*

$$\text{EL}_n(A) \cong \text{EL}_m(A),$$

the composite

$$\text{EL}_n(A) \cong \text{EL}_n(M_m(A)) = \text{EL}_{nm}(A) = \text{EL}_m(M_n(A)) \cong \text{EL}_m(A),$$

Leavitt/IntegralGeneration
elementaryGroup_eq_closure_
of_adjoin_int
elementaryGroup_
finitelyGenerated_int
Leavitt/ElementaryGroup
elementaryGroup_
finitelyGenerated
Any finitely generated unital
ring, with the printed
generating set exhibited: root
matrices at the ring
generators and at 1. The
characteristic-two form is the
one the binary development
consumes.
PropertyT/FreeElementaryPr
opertyT
controlSet_isKazhdanPair
PropertyT/FiniteFieldElemen
taryPropertyT
finiteFieldElementaryThree_
hasKazhdanPropertyT
Proved internally, with an
explicit Kazhdan pair.

Leavitt/LeavittRankEquivalence
nce
rankSuccEquiv
rankSuccToProduct
rankSucc_propertyT_of_
rankSucc

where the outer isomorphisms apply Θ_C^{-1} and $\Theta_{C'}$ of Proposition 5.4 to each matrix coefficient, and the middle equalities are block flattening. In particular finite generation, infinitude, property (T), and (non)soficity hold at one rank ≥ 2 if and only if they hold at every rank ≥ 2 .

Proof. Coefficient transport. A unital ring isomorphism $\varphi : B \rightarrow B'$ carries $x_{ij}(b)$ to $x_{ij}(\varphi b)$, hence induces an isomorphism $\text{EL}_p(B) \cong \text{EL}_p(B')$ for every p . Apply this with $\varphi = \Theta_{C_m}^{-1} : A \rightarrow M_m(A)$, which exists by Proposition 5.4.

Block flattening. Identify $M_p(M_q(A)) = M_{pq}(A)$ by the index pairing (i, c) , $1 \leq i \leq p$, $1 \leq c \leq q$. We claim $\text{EL}_p(M_q(A)) = \text{EL}_{pq}(A)$ as subgroups of $\text{GL}_{pq}(A)$, for every $p \geq 2$ and $q \geq 1$. One inclusion is direct: a block transvection $I + aE_{ij}$, $i \neq j$, $a \in M_q(A)$, equals the product $\prod_{c,d} x_{(i,c),(j,d)}(a_{cd})$ of q^2 commuting entry transvections. For the other inclusion, an entry transvection $x_{(i,c),(j,d)}(r)$ with $i \neq j$ is a block transvection with the single-entry coefficient rE_{cd} ; and one with $i = j$ (so $c \neq d$) is produced by the Steinberg relation through any third block index $l \neq i$, which exists because $p \geq 2$:

$$x_{(i,c),(i,d)}(r) = [x_{(i,c),(l,c)}(r), x_{(l,c),(i,d)}(1)],$$

both factors being cross-block transvections, hence in $\text{EL}_p(M_q(A))$ by the previous sentence. Applying block flattening with $(p, q) = (n, m)$ and—after reindexing along the bijection $(i, c) \mapsto (c, i)$, which conjugates by a permutation matrix and matches entry transvections to entry transvections—with $(p, q) = (m, n)$, gives the middle equalities. The final claim holds because all four properties are isomorphism-invariant. $\square$

5.3. Characteristic-two block factorizations. The following two identities, valid in characteristic two, are the engine of the explicit spine.

Lemma 5.9. *Let A be a unital ring of characteristic 2 carrying a binary Leavitt family. Then, in $M_2(A)$:*

- (a) $x_{12}(s_1) x_{21}(t_1) x_{12}(s_1) = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 0 \end{pmatrix};$
- (b) $x_{21}(1 + t_0) x_{12}(1) x_{21}(1 + s_0) x_{12}(t_0) = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 & s_1 t_1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix}.$

Proof. (a) Since $1 + p_1 = p_0$ in characteristic 2,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & s_1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ t_1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 + s_1 t_1 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

and then

$$\begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & s_1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 & p_0 s_1 + s_1 \\ t_1 & t_1 s_1 + 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

using $p_0 s_1 = s_0(t_0 s_1) = 0$ and $t_1 s_1 + 1 = 1 + 1 = 0$.

(b) Compute the product of the first two factors:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1 + t_0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 + t_0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix}$$

Leavitt/Leavitt

characteristicTwo_involution

characteristicTwo_compressor

compressor_factorization

The factorization is proved in

every characteristic.

(using $1 + t_0 + 1 = t_0$ in characteristic 2). Multiplying by the third factor,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1+t_0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 1+s_0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 & 1 \\ 1+t_0+t_0+t_0s_0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 & 1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix},$$

where the $(1,1)$ -entry is $1 + 1 + s_0 = s_0$ and the $(2,1)$ -entry is $(1 + t_0) + t_0(1 + s_0) = 1 + t_0 + t_0 + t_0s_0 = 1 + 1 = 0$, using $t_0s_0 = 1$. Finally,

$$\begin{pmatrix} s_0 & 1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & t_0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 & s_0t_0 + 1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 & s_1t_1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix},$$

since $s_0t_0 + 1 = p_0 + 1 = p_1 = s_1t_1$ in characteristic 2. $\square$

5.4. Thompson's group V in a Leavitt corner. Thompson's group V is the group of homeomorphisms of the boundary $\{0,1\}^{\mathbb{N}}$ given by *tree tables*: a pair of ordered complete leaf sets $(\beta_1, \dots, \beta_\ell)$, $(\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_\ell)$ with the same number ℓ of leaves, acting by the prefix substitutions $\beta_i x \mapsto \alpha_i x$; each such map carries the cylinder of β_i bijectively onto the cylinder of α_i and is a homeomorphism of the Cantor set. Two tables define the same element exactly when they have a common refinement, refinement being simultaneous subdivision of a source leaf and its target leaf.

Proposition 5.10 (Tree-table embedding). *Let A be a nontrivial unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family. For $g \in V$ given by a table $((\beta_i), (\alpha_i))$, put*

$$(23) \quad U_g = \sum_{i=1}^{\ell} \alpha_i \beta_i^* \in A.$$

Then U_g is well defined (independent of the table), $U_g U_h = U_{gh}$, $U_1 = 1$, each U_g is a unit with $U_g^{-1} = U_{g^{-1}}$, and $g \mapsto U_g$ is an injective homomorphism $V \hookrightarrow A^\times$.

Proof. Refining a table replaces a summand $\alpha\beta^*$ by $\alpha 0 (\beta 0)^* + \alpha 1 (\beta 1)^* = \alpha(s_0t_0 + s_1t_1)\beta^* = \alpha\beta^*$; since any two tables of the same element admit a common refinement, U_g is well defined. For multiplicativity, choose tables of g and h such that the source leaf set of g equals the target leaf set of h (refine both accordingly); then

$$U_g U_h = \sum_{i,j} \alpha_i \beta_i^* \gamma_j \delta_j^* = \sum_i \alpha_i \delta_i^* = U_{gh},$$

using $\beta_i^* \gamma_j = \delta_{ij}$ for the common leaf set, and the composed table represents gh . Also $U_1 = \sum_i \alpha_i \alpha_i^* = 1$ by Lemma 5.3, so each U_g is a unit with inverse $U_{g^{-1}}$. For injectivity, suppose $U_g = 1$ with a table $((\beta_i), (\alpha_i))$. Multiplying $\sum_i \alpha_i \beta_i^* = 1$ on the right by β_j gives $s_{\alpha_j} = s_{\beta_j}$ in A for each j —the products $\beta_i^* \beta_j = \delta_{ij}$ collapse the sum. Equality of these elements forces equality of the binary words. If neither word is a prefix of the other, multiplying $s_{\alpha_j} = s_{\beta_j}$ on the left by $s_{\alpha_j}^*$ gives $1 = s_{\alpha_j}^* s_{\beta_j} = 0$, contradicting the nontriviality of A . If, say, $\beta_j = \alpha_j \gamma$ with γ nonempty, the same multiplication gives $1 = s_\gamma$; choosing $i \in \{0,1\}$ different from the first letter of γ then gives $t_i = t_i s_\gamma = 0$, whence $1 = t_i s_i = 0$, again a contradiction. The case $\alpha_j = \beta_j \gamma$ is symmetric.

Leavitt/FamilyVEmbedding
vEmbeddingOfFamily
vEmbeddingOfFamily_injective
vEmbeddingOfFamily_
tableEquiv
tableSum_eq_of_mapsCylinder
tableSum_mul
wordS_injective
Leavitt/ThompsonVEmbedding
ng
vEmbedding
vEmbedding_injective
isComplete_of_covers
Leavitt/ThompsonV
tableEquiv
Over an arbitrary nontrivial
ring carrying a binary family,
with vEmbeddingOfFamily_
tableEquiv the formula (23),
well definedness
tableSum_eq_of_mapsCylinder,
and faithfulness the word
calculus wordS_injective.
The ThompsonVEmbedding
declarations are the earlier
version over the presented
algebra $L_k(1,2)$.

Hence $\alpha_j = \beta_j$ as words for every j , and g is the identity substitution. This is the standard realization of the Higman–Thompson groups inside Leavitt algebras and their Cuntz-algebra completions; compare [16, 17]. $\square$

Lemma 5.11 (Corner embedding). *Let A be a nontrivial unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family. For $g \in V$ put*

$$\rho(g) = p_0 + s_1 U_g t_1 \in A.$$

Then $\rho : V \rightarrow A^\times$ is an injective group homomorphism, and for all $g \in V$:

$$t_1 \rho(g) s_1 = U_g, \quad \rho(g) s_0 = s_0, \quad t_0 \rho(g) = t_0.$$

Proof. All computations take place in the subring generated by the Leavitt family, using $t_1 s_0 = 0$, $t_0 s_1 = 0$, $t_1 s_1 = t_0 s_0 = 1$, $p_0 s_0 = s_0$, $t_0 p_0 = t_0$, $p_0 s_1 = 0$, $t_1 p_0 = 0$. Multiplicativity:

$$\begin{aligned} \rho(g) \rho(h) &= (p_0 + s_1 U_g t_1)(p_0 + s_1 U_h t_1) \\ &= p_0^2 + p_0 s_1 U_h t_1 + s_1 U_g t_1 p_0 + s_1 U_g t_1 s_1 U_h t_1 \\ &= p_0 + s_1 U_g U_h t_1 = \rho(gh), \end{aligned}$$

by Proposition 5.10. Also $\rho(1) = p_0 + p_1 = 1$, so $\rho(g) \in A^\times$ with inverse $\rho(g^{-1})$. The three displayed identities are immediate: $t_1 \rho(g) s_1 = t_1 p_0 s_1 + t_1 s_1 U_g t_1 s_1 = U_g$; $\rho(g) s_0 = p_0 s_0 + s_1 U_g t_1 s_0 = s_0$; $t_0 \rho(g) = t_0 p_0 + t_0 s_1 U_g t_1 = t_0$. Injectivity: $\rho(g) = 1$ forces $U_g = t_1 \rho(g) s_1 = t_1 s_1 = 1$, hence $g = 1$ by Proposition 5.10. $\square$

Thus ρ realizes V inside the corner $p_0 + s_1(\cdot)t_1$, acting as the identity on the complementary corner $s_0(\cdot)t_0$: this complementarity is the algebraic seed of the centralizer relation $[K, J] = 1$.

The non-LEF input of the whole paper is the following finite obstruction. Its two relators are the standard defining relators of Thompson’s group F , used here purely as relators.

Lemma 5.12 (Two-relator obstruction). *Let a, b be elements of a group satisfying*

$$(24) \quad [ab^{-1}, a^{-1}ba] = 1 \quad \text{and} \quad [ab^{-1}, a^{-2}ba^2] = 1.$$

If a and b do not commute, the group is not LEF.

Proof. We first show that in a finite group the relations (24) force $[a, b] = 1$. Put $c_n = a^{-n}ba^n$, so $c_0 = b$ and $a^{-1}c_n a = c_{n+1}$. A relation $[ab^{-1}, c_n] = 1$ rearranges: $ab^{-1}c_n ba^{-1} = c_n$ is exactly

$$b^{-1}c_n b = a^{-1}c_n a = c_{n+1}.$$

Thus the two relations (24) are the cases $n = 1, 2$ of the family (C_n) : $b^{-1}c_n b = c_{n+1}$. Conjugating (C_1) by a^{-n} gives, since $a^{-n}ba^n = c_n$,

$$(A_n) : \quad c_n^{-1} c_{n+1} c_n = c_{n+2} \quad (n \geq 1).$$

Leavitt/LeavittCorner
cornerHom
cornerHom_s0
t0_cornerHom
t1_cornerHom_s1

Sofic/ThompsonFObstruction
not_isLEF_of_two_relations
finite_commute_of_two_relations
conjugacy_relation_all

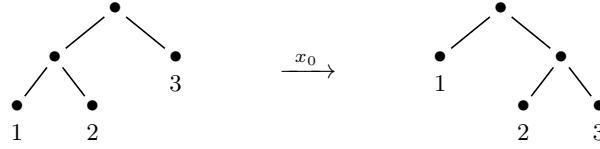


FIGURE 4. The tree table of x_0 . Matching leaf labels give the prefix substitution: the source leaves 00, 01, 1 map to the target leaves 0, 10, 11, so $x_0 = \{00 \mapsto 0, 01 \mapsto 10, 1 \mapsto 11\}$. The element x_1 applies the same table inside the cylinder 1 and fixes its complement.

Now (C_n) holds for every $n \geq 1$, by strong induction with base $(C_1), (C_2)$: using (A_{n-1}) , then (C_{n-1}) and (C_n) , then (A_n) ,

$$b^{-1}c_{n+1}b = b^{-1}(c_{n-1}^{-1}c_n c_{n-1})b = c_n^{-1}c_{n+1}c_n = c_{n+2}.$$

In a finite group $a^N = 1$ for some $N \geq 1$, so $c_N = c_0 = b$, and (C_N) reads $b^{-1}bb = c_{N+1} = c_1$; that is, $b = a^{-1}ba$, so $[a, b] = 1$.

Now suppose the ambient group were LEF. Take F to consist of 1, $[a, b]$, and every product of at most twenty letters drawn from $\{a^{\pm 1}, b^{\pm 1}\}$ —a finite set containing a , b , and all partial products needed to evaluate both relators and $[a, b]$ letter by letter. A local embedding $\varphi : F \rightarrow P$ into a finite group is multiplicative on these partial products, so $\varphi(a), \varphi(b)$ satisfy (24) in P , whence $[\varphi(a), \varphi(b)] = 1_P$ by the previous paragraph; but $\varphi([a, b]) = [\varphi(a), \varphi(b)] = 1_P = \varphi(1)$ and injectivity force $[a, b] = 1$, a contradiction. $\square$

Proposition 5.13. *Thompson’s group V is not LEF.*

Proof. Let $x_0, x_1 \in V$ be the tree tables

$$\begin{aligned} x_0 : \{ & 00 \mapsto 0, 01 \mapsto 10, 1 \mapsto 11 \}, \\ x_1 : \{ & 0 \mapsto 0, 100 \mapsto 10, 101 \mapsto 110, 11 \mapsto 111 \} \end{aligned}$$

(x_1 acts as x_0 inside the cylinder 1 and as the identity outside it; Figure 4 draws the pair of trees of x_0). Both relators (24) hold for $(a, b) = (x_0, x_1)$: each side is a composition of finitely many prefix substitutions, and refining all tables to a common leaf depth and comparing leaf images is a finite computation. The pair does not commute: on the point 011^∞ of the Cantor set,

$$x_0x_1(011^\infty) = x_0(011^\infty) = 101^\infty, \quad x_1x_0(011^\infty) = x_1(101^\infty) = 1101^\infty.$$

Lemma 5.12 applies. $\square$

Remark 5.14 (The classical facts about V , and the classical route). The group V is infinite, simple, and finitely presented [11, 6], and 2-generated [5]; it is perfect, since $[V, V]$ is a nontrivial normal subgroup of a simple group. These classical facts give a second proof of Proposition 5.13: a finitely presented LEF group is residually finite (Lemma 2.8), while an infinite simple

Leavitt/ThompsonVWitness
thompsonV_not_isLEF
Leavitt/ThompsonWitness
not_isLEF_
cornerWitnessSubgroup
Criterion/Scheme
not_isLEF_cornerSubgroup
Proved for V itself, with no
simplicity or presentation
input.

group is not. Nothing in the main line of this paper consumes them—the proofs of Theorems A–D use only Lemma 5.12 and the explicit pair above—but they are the conceptual frame: the witness subgroup built in Section 6 is the image of the standard copy of Thompson’s F inside the corner copy of V .

6. THE COMPRESSION SCHEME IN ADJACENT RANKS

This section presents the algebraic heart of the paper in its natural generality. The matrix identities below are verifiable by finite computation from the two Leavitt relations, over an arbitrary ambient ring. Beyond them, the section uses only the facts about Thompson’s group V established in Section 5 and the two membership hypotheses isolated in Theorem 6.10, the latter discharged explicitly in Section 7 and K -theoretically in Section 8.

Throughout, A is a nontrivial associative unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family (s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1) in the sense of Definition 5.1—in particular A may be, but need not contain a copy of, the Leavitt algebra $L = L_k(1, 2)$ —and we retain the notation $p_0 = s_0 t_0$, $p_1 = s_1 t_1$. Fix $m \geq 2$ and put

$$n = m + 1, \quad G = \text{EL}_n(A), \quad \Gamma = \{\hat{\gamma} = \text{diag}(\gamma, 1) \mid \gamma \in \text{EL}_m(A)\} \leq G.$$

Indeed $\Gamma \leq G$: an elementary matrix in the first m coordinates is an elementary matrix of rank n . The group $\Gamma \cong \text{EL}_m(A)$ is infinite, since $a \mapsto x_{12}(a)$ is injective and A is infinite by Lemma 5.2.

We use the left comb (22) with n leaves:

$$(25) \quad \alpha_i = s_0^{i-1} s_1 \quad (1 \leq i \leq m), \quad \alpha_n = s_0^m,$$

a complete leaf set, so that $\alpha_i^* \alpha_j = \delta_{ij}$ and $\sum_{i=1}^n \alpha_i \alpha_i^* = 1$ by Lemma 5.3.

6.1. The comb compressor. Define the column $b \in A^{m \times 1}$, the row $c \in A^{1 \times m}$, and the matrices $u, u' \in M_n(A)$:

$$b = \begin{pmatrix} s_1 \alpha_1^* \\ \vdots \\ s_1 \alpha_m^* \end{pmatrix}, \quad c = (\alpha_1 t_1 \quad \cdots \quad \alpha_m t_1),$$

$$u = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 I_m & b \\ 0 & \alpha_n^* \end{pmatrix}, \quad u' = \begin{pmatrix} t_0 I_m & 0 \\ c & \alpha_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Lemma 6.1. *The following identities hold in A :*

$$bc = p_1 I_m, \quad cb = 1 - \alpha_n \alpha_n^*, \quad t_0 b = 0, \quad cs_0 = 0, \quad b \alpha_n = 0, \quad \alpha_n^* c = 0.$$

Consequently $uu' = u'u = I_n$; thus $u \in \text{GL}_n(A)$ with $u^{-1} = u'$.

Proof. Entrywise: $(bc)_{ij} = s_1 \alpha_i^* \alpha_j t_1 = \delta_{ij} s_1 t_1 = \delta_{ij} p_1$. Next, $cb = \sum_{i=1}^m \alpha_i t_1 s_1 \alpha_i^* = \sum_{i=1}^m \alpha_i \alpha_i^* = 1 - \alpha_n \alpha_n^*$ by Lemma 5.3. The entries of $t_0 b$ are $t_0 s_1 \alpha_i^* = 0$; those of cs_0 are $\alpha_i t_1 s_0 = 0$; those of $b \alpha_n$ are $s_1 \alpha_i^* \alpha_n = 0$ and of $\alpha_n^* c$ are $\alpha_n^* \alpha_i t_1 = 0$, by orthogonality of distinct leaves. Then

$$uu' = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 t_0 I_m + bc & b \alpha_n \\ \alpha_n^* c & \alpha_n^* \alpha_n \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} (p_0 + p_1) I_m & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = I_n,$$

Leavitt/LeavittMatrixCompression

matrixCompressionHom

matrixCompressionUnit

matrixCompression_recover

Leavitt/RankFourCompressor

s

compressor

compressor_val

compressor is a product of

elementary transvections,

invertible by construction,

and compressor_val identifies

it with the matrix (26).

and likewise

$$u'u = \begin{pmatrix} t_0 s_0 I_m & t_0 b \\ c s_0 & c b + \alpha_n \alpha_n^* \end{pmatrix} = I_n. \quad \square$$

Proposition 6.2 (Compression). *For every $\gamma \in \text{EL}_m(A)$,*

$$(27) \quad u \hat{\gamma} u^{-1} = p_1 \widehat{I_m + s_0 \gamma t_0},$$

and on elementary generators $u \hat{x}_{ij}(a) u^{-1} = \hat{x}_{ij}(s_0 a t_0)$ for $i \neq j \leq m$. Consequently

$$(28) \quad K := u \Gamma u^{-1} = \langle \hat{x}_{ij}(s_0 a t_0) : a \in A, i \neq j \leq m \rangle \leq \Gamma,$$

and conjugation by u is an isomorphism $\Gamma \xrightarrow{\cong} K$; in particular $K \cong \text{EL}_m(A)$.

Proof. Block multiplication using Lemma 6.1:

$$\begin{aligned} u \hat{\gamma} u^{-1} &= \begin{pmatrix} s_0 \gamma & b \\ 0 & \alpha_n^* \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} t_0 I_m & 0 \\ c & \alpha_n \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 \gamma t_0 + b c & b \alpha_n \\ \alpha_n^* c & \alpha_n^* \alpha_n \end{pmatrix} \\ &= \begin{pmatrix} s_0 \gamma t_0 + p_1 I_m & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}. \end{aligned}$$

For $\gamma = x_{ij}(a) = I_m + a E_{ij}$, the block is $p_1 I_m + s_0 t_0 I_m + s_0 a t_0 E_{ij} = I_m + s_0 a t_0 E_{ij} = x_{ij}(s_0 a t_0)$. Since Γ is generated by the $\hat{x}_{ij}(a)$ and conjugation is a group isomorphism onto its image, K is generated by the displayed elements, which lie in Γ . $\square$

The compressed copy K sits inside Γ with all matrix entries confined to the corner $s_0(\cdot)t_0 = p_0 A p_0$ of A ; the complementary corner $p_1 A p_1$ is untouched, and this is the room in which the centralizing subgroup J will live.

6.2. The involution z and generation. Let $z \in M_n(A)$ agree with the identity matrix outside the coordinates 1 and n , where it is

$$(29) \quad z|_{\{1,n\}} = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}; \quad \text{that is, } z = I_n + (p_0 - 1)E_{11} + s_1 E_{1n} + t_1 E_{n1} - E_{nn}.$$

Lemma 6.3. $z^2 = I_n$; in particular $z \in \text{GL}_n(A)$. Moreover z centralizes K .

Proof. On the coordinates $\{1, n\}$,

$$\begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}^2 = \begin{pmatrix} p_0^2 + s_1 t_1 & p_0 s_1 \\ t_1 p_0 & t_1 s_1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 + p_1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = I_2,$$

using $p_0 s_1 = 0$, $t_1 p_0 = 0$, $t_1 s_1 = 1$; the remaining coordinates are fixed. For the centralizing statement, put $r = s_0 a t_0$ and note

$$p_0 r = r = r p_0, \quad t_1 r = 0, \quad r s_1 = 0.$$

Let $i \neq j \leq m$. If $1 \notin \{i, j\}$, then z acts as the identity on the coordinates i, j and $z \hat{x}_{ij}(r) z = \hat{x}_{ij}(r)$. If $i = 1$: the matrix $r E_{1j}$ satisfies $z(r E_{1j}) z = (p_0 r E_{1j} + t_1 r E_{nj}) z = r E_{1j} z = r E_{1j}$, since the j -th row of z is $e_j^\top$ for $2 \leq j \leq m$. If $j = 1$: $z(r E_{i1}) z = r E_{i1} z = r p_0 E_{i1} + r s_1 E_{in} = r E_{i1}$. In each case $z \hat{x}_{ij}(r) z^{-1} = \hat{x}_{ij}(r)$, and these elements generate K by (28). $\square$

Leavitt/RankFourCompressor
s

compressor_conjugation

compressionEnd_injective

Leavitt/Leavitt

z_sq

Leavitt/RankFourCompressor

s

involution_sq

Leavitt/DiagonalCornerComp

ression

matrixCompression_commutates_

firstDiagonalCorner

Define the second compressor

$$(30) \quad v = zu.$$

Then, by Proposition 6.2 and Lemma 6.3,

$$(31) \quad v\Gamma v^{-1} = z(u\Gamma u^{-1})z^{-1} = zKz^{-1} = K = u\Gamma u^{-1} :$$

the two compressors have one common image. The quotient $vu^{-1} = z$ is precisely what generates the missing last row and column:

Proposition 6.4 (Generation). *The subgroup of $\mathrm{GL}_n(A)$ generated by Γ and z contains $\mathrm{EL}_n(A)$. Consequently, if u and z lie in $\mathrm{EL}_n(A)$, then*

$$\mathrm{EL}_n(A) = \langle \Gamma, z \rangle = \langle \Gamma, u, v \rangle.$$

Proof. For $2 \leq j \leq m$ and $a \in A$, we claim

$$z\hat{x}_{1j}(s_1a)z = x_{nj}(a), \quad z\hat{x}_{j1}(at_1)z = x_{jn}(a).$$

For the first: $z(s_1aE_{1j})z = (p_0s_1aE_{1j} + t_1s_1aE_{nj})z = aE_{nj}z = aE_{nj}$, using $p_0s_1 = 0$, $t_1s_1 = 1$, and that the j -th row of z is $e_j^\top$. For the second: $z(at_1E_{j1})z = at_1E_{j1}z = at_1p_0E_{j1} + at_1s_1E_{jn} = aE_{jn}$, using $t_1p_0 = 0$, $t_1s_1 = 1$, and that the j -th column of z is e_j . Thus $\langle \Gamma, z \rangle$ contains $x_{nj}(a)$ and $x_{jn}(a)$ for all $2 \leq j \leq m$ and $a \in A$, as well as all $\hat{x}_{ij}(a) = x_{ij}(a)$ with $i \neq j \leq m$. The remaining elementary matrices are supplied by the Steinberg relation, using $m \geq 2$ so that the coordinate $2 \notin \{1, n\}$ exists:

$$x_{1n}(a) = [x_{12}(a), x_{2n}(1)], \quad x_{n1}(a) = [x_{n2}(a), x_{21}(1)].$$

Hence $\langle \Gamma, z \rangle \supseteq \mathrm{EL}_n(A)$. If moreover $u, z \in \mathrm{EL}_n(A)$, then $\langle \Gamma, z \rangle \subseteq \mathrm{EL}_n(A)$, giving the first equality; and since $z = vu^{-1}$, also $\langle \Gamma, u, v \rangle \supseteq \langle \Gamma, z \rangle = \mathrm{EL}_n(A) \supseteq \langle \Gamma, u, v \rangle$. $\square$

6.3. The commuting corner witness. For $g \in V$, recall $\rho(g) = p_0 + s_1U_g t_1 \in A^\times$ from Lemma 5.11, and define

$$j(g) = \mathrm{diag}(\rho(g), 1, \dots, 1) \in \mathrm{GL}_n(A), \quad J = \langle j(x_0), j(x_1) \rangle,$$

where $x_0, x_1 \in V$ are the two tree tables of Proposition 5.13. Thus J is a two-generator subgroup of the corner copy $j(V)$ of V ; it is the image of the standard copy of Thompson's F . Two lemmas place its generators inside Γ by explicit commutator certificates.

For prefix-incomparable words v, w , write

$$T(v, w) = s_v t_w + s_w t_v + (1 - p_v - p_w) \in A^\times,$$

the *cylinder transposition*: it is the table unit U_g of the element of V exchanging the cylinders v and w and fixing everything else, and $T(v, w)^2 = 1$.

Lemma 6.5 (Transpositions are single commutators). *Let v and w be prefix-incomparable. Then*

$$T(v, w) = [T(v0, v1)T(w0, w1), T(v0, w0)]$$

is a single commutator of units of A .

Leavitt/RankFourCompressor
s
coreEmbedding_compressorSet_
generate

Leavitt/ThompsonWitness
cylinderSwap_is_commutator
cylinderSwap_mem_commutator

Proof. All five transpositions are table units, and multiplication of table units composes the underlying prefix maps (Proposition 5.10), so the identity may be verified at the level of maps of $\{0, 1\}^{\mathbb{N}}$. Splitting the two cylinders into their children, $T(v, w)$ acts as the double transposition $(v0\ w0)(v1\ w1)$ of the four pairwise-incomparable child cylinders, fixing everything else; and in the symmetric group of these four cylinders, with $x = (v0\ v1)(w0\ w1)$ and $y = (v0\ w0)$,

$$xyx^{-1} = (v1\ w1), \quad \text{so} \quad [x, y] = (v1\ w1)(v0\ w0) = T(v, w)\text{'s action.}$$

All the maps involved fix the complement of the four child cylinders, so the identity holds outright. $\square$

Lemma 6.6 (Commutator certificates for the witness pair). *The table units of x_0 and x_1 factor as*

$$U_{x_0} = T(0, 10) T(0, 11) T(0, 1), \quad U_{x_1} = \kappa_{[1]}(U_{x_0}),$$

where $\kappa_{[1]}(u) = p_0 + s_1 u t_1$ is the corner insertion at the cylinder 1—multiplicative and unital by the computation of Lemma 5.11. Consequently U_{x_0} and U_{x_1} are products of three commutators of units of A each, and so are $\rho(x_0)$ and $\rho(x_1)$.

Proof. For the factorization, compose the three transpositions as prefix maps, rightmost first: a point $00v$ goes to $10v$, stays at $10v$, then goes to $0v$; a point $01v$ goes to $11v$, then to $0v$, then to $10v$; a point $1v$ goes to $0v$, then to $11v$, and stays. The composite is exactly the table $\{00 \mapsto 0, 01 \mapsto 10, 1 \mapsto 11\} = x_0$, and the displayed unit identity follows through Proposition 5.10. The identity $U_{x_1} = \kappa_{[1]}(U_{x_0})$ is the definition of x_1 (act as x_0 inside the cylinder 1, and note $1 - p_1 = p_0$). Each transposition is a single commutator by Lemma 6.5, so U_{x_0} is a product of three commutators, and $\kappa_{[1]}$, being unital and multiplicative, carries each commutator certificate to a commutator certificate. Finally $\rho(g) = p_0 + s_1 U_g t_1 = \kappa_{[1]}(U_g)$ itself, so the same transport gives the claim for $\rho(x_0)$ and $\rho(x_1)$. $\square$

Proposition 6.7. $J \leq \Gamma$: both $j(x_0)$ and $j(x_1)$ lie in $\text{EL}_m(A)$, embedded in the first m coordinates. The subgroup J is generated by two elements, and it is not LEF.

Proof. By Lemma 6.6, $\rho(x_0)$ and $\rho(x_1)$ are products of commutators of units of A ; the Whitehead commutator lemma (Lemma 5.5, with $m \geq 2$) places $\text{diag}(\rho(x_i), 1, \dots, 1)$ in $\text{EL}_m(A)$. Hence $J \leq \Gamma$. The composite $g \mapsto j(g)$ is an injective homomorphism (Lemma 5.11), so $j(x_0), j(x_1)$ satisfy the two relators (24) and do not commute, exactly as x_0, x_1 do in the proof of Proposition 5.13; Lemma 5.12 shows J is not LEF. $\square$

Remark 6.8 (The full corner copy of V). Granting the classical perfectness of V (Remark 5.14), the same Whitehead argument places *every* $j(g)$, $g \in V$, in $\text{EL}_m(A)$, so the full corner copy $j(V) \cong V$ is a subgroup of Γ , over every

Leavitt/ThompsonWitness
rootRotation
cornerWitnessSubgroup
cornerWitnessSubgroup_le_
commutator

Leavitt/UniversalRankFour
witnessEmbedding
witnessEmbedding_injective
Leavitt/DiagonalElementary
firstDiagonalUnit_mem_of_
mem_commutator
Leavitt/ThompsonWitness
not_isLEF_
cornerWitnessSubgroup

ring carrying a binary Leavitt family. The main theorems use only the two-generator witness J , whose certificates are explicit.

Proposition 6.9. $[K, J] = 1$ and $K \cap J = \{1\}$. Consequently $KJ \cong K \times J$.

Proof. Centralizing. Conjugating an elementary matrix by a diagonal matrix multiplies its coefficient: $j(g) \hat{x}_{il}(r) j(g)^{-1} = \hat{x}_{il}(\rho(g)^{[i=1]} r \rho(g^{-1})^{[l=1]})$, where the exponent $[i = 1]$ is 1 if $i = 1$ and 0 otherwise. For $r = s_0 a t_0$, Lemma 5.11 gives $\rho(g)r = \rho(g)s_0 a t_0 = s_0 a t_0 = r$ and $r\rho(g^{-1}) = s_0 a t_0 \rho(g^{-1}) = s_0 a t_0 = r$. Hence $j(g)$ commutes with every generator $\hat{x}_{il}(s_0 a t_0)$ of K from (28).

Trivial intersection. Suppose $j(g) \in K$. By (27), every element of K has the form $p_1 \widehat{I_m} + s_0 \gamma t_0$ with $\gamma \in \text{EL}_m(A)$; comparing $(1, 1)$ -entries, $\rho(g) = p_1 + s_0 \gamma_{11} t_0$. Sandwiching between t_1 and s_1 : on one side, $t_1(\rho(g) - 1)s_1 = t_1(s_1 U_g t_1 - p_1)s_1 = U_g - 1$, using $t_1 p_0 = 0$; on the other, $t_1(p_1 + s_0 \gamma_{11} t_0 - 1)s_1 = t_1(s_0 \gamma_{11} t_0 - p_0)s_1 = 0$, using $t_1 s_0 = 0$ and $t_1 p_0 = 0$. Hence $U_g = 1$, so $g = 1$ by Proposition 5.10, and $j(g) = 1$.

The two computations quantify over every $g \in V$, so they prove the claims for the full corner copy $j(V)$; the witness $J = \langle j(x_0), j(x_1) \rangle \leq j(V)$ inherits both. Since K and J commute and intersect trivially, the multiplication map $K \times J \rightarrow KJ$ is an isomorphism. $\square$

6.4. The Leavitt-corner theorem.

Theorem 6.10 (Leavitt-corner theorem). *Let A be a nontrivial associative unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family, let $m \geq 2$, and put $n = m + 1$. Let $u, z \in \text{GL}_n(A)$ be the matrices (26) and (29). Assume:*

- (i) $\text{EL}_m(A)$ and $\text{EL}_n(A)$ have property (T);
- (ii) $u, z \in \text{EL}_n(A)$; this holds, for instance, whenever $\text{GL}_n(A) = \text{EL}_n(A)$.

Then $\text{EL}_n(A)$ is not sofic.

Proof. Put $G = \text{EL}_n(A)$ and let $\Gamma, u, z, v = zu, K, J$ be as above. By hypothesis (i), G and $\Gamma \cong \text{EL}_m(A)$ are property-(T) groups, hence finitely generated, and Γ is infinite. By hypothesis (ii) and Proposition 6.4, $G = \langle \Gamma, u, v \rangle = \langle \Gamma, Q \rangle$ with $Q = \{u, v\} \subseteq G$. By Proposition 6.2 and (31),

$$u\Gamma u^{-1} = v\Gamma v^{-1} = K \leq \Gamma,$$

so both elements of Q conjugate Γ into itself. Fix $q_0 = u$, so $K = q_0 \Gamma q_0^{-1}$. By Propositions 6.7 and 6.9, the subgroup $J \leq \Gamma$ is generated by two elements, satisfies $[K, J] = 1$ and $K \cap J = \{1\}$, and is not LEF. If G were sofic, Corollary 4.2 (Theorem D) would force J to be LEF, a contradiction. $\square$

Corollary 6.11. *Let A be a nontrivial finite-type algebra over a finite field carrying a binary Leavitt family, and let $m \geq 2, n = m + 1$. If $u, z \in \text{EL}_n(A)$ —for instance, if $\text{GL}_n(A) = \text{EL}_n(A)$ —then $\text{EL}_n(A)$ is an infinite, finitely generated, property-(T) group that is not sofic.*

Criterion/Scheme

commute_compressed_corner

compressed_inf_corner

Leavitt/GeneralCornerTheore

m

corner_not_isSofic

compressionSetup

coreEmbedding_compressorSet_

generate

witnessEmbedding

corner_not_isSofic_of_

charTwo

Leavitt/GeneralScheme

uUnit

zUnit

uMatrix_mul_uPrimeMatrix

Criterion/CompressionSetup

CompressionSetup

Formalized at every adjacent

pair $(m, m + 1)$ with $m \geq 2$,

at exactly the printed

hypotheses: nontrivial ring,

binary family, (T) at both

ranks, and the membership

hypothesis (ii); finite

generation and countability

of the groups are derived

from (T). The witness is the

Whitehead diagonal in the

plane $(0, 1)$, and corner_not_

isSofic_of_charTwo

discharges (ii) in

characteristic two through

the elementary words of

Leavitt/GeneralRankWords.

Proof. Theorem 5.7 gives property (T) for $\text{EL}_3(A)$, and the elementary rank equivalence (Proposition 5.8) transports it to $\text{EL}_m(A)$ and $\text{EL}_n(A)$ for every $m \geq 2$, supplying hypothesis (i) of Theorem 6.10; hence $\text{EL}_n(A)$ is not sofic and has property (T). It is finitely generated by Lemma 5.6 (here $n \geq 3$, and a finite-type algebra over a finite field is a finitely generated ring), and infinite, since $a \mapsto x_{12}(a)$ embeds the ring A , which is infinite by Lemma 5.2. Over an arbitrary finitely generated unital ring and $m \geq 3$, the same conclusion holds verbatim, granting the full theorem of [9] in place of Theorem 5.7. $\square$

Remark 6.12 (The trust surface of the scheme). The matrix identities of this section are verifiable by finite computation from the two Leavitt relations; beyond them, the section inputs only the Whitehead lemma, the two-relator obstruction and the explicit commutator certificates of Section 5, and hypotheses (i) and (ii) of Theorem 6.10. The witness is elementary for every ambient ring: Proposition 6.7 uses only Lemmas 6.5–6.6 and the Whitehead lemma, and no perfectness theorem; with the classical perfectness of V , the full corner copy of V is elementary as well (Remark 6.8). The entire membership burden therefore falls on hypothesis (ii), which concerns exactly two matrices, u and z : Section 7 discharges it by explicit elementary factorizations in characteristic two, and Section 8 discharges it over every finite field via $K_1(L) = 0$ and the GE property, with the K_1 input available in elementary form (Remark 8.4).

7. THE EXPLICIT REALIZATION: NO K -THEORY

In this section $k = \mathbb{F}_2$ and $R = L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$; the matrix identities and the argument extend without change to any finite field of characteristic two. Fix $m \geq 3$, put $n = m + 1$, and let $G = \text{EL}_n(R)$, Γ , u , z , v , K , J be as in Section 6 with $A = R$. We now exhibit the two matrices u and z as explicit products of elementary matrices, discharging hypothesis (ii) of Theorem 6.10 with no K -theoretic input.

Proposition 7.1 (Explicit elementary factorization of the compressor). *For $1 \leq i \leq m$, put*

$$U_i = x_{ni}(1 + t_0) x_{in}(1) x_{ni}(1 + s_0) x_{in}(t_0) \in \text{EL}_n(R).$$

Then

$$u = U_m U_{m-1} \cdots U_1.$$

In particular $u \in \text{EL}_n(R)$, as a product of $4m$ elementary matrices.

Proof. By Lemma 5.9(b), applied in the pair of coordinates (i, n) , the matrix U_i agrees with the identity outside the coordinates i and n and equals $\begin{pmatrix} s_0 & s_1 t_1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix}$ on them; explicitly,

$$U_i = I_n + (s_0 + 1)E_{ii} + s_1 t_1 E_{in} + (t_0 + 1)E_{nn},$$

*Criterion/CriterionAssembly
not_isSofic_of_not_isLEF
Leavitt/FamilyRankFour
compressionSetup
ambient_not_isSofic
elementary_not_isSofic
units_not_isSofic
gl_not_isSofic
FamilyRankFour assembles the
corollary over any nontrivial
countable finite-type algebra
with a binary family,
discharging the memberships
rather than assuming them;
the ranks it reaches are every
 $r \geq 2$, together with $A^\times$ and
every GL_r .
Leavitt/GeneralRankWords
piece
piece_val
comb
comb_mem
comb_val
combMatrix
partialComb_val
Leavitt/RankFourCompressor
s
compressor
compressorMatrix
compressorPiece
compressorPiece_val
compressor_val
Every rank: piece and comb
are the displayed products for
arbitrary m , comb_val is the
printed row induction
(partialComb_val), all via a
coordinate-plane embedding
of the two-by-two identities.
The rank-four instance, valid
in every characteristic, is
kept for the concrete spine.*

signs being immaterial in characteristic two. Put $P_k = U_k U_{k-1} \cdots U_1$. We claim, by induction on k , that

$$P_k = \sum_{i \leq k} (s_0 E_{ii} + s_1 t_1 t_0^{i-1} E_{in}) + \sum_{k < i \leq m} E_{ii} + t_0^k E_{nn}.$$

For $k = 1$ this is the displayed form of U_1 . For the inductive step, compute the rows of $P_{k+1} = U_{k+1} P_k$. For $i \notin \{k+1, n\}$, the i -th row of U_{k+1} is $e_i^\top$, so the i -th row of P_{k+1} equals that of P_k . The $(k+1)$ -st row of U_{k+1} is $s_0 e_{k+1}^\top + s_1 t_1 e_n^\top$; since the $(k+1)$ -st row of P_k is $e_{k+1}^\top$ and the n -th row of P_k is $t_0^k e_n^\top$, the $(k+1)$ -st row of P_{k+1} is $s_0 e_{k+1}^\top + s_1 t_1 t_0^k e_n^\top$. The n -th row of U_{k+1} is $t_0 e_n^\top$, so the n -th row of P_{k+1} is $t_0^{k+1} e_n^\top$. This is the claimed form for $k+1$.

Finally, for the left comb (25), $s_1 t_1 t_0^{i-1} = s_1 (s_0^{i-1} s_1)^* = s_1 \alpha_i^*$ for $1 \leq i \leq m$, and $t_0^m = \alpha_n^*$. Hence

$$P_m = \sum_{i=1}^m (s_0 E_{ii} + s_1 \alpha_i^* E_{in}) + \alpha_n^* E_{nn} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 I_m & b \\ 0 & \alpha_n^* \end{pmatrix} = u,$$

by (26). $\square$

Lemma 7.2 (Explicit elementary factorization of the involution).

$$z = x_{1n}(s_1) x_{n1}(t_1) x_{1n}(s_1) \in \text{EL}_n(R).$$

Proof. Lemma 5.9(a), applied in the pair of coordinates $(1, n)$, produces exactly the matrix z of (29). $\square$

Theorem 7.3 (The explicit spine). *For every $m \geq 3$, the group $\text{EL}_{m+1}(R)$ over $R = L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$ is infinite, finitely generated, has property (T), and is not sofic.*

Proof. The ring $R = L_{\mathbb{F}_2}(1, 2)$ is finitely generated (by s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 over the prime field). Proposition 7.1 and Lemma 7.2 verify $u, z \in \text{EL}_{m+1}(R)$, and Corollary 6.11 applies. $\square$

Proof of Theorem A. Theorem 7.3 gives every $m \geq 3$; the case $m = 3$ is the group $G = \text{EL}_4(R)$. For $m \in \{1, 2\}$, the elementary rank equivalence of Proposition 5.8 is an explicit isomorphism $\text{EL}_{m+1}(R) \cong \text{EL}_4(R)$, and all four properties transport along it; in particular $\text{EL}_2(R)$ and $\text{EL}_3(R)$ have property (T) although Theorem 5.7 says nothing at rank two. The two auxiliary matrices are exhibited as explicit products of elementary matrices: u by Proposition 7.1 and z (hence $v = zu$) by Lemma 7.2. The remaining memberships, of the two witness matrices $j(x_0)$ and $j(x_1)$, follow from the explicit commutator certificates of Lemmas 6.5 and 6.6 together with the Whitehead identity of Lemma 5.5, which converts each certificate into an explicit elementary word. No K -theory is used. $\square$

Remark 7.4 (Scope of the explicit spine). The factorizations of this section are identities in characteristic two and hold over any field of characteristic two; finiteness of the field is used only through finite generation of the

Leavitt/GeneralRankWords
involutionWord
involutionWord_mem
involutionWord_val
involutionWord_sq
Leavitt/RankFourCompressor
s
involution
involutionMatrix
involution_sq
Leavitt/RawSwapCompressor
s
rawInvolutionWord_val
Every rank, with the
displayed value and $z^2 = 1$;
the rank-four instance is
valid in every characteristic.
RawSwapCompressors
additionally proves that the
uncorrected
three-transvection word
already centralizes,
conjugates, and generates, so
the order-two relation is a
convenience rather than an
input.
Endpoint/MainResults
universalLeavittEL4_not_
isSofic
universalLeavitt_profile

ring in Theorem 5.7. Thus $\text{EL}_{m+1}(L_k(1, 2))$ is infinite, finitely generated, Kazhdan, and nonsolic, with all memberships explicit, for every finite field k of characteristic two and every $m \geq 3$ —and then for every $m \geq 1$ by the elementary rank equivalence (Proposition 5.8). For rank $n = 3$ (that is, $m = 2$), hypothesis (i) of Theorem 6.10 for EL_2 is not supplied by Theorem 5.7; it is exactly here that the rank equivalence substitutes. Section 8 reaches the remaining groups of Theorem B—the unit group and every GL_r , over every finite field—through self-similarity.

8. RANK TWO AND THE FULL PANORAMA

The compression–centralizer mechanism closes already in rank two, over a different and smaller group Γ : the full diagonal unit group, with property (T) transported through self-similarity rather than supplied by Theorem 5.7. Since all the groups in question turn out to be isomorphic, the value of the rank-two realization is not a new group but a map of the mechanism’s boundary—it shows how little room the criterion actually needs. Combined with matrix self-similarity and the vanishing of K_1 (Proposition 8.2, with the elementary proof of Appendix A), this yields Theorem B.

8.1. The two-by-two realization.

Theorem 8.1 (Two-by-two Leavitt-corner theorem). *Let A be a nontrivial associative unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family. Suppose that $A^\times$ and $\text{EL}_2(A)$ have property (T) and that $\text{GL}_2(A) = \text{EL}_2(A)$. Then $\text{EL}_2(A)$ is not sofic.*

Proof. Put $G = \text{EL}_2(A) = \text{GL}_2(A)$ and

$$\Gamma = \{\text{diag}(a, 1) \mid a \in A^\times\} \leq G.$$

Then $\Gamma \cong A^\times$ is a property-(T) group, hence finitely generated, and it is infinite because $\rho : V \hookrightarrow A^\times$ is injective (Lemma 5.11).

The compressor. Put

$$u = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 & p_1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad u' = \begin{pmatrix} t_0 & 0 \\ p_1 & s_0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Using $p_1 s_0 = s_1(t_1 s_0) = 0$, $t_0 p_1 = (t_0 s_1)t_1 = 0$, $t_0 s_0 = 1$, and $p_0 + p_1 = 1$:

$$uu' = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 t_0 + p_1 & p_1 s_0 \\ t_0 p_1 & t_0 s_0 \end{pmatrix} = I_2, \quad u'u = \begin{pmatrix} t_0 s_0 & t_0 p_1 \\ p_1 s_0 & p_1 + s_0 t_0 \end{pmatrix} = I_2,$$

so $u \in \text{GL}_2(A) = G$ with $u^{-1} = u'$. For $a \in A$, put

$$\kappa(a) = p_1 + s_0 a t_0.$$

Then $\kappa(1) = 1$ and $\kappa(a)\kappa(a') = p_1 + s_0 a a' t_0 = \kappa(a a')$ by the same identities, so κ is unital and multiplicative and restricts to a group homomorphism $A^\times \rightarrow A^\times$, injective because $t_0 \kappa(a) s_0 = t_0 p_1 s_0 + t_0 s_0 a t_0 s_0 = a$; and

$$u \text{diag}(a, 1) u^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} s_0 a & p_1 \\ 0 & t_0 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} t_0 & 0 \\ p_1 & s_0 \end{pmatrix}$$

Leavitt/RankTwoCompression
n
rankTwo_not_isSofic
rankTwoInvolution_conj_
upperNil
rankTwoInvolution_conj_
lowerNil

$$= \begin{pmatrix} s_0 a t_0 + p_1 & p_1 s_0 \\ t_0 p_1 & t_0 s_0 \end{pmatrix} = \text{diag}(\kappa(a), 1).$$

Hence

$$K := u\Gamma u^{-1} = \{\text{diag}(\kappa(a), 1) \mid a \in A^\times\} \leq \Gamma.$$

The involution. Put

$$z = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 & s_1 \\ t_1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \text{so} \quad z^2 = \begin{pmatrix} p_0^2 + s_1 t_1 & p_0 s_1 \\ t_1 p_0 & t_1 s_1 \end{pmatrix} = I_2,$$

using $p_0 s_1 = 0$, $t_1 p_0 = 0$, $t_1 s_1 = 1$; thus $z \in \text{GL}_2(A) = G$ and $z^{-1} = z$. For any $c \in A$,

$$(32) \quad z \text{diag}(c, 1) z = \begin{pmatrix} p_0 c p_0 + p_1 & p_0 c s_1 \\ t_1 c p_0 & t_1 c s_1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The element $\kappa(a)$ satisfies $p_0 \kappa(a) = \kappa(a) p_0 = s_0 a t_0$, $t_1 \kappa(a) = t_1$, and $\kappa(a) s_1 = s_1$; substituting into (32) gives $z \text{diag}(\kappa(a), 1) z = \text{diag}(s_0 a t_0 + p_1, 1) = \text{diag}(\kappa(a), 1)$. Hence z centralizes K , and $v := zu \in G$ satisfies $v\Gamma v^{-1} = zKz^{-1} = K$.

Generation. For any $a \in A$, the elements $1 + p_0 a t_1$ and $1 + s_1 a p_0$ are units of A , since $(p_0 a t_1)^2 = 0$ and $(s_1 a p_0)^2 = 0$ (using $t_1 p_0 = 0$ and $p_0 s_1 = 0$); so the diagonal matrices $\text{diag}(1 + p_0 a t_1, 1)$ and $\text{diag}(1 + s_1 a p_0, 1)$ lie in Γ . Substituting $c = 1 + p_0 a t_1$ and $c = 1 + s_1 a p_0$ into (32) and using $t_1 p_0 = 0$, $p_0 s_1 = 0$, $t_1 s_1 = 1$, $p_0^2 = p_0$:

$$(33) \quad z \text{diag}(1 + p_0 a t_1, 1) z = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & p_0 a \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = x_{12}(p_0 a),$$

$$(34) \quad z \text{diag}(1 + s_1 a p_0, 1) z = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ a p_0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = x_{21}(a p_0).$$

Next, the *corner swap*

$$d = s_1 t_0 + s_0 t_1 \in A^\times, \quad d^2 = s_1 t_1 + s_0 t_0 = 1,$$

gives $D = \text{diag}(d, 1) \in \Gamma$ with $D^{-1} = D$. Conjugation by D multiplies an upper coefficient on the left by d and a lower coefficient on the right by d ; since $d p_0 s_0 t_1 = d s_0 t_1 = p_1$ and $s_1 t_0 p_0 d = s_1 t_0 d = p_1$,

$$D x_{12}(p_0(s_0 t_1 a)) D = x_{12}(p_1 a), \quad D x_{21}((a s_1 t_0) p_0) D = x_{21}(a p_1),$$

with the inner matrices supplied by (33) and (34). Finally

$$x_{12}(a) = x_{12}(p_0 a) x_{12}(p_1 a), \quad x_{21}(a) = x_{21}(a p_0) x_{21}(a p_1),$$

so $\langle \Gamma, z \rangle$ contains every elementary matrix; hence $\langle \Gamma, z \rangle = G$, and since $z = vu^{-1}$,

$$G = \langle \Gamma, u, v \rangle, \quad u\Gamma u^{-1} = v\Gamma v^{-1} = K \leq \Gamma.$$

The commuting corner. Put $J = \langle \text{diag}(\rho(x_0), 1), \text{diag}(\rho(x_1), 1) \rangle \leq \Gamma$; membership is automatic here, since $\rho(g) \in A^\times$. By Lemma 5.11 the pair

inherits the relators (24) and the noncommutation of x_0, x_1 , so J is a two-generator non-LEF subgroup by Lemma 5.12. The subgroups K and J commute—indeed K commutes with the whole diagonal corner copy:

$$\begin{aligned}\kappa(a)\rho(g) &= (p_1 + s_0at_0)(p_0 + s_1U_g t_1) = s_1U_g t_1 + s_0at_0 \\ &= (p_0 + s_1U_g t_1)(p_1 + s_0at_0) = \rho(g)\kappa(a),\end{aligned}$$

using $p_1s_1 = s_1$, $t_1p_1 = t_1$, $t_0p_0 = t_0$, $p_0s_0 = s_0$, $t_0s_1 = 0$, $t_1s_0 = 0$. And $K \cap J$ is trivial: if $\kappa(a) = \rho(g)$, then sandwiching between t_0 and s_0 gives $a = t_0\kappa(a)s_0 = t_0\rho(g)s_0 = 1$, so $\rho(g) = \kappa(1) = 1$ and $g = 1$ by injectivity of ρ .

Conclusion. The data $G, \Gamma, Q = \{u, v\}$, $q_0 = u$, K, J satisfy all hypotheses of Corollary 4.2: G and Γ are finitely generated Kazhdan groups, Γ is infinite, $G = \langle \Gamma, Q \rangle$, each $q \in Q$ conjugates Γ into itself with $q_0\Gamma q_0^{-1} = K$, and $J \leq \Gamma$ is finitely generated with $[K, J] = 1$ and $K \cap J = \{1\}$. If G were sofic, J would be LEF, contradicting Lemma 5.12. $\square$

8.2. K_1 vanishes and $\text{GL} = \text{EL}$. Every ring-theoretic fact this subsection needs is proved in Appendix A; for context we recall the theorem of Ara–Goodearl–Pardo [3], of which the facts below are the $L_k(1, 2)$ -instances: a purely infinite simple unital ring R is a GE-ring (every matrix in $\text{GL}_r(R)$ is a product of elementary matrices and one $\text{diag}(a, 1, \dots, 1)$), and $R^\times/[R^\times, R^\times] \cong K_1(R)$. Neither statement is invoked in any proof of this paper.

Proposition 8.2. *Let k be any field and $L = L_k(1, 2)$. Then:*

- (i) $K_1(L) = 0$;
- (ii) the unit group $L^\times$ is perfect;
- (iii) $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$ for every $r \geq 2$.

Proof. Parts (i) and (iii) are proved, elementarily and in full, in Appendix A: Theorem A.2 establishes $K_1(L) = 0$ in Whitehead form—every unit u has $\text{diag}(u, 1) \in \text{EL}_2(L)$ —and Corollary A.23 deduces $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$ for every $r \geq 2$, by rank-two elimination and flattening transport. The only input of the appendix beyond the Leavitt relations is strong division (Lemma A.3), which holds because L is purely infinite simple: the graph criteria of [1] are immediate for the rose R_2 with one vertex and two loops—the single vertex admits no nontrivial hereditary saturated subset, every cycle has an exit, and the vertex lies on a cycle.

Part (ii) is Corollary A.23 as well: $\Theta_{\mathcal{C}_3}$ identifies $L^\times$ with $\text{GL}_3(L) = \text{EL}_3(L)$, and every elementary generator is a commutator by the Steinberg relation, so $L^\times$ is its own commutator subgroup. (Classically, (ii) also follows from (i) and the Ara–Goodearl–Pardo identification of K_1 with the abelianized unit group.)

For an independent confirmation of (i), the K -theory of Leavitt path algebras [2] gives the exact sequence

$$K_1(k) \xrightarrow{1-N^\top} K_1(k) \longrightarrow K_1(L) \longrightarrow K_0(k) \xrightarrow{1-N^\top} K_0(k),$$

KOne/RefineLoopDischarge
K1_trivial
stableUnits_eq_top_holds
KOne/AllRanksElementary
elementaryGroup_eq_top
glAll_eq_elementary
binaryLeavittUnits_perfect

where N is the adjacency matrix—here the 1×1 matrix (2) , so $1 - N^T = -1$, an isomorphism on both $K_0(k) \cong \mathbb{Z}$ and $K_1(k) \cong k^\times$, whence $K_1(L) = 0$. $\square$

Remark 8.3. For an independent recent account of generation phenomena for unit groups and matrix groups over Leavitt algebras, consistent with Proposition 8.2 and with the self-similarity of Proposition 5.4, see [12].

Remark 8.4 (An elementary route to $K_1(L) = 0$). The classical computation of $K_1(L)$ goes through the localization sequence of [2]. Appendix A replaces this input by a complete elementary proof—a Gaussian elimination over the binary tree, in the spirit of a Wiener–Hopf factorization whose “symbol” is a matrix pencil with two shift variables. In outline: a width reduction narrows every unit, modulo the Whitehead class group H of Definition A.1, to one whose value lies in the degree window $[-1, 1]$; at a sufficiently deep leaf set such a narrow unit becomes a matrix pencil with scalar coefficient matrices (A_0, A_1, C, B_0, B_1) over the five-dimensional space $kt_0 \oplus kt_1 \oplus k \oplus ks_0 \oplus ks_1$, indexed by a pair of complete leaf sets; and a single loop with two exits eliminates the pencil, splitting one column per pass (the index shift of the Wiener–Hopf analogy) until either a reshape by two tree tables lands the value in a one-sided degree window, or the stacked matrix $[B_0; B_1]$ acquires a scalar left inverse and the *inverse* unit lands there instead; one-sided windows die by a block-move induction whose base is the keystone Lemma A.16. Every step is carried out in Appendix A, so the K_1 -theoretic input of [2] is eliminated from the trust surface of Theorem B; the citation is retained as an independent confirmation.

Remark 8.5 (Effective Wiener–Hopf factorization over the binary tree). The proof in Appendix A is an algorithm, and unwinding its run records a factorization of independent interest: *every unit of $L = L_k(1, 2)$ is an explicit product of cylinder unipotents $1 + s_v x t_w$, code-scalar units (matrices over k transported along a complete leaf set), tree-table units (elements of Thompson’s group V), and one unit of nonpositive degree window conjugated by two tree tables*—the moves that the width reduction, the loop, and the two exits actually perform, in the order they perform them. The run is effective, with bounds read off the printed proof: for u supported on monomials of depth at most d , the pencil sits over the full code of depth $m + 1 \leq d + 1$, so every code involved has at most 2^{d+2} words; each loop pass is one Gaussian elimination over k at that size; and the loop counter of Theorem A.22 starts at 2^{m+1} columns and exits by 2^{m+2} , so at most 2^{d+1} passes occur. The factorization, and with it an explicit factorization of any $\text{diag}(u, 1, \dots, 1)$ into elementary matrices, is therefore computed in time polynomial in 2^d and in the number of monomials of u . In the classical Wiener–Hopf picture the loop is index normalization: each refinement is the index shift that trades a constant diagonal for a shift atom, and the two exits are the two triangular factorizations. We are not aware of a prior effective factorization—or of any elementary proof of $K_1(L_k(1, 2)) = 0$ —in the literature; the localization-sequence computation of [2] is neither elementary nor effective.

KOne/RefineLoopDischarge

K1_trivial

narrowReduction_holds

scalarReduction_holds

8.3. Finite fields: all ranks and the unit group.

Theorem 8.6. *Let k be a finite field and $L = L_k(1, 2)$. Then $\text{EL}_2(L) = \text{GL}_2(L)$ is infinite, finitely generated, has property (T), and is not sofic.*

Proof. The ring L is finitely generated, by s_0, s_1, t_0, t_1 and the finitely many scalars. By Theorem 5.7, Proposition 5.8, and Lemma 5.6, $\text{EL}_4(L)$ is a finitely generated Kazhdan group; by Proposition 8.2(iii), $\text{EL}_4(L) = \text{GL}_4(L)$; and by Proposition 5.4 with the left comb $\mathcal{C}_4$, $\text{GL}_4(L) \cong L^\times$. Hence $L^\times$ is a finitely generated Kazhdan group. Similarly, $\text{GL}_2(L) = \text{EL}_2(L)$ by Proposition 8.2(iii), and $\text{GL}_2(L) \cong L^\times$ by Proposition 5.4 with $\mathcal{C}_2 = (s_1, s_0)$; so $\text{EL}_2(L)$ is Kazhdan as well. Theorem 8.1 with $A = L$ now shows that $\text{EL}_2(L)$ is not sofic. It is infinite, containing $\text{diag}(\rho(V), 1) \cong V$, and finitely generated, being Kazhdan. $\square$

Theorem 8.7 (Panorama). *Let k be a finite field and $L = L_k(1, 2)$. Then the groups*

$$L^\times = \text{GL}_1(L), \quad \text{GL}_r(L) \ (r \geq 1), \quad \text{EL}_r(L) \ (r \geq 2)$$

are mutually isomorphic—explicitly, $\Theta_{\mathcal{C}} : \text{GL}_r(L) \rightarrow L^\times$ is an isomorphism for every ordered complete leaf set $\mathcal{C}$ of size r , and $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$ for $r \geq 2$ —and each is an infinite, finitely generated, property-(T) group that is not sofic.

Proof. The isomorphisms are Proposition 5.4, and the equalities $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$ are Proposition 8.2(iii). Each of the listed groups is therefore isomorphic to $\text{EL}_2(L)$, which is infinite, finitely generated, Kazhdan, and nonsocic by Theorem 8.6; all four properties are isomorphism-invariant. $\square$

Proof of Theorem B. Part (i) and part (ii) are exactly Theorem 8.7, with the explicit isomorphism (2) given by Proposition 5.4. $\square$

Remark 8.8 (Two routes to rank four). For a finite field of characteristic two and rank $m + 1 \geq 4$, the membership hypotheses are discharged twice over: explicitly, with no K -theory, in Section 7; and via Proposition 8.2 here. Theorem B in its full strength—all ranks down to two, all finite fields, and the unit group itself—uses the second route. The step that makes the panorama characteristic-free is Proposition 6.7: the witness is elementary because its memberships go through single-commutator certificates and the Whitehead lemma, identities valid over every ring, rather than through transvection factorizations of transpositions, which require characteristic two.

9. FINITELY PRESENTED NONSOFTIC COVERS

Nonsocicity of a finitely generated group is witnessed by a finite fragment of its multiplication table; imposing that fragment as a presentation produces finitely presented nonsocic covers. The covers are proved nonsocic directly, from the forbidden table itself; quotient closure of socicity—which in fact fails, by Remark 10.6—plays no role.

Leavitt/RankTwoCompression
rankTwo_not_isSofic
KOne/AllRanksElementary
binaryLeavittRankTwo_not_isSofic
Leavitt/UnitsGLProfile
binaryLeavittUnits_profile
binaryLeavittGL_profile
Instantiated over $L_k(1, 2)$
for every finite field, by the
rank-two compression itself.
Endpoint/MainResults
binaryLeavitt_finiteField_profile
binaryLeavittUnits_not_isSofic
binaryLeavittGL_not_isSofic
universalLeavittEL3_not_isSofic
Leavitt/PrefixCode
prefixRingEquiv
prefixRingEquiv_apply
prefixUnitsEquiv
Proved over every finite field
via self-similarity, without
 K_1 or GE; the isomorphisms
 $\Theta_{\mathcal{C}}$ are prefixRingEquiv and
prefixUnitsEquiv.

Covers/TableCover
TableModel

Definition 9.1. Let G be a group, $F \subseteq G$ finite with $1 \in F$, and $\varepsilon > 0$. An (F, ε) -model of G is a map $\varphi : F \cup F \cdot F \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y)$, for some finite set Y , such that

$$(35) \quad d_H(\varphi(g)\varphi(h), \varphi(gh)) \leq \varepsilon \quad (g, h \in F),$$

$$(36) \quad d_H(\varphi(g), \varphi(h)) \geq 1 - \varepsilon \quad (g, h \in F, g \neq h).$$

Lemma 9.2 (Finite-table characterization). *A countable group G is sofic if and only if it admits an (F, ε) -model for every finite $F \ni 1$ and every $\varepsilon > 0$.*

Proof. If σ_n is a sofic approximation, then for fixed (F, ε) the restriction of σ_n to $F \cup F \cdot F$ is an (F, ε) -model for all large n : (35) is Definition 2.1(a), and (36) follows from (a) and (b) since $d_H(\sigma_n(g), \sigma_n(h)) \geq d_H(\sigma_n(gh^{-1})\sigma_n(h), \sigma_n(h)) - d_H(\sigma_n(gh^{-1})\sigma_n(h), \sigma_n(g)) = d_H(\sigma_n(gh^{-1}), \text{id}) - o(1)$.

Conversely, exhaust G by finite symmetric sets $F_1 \subseteq F_2 \subseteq \dots$ containing 1, and let φ_n be an $(F_n, 1/n)$ -model on Y_n ; replacing Y_n by many disjoint copies of itself we may assume $|Y_n| \rightarrow \infty$. Define $\sigma_n(g) = \varphi_n(g)$ for $g \in F_n$ and $\sigma_n(g) = \text{id}$ otherwise. Fix $g, h \in G$; for n large, $g, h, gh \in F_n$, and (35) gives Definition 2.1(a). For faithfulness, first note that $p_n = \varphi_n(1)$ satisfies $d_H(p_n^2, p_n) \leq 1/n$ by (35) with $g = h = 1$, and $d_H(p_n^2, p_n) = d_H(p_n, \text{id})$ by right invariance of d_H ; so $d_H(\varphi_n(1), \text{id}) \leq 1/n$. Then for $g \neq 1$ and n large,

$$d_H(\sigma_n(g), \text{id}) \geq d_H(\varphi_n(g), \varphi_n(1)) - d_H(\varphi_n(1), \text{id}) \geq 1 - \frac{2}{n},$$

by (36). Hence σ_n is a sofic approximation. $\square$

Theorem 9.3 (Finite multiplication-table covers). *Let G be a finitely generated group that is not sofic. Then there is an infinite finitely presented group H that is not sofic, together with a surjection $H \twoheadrightarrow G$.*

Proof. Finite groups are sofic, so G is infinite. By Lemma 9.2 there are a finite set $F \subseteq G$ with $1 \in F$ and an $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ such that G admits no (F, ε_0) -model; enlarging F , we may assume F is symmetric and generates G . Define the finitely presented group

$$(37) \quad H = H_F = \langle x_g \ (g \in F \cup F \cdot F) \mid x_1 = 1, \ x_g x_h = x_{gh} \ (g, h \in F) \rangle.$$

The assignments $x_g \mapsto g$ satisfy the relations in G , and F generates G , so there is a surjection

$$(38) \quad \pi : H \twoheadrightarrow G, \quad \pi(x_g) = g.$$

In particular H is infinite, and $\pi(x_g) = g \neq h = \pi(x_h)$ shows $x_g \neq x_h$ in H for distinct $g, h \in F \cup F \cdot F$.

Suppose H were sofic, with sofic approximation $\sigma_n : H \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$. Define $\varphi_n : F \cup F \cdot F \rightarrow \text{Sym}(Y_n)$ by $\varphi_n(g) = \sigma_n(x_g)$. For $g, h \in F$, the relation $x_g x_h = x_{gh}$ holds in H , so

$$d_H(\varphi_n(g)\varphi_n(h), \varphi_n(gh)) = d_H(\sigma_n(x_g)\sigma_n(x_h), \sigma_n(x_g x_h)) \rightarrow 0.$$

Covers/TableCover
tableModel_of_isSofic
exists_table_obstruction

Covers/TableCover
tableGroup_no_model
exists_finitelyPresented_
obstruction

For distinct $g, h \in F$, the element $x_g x_h^{-1} \neq 1$ of H gives, as in the proof of Lemma 9.2,

$$d_H(\varphi_n(g), \varphi_n(h)) \geq d_H(\sigma_n(x_g x_h^{-1}), \text{id}) - o(1) \rightarrow 1.$$

Hence for n large, φ_n is an (F, ε_0) -model of G —note that (35) and (36) refer only to the multiplication table of F inside G , which is faithfully copied by the generators of H . This contradicts the choice of (F, ε_0) . Therefore H is not sofic. $\square$

Theorem 9.4 (Kazhdan covers). *Let G be a nonsofic group with property (T). Then there is an infinite finitely presented property-(T) group H that is not sofic, together with a surjection $H \twoheadrightarrow G$.*

Proof. Property-(T) groups are finitely generated, and G is infinite as before. By Shalom’s theorem [19], G is a quotient of a finitely presented property-(T) group: fix a surjection $\theta : P \twoheadrightarrow G$ with P finitely presented and Kazhdan. Choose (F, ε_0) as in the proof of Theorem 9.3, and for each $g \in F \cup F \cdot F$ choose a lift $\tilde{g} \in P$ with $\theta(\tilde{g}) = g$, taking $\tilde{1} = 1$. Define

$$(39) \quad H = P / \langle\langle \tilde{g} \tilde{h} \tilde{g} \tilde{h}^{-1} : g, h \in F \rangle\rangle.$$

Then H is finitely presented (finitely many new relators over the finitely presented P) and has property (T) (a quotient of P). Each relator lies in $\ker \theta$, since $\theta(\tilde{g} \tilde{h} \tilde{g} \tilde{h}^{-1}) = gh(gh)^{-1} = 1$; hence θ descends to a surjection $H \twoheadrightarrow G$, and H is infinite. Writing $y_g \in H$ for the image of $\tilde{g}$, we have $y_1 = 1$, $y_g y_h = y_{gh}$ for $g, h \in F$, and $y_g \neq y_h$ for distinct $g, h \in F$ (their images in G differ). If H were sofic, then $\varphi_n(g) = \sigma_n(y_g)$ would be an (F, ε_0) -model of G for large n , exactly as in the proof of Theorem 9.3, a contradiction. $\square$

Proof of Theorem C. The first two assertions are Theorems 9.3 and 9.4. For the final assertion, apply Theorem 9.4 to the infinite finitely generated property-(T) nonsofic group $L^\times$ of Theorem B, over any fixed finite field; the resulting H surjects onto $L^\times$, and composing with the inverses of the isomorphisms Θ_C of Theorem B(ii) exhibits a quotient of H isomorphic to each group listed there. $\square$

Remark 9.5 (Effectivity). The covers are effective in the logical sense: non-soficity of G is equivalent, by Lemma 9.2, to the existence of a finite witness (F, ε_0) , and any witness yields H by (37) or (39). The proof establishes the existence of a witness without computing one, and no claim is made that $L^\times$ itself is finitely presented.

10. CONCLUDING REMARKS

Remark 10.1 (The trust surface of Theorem A). Theorem A is independent of $\text{GL}_r = \text{EL}_r$ and of $K_1(L) = 0$: the memberships of u and z are explicit factorizations, the remaining memberships follow from the Whitehead identity and the explicit commutator certificates of the witness pair, and the only

Kazhdan/ShalomFinitePresen
tation
exists_presented_kazhdan_
cover
exists_finitelyPresented_
kazhdan_cover
Covers/KazhdanCover
exists_kazhdan_
finitelyPresented_cover_of_
not_isSofic
Shalom’s theorem is proved
internally, not cited.

analytic inequality proved in the paper is the co-area estimate of Lemma 2.7—the approximation-theoretic depth resides in the cited theorems of Kun and Kun–Thom. The argument concerns permutation models only; hyperlinearity of these groups, and the Connes embedding problem, remain open.

Remark 10.2 (Two compressors, one image). The pair $Q = \{u, v\}$ resolves a genuine tension: generation of G requires elements that move Γ , while compression requires elements that map Γ into itself. The present realization divides the two roles. The compressor u seats $K = u\Gamma u^{-1}$; the involution $z = vu^{-1}$ generates the missing last row and column of EL_n (Proposition 6.4); and the two compressors share the single image K , so the criterion sees one coherent compression while z carries the generation. The criterion itself is indifferent to the size of Q ; the algebra here simply supplies two natural compressors rather than one.

Remark 10.3 (The median is canonical up to scale). The normalization $f = s/(s + m)$ of Section 4 pins at $1/2$, and the value $1/2$ is not a trace or a spectral constant: it is the fixed point of the exchange of source and target sizes, and it is a vertex-weighted median by construction. Median pinning is exactly the statement that a permutation compressing one expander decomposition into another must asymptotically preserve the size profile—the conservative core of the argument, with exact conservation (Lemma 3.2) converting a one-sided drift estimate into a two-sided one at no cost.

Remark 10.4 (What property (T) is used for). Property (T) enters three times, in three different roles: (a) through Theorem 2.9 applied to Γ , producing the source decomposition that is compressed; (b) through Theorem 2.9 applied to G , producing the ambient decomposition carrying the co-area inequality—and by Remark 4.3 this use is replaceable by any componentwise ℓ^1 Poincaré decomposition; (c) through the Kazhdan factor hypothesis of Theorem 2.10. The local Theorem 4.1 quantifies over the first two uses and leaves only the third to the black box.

Remark 10.5 (Scope). The Leavitt-corner theorem (Theorem 6.10) applies to an arbitrary nontrivial unital ring carrying a binary Leavitt family, whenever the two adjacent elementary groups are Kazhdan and the two matrices u, z are elementary; for finitely generated rings and $m \geq 3$ the Kazhdan hypothesis is automatic (Corollary 6.11). Finite fields are where all hypotheses are verified simultaneously (Theorem 8.7); characteristic two is where they are verified explicitly (Theorem 7.3); and the construction can already be carried out in rank two (Theorem 8.1).

Remark 10.6 (Soficity is not closed under quotients). Theorem A settles a companion closure question in the negative. Every group is a quotient of a free group, and free groups are residually finite—hence LEF, hence sofic; presenting the nonsocic group of Theorem A as such a quotient exhibits a residually finite group with a nonsocic quotient. Consequently none of the three classes—residually finite, LEF, sofic—is closed under quotients. This

Endpoint/QuotientNonclosure
e
exists_sofic_group_with_
nonsocic_quotient
exists_isLEF_group_with_non_
isLEF_quotient
exists_residuallyFinite_
group_with_non_
residuallyFinite_quotient
Sofic/FreeGroupResiduallyFi
nite
freeGroup_residuallyFinite
isSofic_freeGroup
Residual finiteness of free
groups is proved from scratch,
by the ball action on reduced
words; the three nonclosure
statements share one
presentation.

is also why the covers of Section 9 are proved nonsfic directly, from the forbidden table: a quotient-closure argument would have sufficed there, and none is valid.

APPENDIX A. AN ELEMENTARY AND EFFECTIVE PROOF OF $K_1(L_k(1, 2)) = 0$

This appendix proves the vanishing of K_1 announced in Remark 8.4, in the Whitehead form in which Section 8 uses it, by elementary means: no localization sequence, no spectra, and no input beyond the two Leavitt relations and one classical fact about L recorded as Lemma A.3 below. The proof is an algorithm—a Gaussian elimination over the binary tree—and the complexity accounting of Remark 8.5 reads off from it. The appendix is written to be read and checked entirely on paper.

Throughout, k is a field and $L = L_k(1, 2)$. Recall from Section 5 the word notation s_w, s_w^* (we write $t_w = s_w^*$ for the word w , so $t_w s_{w'} = \delta_{w, w'}$ for $|w| = |w'|$), the cylinder idempotents $p_w = s_w t_w$, and complete leaf sets. A *complete code of depth $\leq r$* (resp. $\geq r$) is a complete leaf set all of whose words have length $\leq r$ (resp. $\geq r$).

A.1. The Whitehead class group.

Definition A.1. Let

$$H = \{u \in L^\times \mid \text{diag}(u, 1) \in \text{EL}_2(L)\}.$$

Since $\text{diag}(uv, 1) = \text{diag}(u, 1) \text{diag}(v, 1)$, H is a subgroup of $L^\times$. The main theorem of this appendix is:

Theorem A.2. $H = L^\times$. *Equivalently, for every $u \in L^\times$ and every $r \geq 2$, the matrix $\text{diag}(u, 1, \dots, 1)$ is a product of elementary matrices in $\text{EL}_r(L)$.*

(The two forms are equivalent because $\text{EL}_2 \hookrightarrow \text{EL}_r$ in the first two coordinates.) The single external input is the following division property, a standard consequence of pure infiniteness and simplicity of L [1].

Lemma A.3 (Strong division). *For every nonzero $x \in L$ there are $p, q \in L$ with $pxq = 1$.*

The first consequence is a Gaussian elimination for invertible two-by-two matrices; it is the rank-two case of the GE property of purely infinite simple rings [3] in elementary form, and rank two is all the sequel needs—every higher rank is reached by flattening (Corollary A.23).

Lemma A.4 (Elementary diagonalization). *Let A be a nontrivial unital ring in which every nonzero element x admits p, q with $pxq = 1$, and let $X \in \text{GL}_2(A)$. Then there are $E, F \in \text{EL}_2(A)$ and $u \in A^\times$ with*

$$E X F = \text{diag}(u, 1).$$

Leavitt/DiagonalClassGroup
stableUnits
ScalarReduction

KOne/RefineLoopDischarge
K1_trivial
narrowReduction_holds
scalarReduction_holds
stableUnits_eq_top_holds

Leavitt/LeavittSimplicity
exists_mul_mul_eq_one

Leavitt/MatrixDiagonalizatio
n
exists_elementary_mul_diag
binaryLeavitt_exists_
elementary_mul_diag

Proof. Write $X = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}$. Assume first $a \neq 0$, and pick p, q with $paq = 1$. Three elementary operations plant a literal 1 in the corner: the column operation $C_2 += C_1 \cdot \rho$ with $\rho = q(1 - pb)$ replaces b by $b' = a\rho + b$, which satisfies $pb' = paq(1 - pb) + pb = 1$; the row operation $R_2 += wR_1$ with $w = (1 - d')p$, where $d' = c\rho + d$, replaces d' by $wb' + d' = (1 - d')pb' + d' = 1$; and with a 1 at position $(2, 2)$, the operations $R_1 += (-b')R_2$ and $C_1 += C_2 \cdot (-c')$ (where c' is the current $(2, 1)$ entry) clear the off-diagonal entries. The result is $\text{diag}(v, 1)$ with $v \in A^\times$, since the product of invertible matrices is invertible and a diagonal matrix is invertible exactly when its diagonal entries are. If $a = 0$, then some entry of X is nonzero (as X is invertible and $A \neq 0$), and one elementary row or column addition moves a nonzero element into position $(1, 1)$; this reduces to the previous case. $\square$

Leavitt/DiagonalClassGroup
conj_mem_elementaryGroup_of_
division
stableUnits_normal

Lemma A.5. $\text{EL}_2(L)$ is normal in $\text{GL}_2(L)$, and H is normal in $L^\times$.

Proof. Conjugation by an elementary matrix preserves EL_2 ; conjugation by $\text{diag}(u, v)$ sends $x_{12}(a)$ to $x_{12}(uav^{-1})$ and $x_{21}(a)$ to $x_{21}(vau^{-1})$, hence also preserves EL_2 ; and by Lemma A.4 every element of $\text{GL}_2(L)$ is a product of elementary matrices and one matrix $\text{diag}(u, 1)$. For the second claim, if $u \in H$ and $g \in L^\times$, then $\text{diag}(gug^{-1}, 1) = \text{diag}(g, 1) \text{diag}(u, 1) \text{diag}(g, 1)^{-1} \in \text{EL}_2(L)$ by the first claim. $\square$

By Lemma A.5 the quotient $L^\times/H$ is a group; we write $[u]$ for the class of u , so that Theorem A.2 says $[u] = 1$ for every unit. Three families of moves generate equalities in $L^\times/H$.

KOne/StableUnitsGenerators
mem_stableUnits_of_val_
unipotent
KOne/IncomparableUnipoten
ts
incomparableUnit_mem

Lemma A.6 (Unipotent moves). *Let $a, b \in L$ with $ba = 0$. Then $1 + ab \in H$. In particular, for prefix-incomparable words v, w and any $x \in L$, the cylinder unipotent $1 + s_v x t_w$ lies in H .*

Proof. From $ba = 0$, $(ab)^2 = a(ba)b = 0$, so $1 + ab$ is a unit with inverse $1 - ab$, and the four-term identity

$$\text{diag}(1 + ab, 1) = x_{12}(a) x_{21}(b) x_{12}(-a) x_{21}(-b)$$

holds by direct block computation: $x_{12}(a)x_{21}(b) = \begin{pmatrix} 1+ab & a \\ b & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, multiplying by $x_{12}(-a)$ clears the $(1, 2)$ entry using $-(1 + ab)a + a = -a(ba) = 0$, and $x_{21}(-b)$ clears the $(2, 1)$ entry. For the particular case take $a = s_v x$, $b = t_w$: then $ba = t_w s_v x = 0$ since v, w are incomparable. $\square$

Leavitt/WhiteheadFlip
flipUnit
diagPair_flipUnit_inv_mem
mul_flipUnit_inv_mem_
stableUnits

Lemma A.7 (The flip). *Let $x, y \in L$ and suppose $1 + xy \in L^\times$. Then $1 + yx \in L^\times$, with inverse $1 - y(1 + xy)^{-1}x$, and*

$$[1 + xy] = [1 + yx] \quad \text{in } L^\times/H.$$

Proof. The stated inverse is checked directly: $(1 + yx)(1 - y(1 + xy)^{-1}x) = 1 + yx - y(1 + xy)(1 + xy)^{-1}x = 1$, and likewise on the other side. The matrix $\text{diag}(1 + xy, (1 + yx)^{-1})$ factors into four elementary matrices,

$$x_{12}(x) x_{21}(y) x_{12}(-(1 + xy)^{-1}x) x_{21}(-(1 + yx)y),$$

again by direct computation. Hence

$\text{diag}((1+xy)(1+yx)^{-1}, 1) = \text{diag}(1+xy, (1+yx)^{-1}) \cdot \text{diag}((1+yx)^{-1}, 1+xy)$, and the second factor is a Whitehead diagonal (Lemma 5.5); both factors lie in $\text{EL}_2(L)$, so $(1+xy)(1+yx)^{-1} \in H$. $\square$

Lemma A.8 (Corner insertion). *For a binary word w and $u \in L^\times$, the corner insertion $\kappa_w(u) = s_w u t_w + (1 - p_w)$ is a unit, and $[\kappa_w(u)] = [u]$. Consequently every central unit lies in H .*

Proof. The matrix $X_w = \begin{pmatrix} s_w & 1-p_w \\ 0 & t_w \end{pmatrix}$ is invertible, with inverse $\begin{pmatrix} t_w & 0 \\ 1-p_w & s_w \end{pmatrix}$ (using $t_w s_w = 1$ and $(1-p_w)s_w = 0$), and it intertwines:

$$X_w \text{diag}(u, 1) X_w^{-1} = \text{diag}(\kappa_w(u), 1).$$

Thus $\text{diag}(\kappa_w(u)u^{-1}, 1) = [X_w, \text{diag}(u, 1)]$, a commutator of invertible matrices, one of which is elementary-diagonalizable; by Lemmas A.4 and 5.5 such a commutator lies in $\text{EL}_2(L)$, so $\kappa_w(u)u^{-1} \in H$.

For a central unit c , centrality gives $s_0 c t_0 + s_1 c t_1 = c(s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1) = c$; on the other hand a direct computation using $t_1 s_0 = 0$ shows

$$\kappa_0(c) \kappa_1(c) = s_0 c t_0 + s_1 c t_1.$$

Hence $[c] = [\kappa_0(c)][\kappa_1(c)] = [c]^2$ in $L^\times/H$, and $[c] = 1$. $\square$

A.2. Code moves. Complete leaf sets play the role of block structures. Two further families of units lie in H .

Lemma A.9 (Code scalars). *Let $\mathcal{D} = (w_1, \dots, w_\ell)$ be a complete leaf set and $G \in \text{GL}_\ell(k)$ an invertible scalar matrix. Then*

$$\Sigma_{\mathcal{D}}(G) = \sum_{i,j} s_{w_i} G_{ij} t_{w_j}$$

is a unit of L lying in H .

Proof. The assignment $G \mapsto \Sigma_{\mathcal{D}}(G)$ is unital and multiplicative by the leaf identities (Lemma 5.3), so $\Sigma_{\mathcal{D}}(G)$ is a unit with inverse $\Sigma_{\mathcal{D}}(G^{-1})$. Over the field k , G is a product of transvections and one diagonal matrix (Gaussian elimination). A transvection $I + \lambda E_{ij}$, $i \neq j$, transports to $1 + \lambda s_{w_i} t_{w_j}$, a cylinder unipotent in H by Lemma A.6 (leaves of a complete leaf set are pairwise incomparable). A diagonal matrix $\text{diag}(d_1, \dots, d_\ell)$ transports to $\prod_i \kappa_{w_i}(d_i)$ with central scalars $d_i \in k^\times$; each factor lies in H by Lemma A.8. $\square$

Lemma A.10 (Code changes). *Let $(\tau_1, \dots, \tau_\ell)$ and $(\sigma_1, \dots, \sigma_\ell)$ be complete leaf sets of the same size. Then the code change*

$$\Omega = \sum_{i=1}^{\ell} s_{\tau_i} t_{\sigma_i}$$

is a unit of L lying in H .

Leavitt/LeavittDiagonalClass
kappaUnit_mul_inv_mem_
stableUnits
central_mem_stableUnits
stableUnits_eq_top

KOne/CodeScalarMoves
codeScalar_unit_mem

KOne/CodeChangeUnits
codeChange_mem_stableUnits
KOne/CodeChangeGlue
codeBijection_mem_
stableUnits

Proof. Ω is a unit with inverse $\sum_i s_{\sigma_i} t_{\tau_i}$, by the leaf identities. Note that the Ω are precisely the images U_g of Thompson's group V under the embedding (23), together with their compositions with index bijections; the lemma is a generation theorem for the Higman–Thompson groupoid. Induct on ℓ . For $\ell = 1$ both sets are the empty word and $\Omega = 1$. For $\ell \geq 2$, the source set, being the leaf set of a finite full binary tree, contains a sibling pair $\sigma_a = w0$, $\sigma_b = w1$. Composing Ω with at most two *transpositions* aligns the pairing so that the targets of σ_a, σ_b are again a sibling pair $v0, v1$ in the same order; here a transposition is a code change that swaps two leaves x, y of one complete leaf set and fixes the rest, i.e. $T(x, y) = s_x t_y + s_y t_x + (1 - p_x - p_y)$, and $T(x, y) \in H$ because it is $\Sigma_{\mathcal{D}}(P)$ for the corresponding scalar permutation matrix P on any complete leaf set $\mathcal{D}$ refining $\{x, y\}$ —a code scalar (Lemma A.9). After alignment, the two sibling terms merge through the completeness relation, $s_{v0} t_{w0} + s_{v1} t_{w1} = s_v (s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1) t_w = s_v t_w$, producing a code change between complete leaf sets of size $\ell - 1$; the inductive hypothesis and normality of H conclude. $\square$

Corollary A.11 (Reshaping). *Let $(R_i), (C_j), (P_i), (Q_j)$ be complete leaf sets, with $|R| = |P|$ and $|C| = |Q|$, and let $E_{ij} \in L$. If*

$$u = \sum_{i,j} s_{R_i} E_{ij} t_{C_j} \quad \text{and} \quad v = \sum_{i,j} s_{P_i} E_{ij} t_{Q_j}$$

are both units, then $v = \Omega_1 u \Omega_2$ for code changes $\Omega_1 = \sum_i s_{P_i} t_{R_i}$ and $\Omega_2 = \sum_j s_{C_j} t_{Q_j}$, and hence $u \in H \iff v \in H$.

Proof. $\Omega_1 u \Omega_2 = \sum s_{P_i} (t_{R_i} s_{R_a}) E_{ab} (t_{C_b} s_{C_j}) t_{Q_j} = v$ by the leaf identities; apply Lemma A.10 and normality. $\square$

A.3. The degree filtration and width reduction. The defining relations of L are homogeneous for $\deg s_i = +1$, $\deg t_i = -1$, so the free-algebra grading descends: $L = \bigoplus_{d \in \mathbb{Z}} L_d$ is $\mathbb{Z}$ -graded, with L_d spanned by the monomials $s_\alpha t_\beta$, $|\alpha| - |\beta| = d$. Write

$$W[a, b] = \text{span}_k \{s_\alpha t_\beta \mid a \leq |\alpha| - |\beta| \leq b\},$$

and, for $x \in L$, write $x = \sum_d x^{(d)}$ for its graded components. Elements of $W[0, 0]$ are called *balanced*; by the leaf identities, the balanced elements supported at depth $\leq n$ are exactly the matrices $\sum_{\gamma, \delta} G_{\gamma\delta} s_\gamma t_\delta$ over the full code $\{0, 1\}^n$ with scalar G , i.e. the image of $M_{2^n}(k)$ under Σ -transport—so Lemma A.9 says: *balanced units are exactly the transported invertible scalar matrices, and they lie in H^1 .*

Lemma A.12 (Width reduction). *Every $u \in L^\times$ satisfies $[u] = [u']$ for some unit u' with value in $W[-1, 1]$ (a narrow unit).*

¹A balanced element that is a unit of L has invertible scalar matrix at its own depth—a singular matrix over a field is an annihilator of a nonzero matrix, hence a zero divisor—and therefore has balanced inverse.

KOne/PencilReshape
reshaped_pencil_mem_iff
exists_resaped_pencil
pencilVal_window_mem

Leavitt/LeavittWindowReduction
exists_window_reduction
Leavitt/LeavittGradingSpans
exists_corner_move
Leavitt/BinaryLeavittWindow
exists_narrow_representative

Proof. Every element of L lies in some window $W[-M, N]$. We show: if $N \geq 2$, then $[u] = [u'']$ for a unit u'' with value in $W[-M, \max(N-1, 1)]$; the mirror statement for $M \geq 2$ follows by the same argument applied to the anti-automorphism θ of Lemma A.13 below, and iterating both lands in $W[-1, 1]$.

The engine is the *corner move*: for any $v, w \in L$,

$$\begin{bmatrix} u \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} s_0(u + vw)t_0 + s_0vt_1 + s_1wt_0 + s_1t_1 \end{bmatrix},$$

obtained by transporting the 2×2 identity $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & v \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} u & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ w & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} u+vw & v \\ w & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ along Θ_{C_2} of Proposition 5.4: the images of the two unipotent factors are the cylinder-type unipotents $1+s_0vt_1$ and $1+s_1wt_0$, which lie in H by Lemma A.6, and the image of $\text{diag}(u, 1)$ is $\kappa_0(u)$, congruent to u by Lemma A.8.

Let x be the value of u , with top component $x^{(N)}$, $N \geq 2$. Since $y t_0 s_0 = y$ for every y , the top component factors as $x^{(N)} = b s_0$ with $b = x^{(N)} t_0 \in W[N-1, N-1]$. Apply the corner move with $v = -b$, $w = s_0$: the new value is

$$s_0(x - x^{(N)})t_0 - s_0bt_1 + s_1s_0t_0 + s_1t_1.$$

The first summand lies in $W[-M, N-1]$ (conjugation by $s_0(\cdot)t_0$ preserves degree), the second has degree $N-1$, and the last two have degrees 1 and 0. Hence the new unit has value in $W[-M, \max(N-1, 1)]$, as claimed. $\square$

A.4. Windows die. The next stage shows that units confined to a *one-sided* window already lie in H . This is where the analytic heart of the argument sits.

Lemma A.13 (Transpose). *The assignment $s_i \mapsto t_i$, $t_i \mapsto s_i$ extends to an anti-automorphism θ of L with $\theta^2 = \text{id}$; it maps $W[a, b]$ onto $W[-b, -a]$, and $u \in H \iff \theta(u) \in H$.*

KOne/ThetaStable
thetaMatUnit_mem_
elementaryGroup
thetaMatUnit_diagUnit

Proof. The relations are symmetric under the assignment composed with order reversal, so θ exists; it negates degree. Applying θ entrywise to the transpose of matrices sends $x_{ij}(a)$ to $x_{ji}(\theta(a))$ and $\text{diag}(u, 1)$ to $\text{diag}(\theta(u), 1)$, so it preserves EL_2 and hence membership in H . $\square$

Lemma A.14 (Pure tails are nilpotent). *Let $1 + \eta \in L^\times$ with $\eta \in W[1, 1]$. Then η is nilpotent.*

KOne/PureTailNilpotency
pure_tail_nilpotent

Proof. Let $y = (1 + \eta)^{-1}$, with graded components $y^{(d)}$ supported in a finite window. The equation $(1 + \eta)y = 1$ reads degree-wise: $y^{(d)} + \eta y^{(d-1)} = \delta_{d,0}$. From the bottom of the window upward, $y^{(d)} = 0$ for d below the window; then $y^{(d)} = -\eta y^{(d-1)}$ for $d < 0$ forces all negative components to vanish, $y^{(0)} = 1$, and $y^{(d)} = (-\eta)^d$ for $d > 0$. Since the window is finite, $(-\eta)^d = 0$ for large d . $\square$

KOne/NilpotentTailKill
nilpotent_tail_mem_
stableUnits
Leavitt/RankNormalForm
exists_rank_normal_form

Lemma A.15 (Nilpotent tails die). *Let $z \in L$ be balanced with s_1z nilpotent, and let $u \in L^\times$ have value $1 + s_1z$. Then $u \in H$.*

Proof. Induct on the nilpotency index D of s_1z ; for $D = 1$, $z = t_1(s_1z) = 0$ and $u = 1$. For $D \geq 2$, put $r = t_1(s_1z)^{D-1}$, of pure degree $D - 2$, so that $(s_1z)^{D-1} = s_1r$ and $r(s_1z) = t_1(s_1z)^D = 0$. Factor $r = Rs_0^{D-2}$ with $R = rt_0^{D-2}$ balanced, take a balanced pseudo-inverse Ξ of R —balanced elements are scalar matrices along a full code, and every scalar matrix R admits Ξ with $R\Xi R = R$ —and set

$$e = t_0^{D-2} \Xi r,$$

a balanced element with the two properties that drive the induction: $e(s_1z) = t_0^{D-2} \Xi(r(s_1z)) = 0$, and $re = (rt_0^{D-2}) \Xi r = R\Xi R s_0^{D-2} = Rs_0^{D-2} = r$, whence $(s_1z)^{D-1}e = s_1(re) = s_1r = (s_1z)^{D-1}$. The mover $1 - s_1(ze) = 1 - (s_1z)e$ lies in H by Lemma A.6 with $(a, b) = (s_1z, -e)$, since $ba = -e(s_1z) = 0$; and for the same reason

$$(1 - s_1(ze))(1 + s_1z) = 1 + s_1(z - ze),$$

the cross term being $-s_1(ze)(s_1z) = -s_1z(e(s_1z)) = 0$. The new tail satisfies $(s_1(z - ze))^{D-1} = (s_1z)^{D-1}(1 - e) = 0$, using $(1 - e)(s_1z) = s_1z$ to telescope and then the second property of e ; so its index is at most $D - 1$, and the inductive hypothesis applies to u times the mover. $\square$

Lemma A.16 (The keystone). *Let $u = c + \zeta \in L^\times$ with c balanced and $\zeta \in W[1, 1]$. Then $c \in L^\times$.*

Proof. Suppose not. Balanced elements at depth n are scalar matrices $M_{2^n}(k)$ along the full code; by the rank normal form over the field k there are balanced units g, h with $gch = e := \sum_{\gamma \in S} p_\gamma$, a cylinder idempotent over a subset S of the depth- n code, and c is invertible exactly when S is everything. So assume S proper, and let $f = 1 - e = \sum_{\gamma \in T} p_\gamma$ with $T \neq \emptyset$. Replace u by $w = guh = e + \zeta'$ (with $\zeta' = g\zeta h \in W[1, 1]$); invertibility of c is not affected. Let $y = w^{-1}$, with graded components $y^{(d)}$, $d \in [\text{lo}, \text{hi}]$, and let $M = -\text{lo}$.

The equation $wy = 1$ reads degree-wise $ey^{(d)} + \zeta'y^{(d-1)} = \delta_{d,0}$. Multiplying the $d = 0$ equation by f on both sides ($fe = 0$, $f^2 = f$) gives $f = f\zeta'y^{(-1)}f$, and substituting the relation $y^{(d)} = fy^{(d)} - \zeta'y^{(d-1)}$ (valid for $d \leq -1$, from $ey^{(d)} = -\zeta'y^{(d-1)}$) repeatedly yields, after M steps (the components below the window vanish),

$$(40) \quad f = \sum_{j=0}^{M-1} \underbrace{f\zeta'(-\zeta')^j}_{\deg=j+1} \cdot \underbrace{fy^{(-1-j)}f}_{\deg=-1-j}.$$

Now count ranks at a deep uniform interface. For ℓ large, every factor in (40) is represented by a scalar matrix between the full codes of appropriate depths: an element of $W[d, d]$ supported at bounded depth is, for all large q , a $2^{q+d} \times 2^q$ scalar matrix (pad with the completeness relation). Representing the j -th summand at interface depths $\ell \rightarrow \ell - 1 - j \rightarrow \ell$, the middle factor passes through the matrix of f at depth $\ell - 1 - j$, whose rank is exactly

$|T| 2^{\ell-1-j-n}$. Hence the matrix of the right-hand side of (40) at depth ℓ has rank at most $\sum_{j < M} |T| 2^{\ell-1-j-n} < |T| 2^{\ell-n}$ —a geometric series short of its limit—while the matrix of f at depth ℓ has rank exactly $|T| 2^{\ell-n}$. This contradiction proves the lemma. $\square$

Proposition A.17 (Windows die). *A unit of L whose value lies in $W[0, N]$ for some N , or in $W[-N, 0]$, lies in H .*

Proof. By the transpose (Lemma A.13) it suffices to treat $W[0, N]$; induct on N .

Base, $N \leq 1$. Let $u = c + \zeta$, c balanced, $\zeta \in W[1, 1]$. By the keystone (Lemma A.16) c is a balanced unit, so $c \in H$ with balanced inverse, and $u = c(1 + \eta)$ with $\eta = c^{-1}\zeta \in W[1, 1]$. By Lemma A.14 η is nilpotent. The corner insertion $\kappa_1(1 + \eta) = 1 + s_1(\eta t_1)$ is congruent to $1 + \eta$ (Lemma A.8), has balanced tail coefficient $z = \eta t_1$, and $s_1 z = s_1 \eta t_1$ inherits nilpotency from η (indeed $(s_1 \eta t_1)^j = s_1 \eta^j t_1$); Lemma A.15 finishes.

Step, $N \geq 2$. Write the value as $1 + (a + \eta)$ with $a \in W[0, N - 1]$ —subtracting 1 costs nothing since 1 is balanced—and η the top component, of degree N . Split $\eta = s_0 q_0 + s_1 q_1$ with $q_z = t_z \eta$ of degree $N - 1$. Perform the stable Whitehead block move along the four depth-two cylinders: with

$$X_z = s_{00} s_z t_{w_z}, \quad Y_z = s_{w_z} q_z t_{00}, \quad (w_0, w_1) = (01, 10),$$

set $m_2 = (1 - X_0)(1 - X_1)$ and $m_1 = (1 + Y_0)(1 + Y_1)$, products of cylinder unipotents in H (Lemma A.6), and let $\kappa = \kappa_{00}(u) = 1 + s_{00}(a + \eta)t_{00}$, congruent to u . In the product $m_2 \kappa m_1$ all cross terms vanish by incomparability of the three cylinders 00, 01, 10, except

$$X_0 Y_0 + X_1 Y_1 = s_{00} (s_0 q_0 + s_1 q_1) t_{00} = s_{00} \eta t_{00},$$

which cancels the top component inside κ . The value of $m_2 \kappa m_1$ is therefore

$$1 + (s_{00} a t_{00} - X_0 - X_1 + Y_0 + Y_1),$$

whose components have degrees in $[0, N - 1]$: the a -part keeps its degrees, $\deg X_z = 1$, and $\deg Y_z = N - 1$. By induction $m_2 \kappa m_1 \in H$, hence $u \in H$. $\square$

A.5. The pencil and the elimination loop.

Lemma A.18 (Pencil form). *Let $x \in W[-1, 1]$. Then there are m and scalar matrices A_0, A_1, C, B_0, B_1 , indexed by the full code $\mathcal{F} = \{0, 1\}^{m+1}$, with*

$$x = \sum_{i,j \in \mathcal{F}} s_i E_{ij} t_j, \quad E_{ij} = A_{0,ij} t_0 + A_{1,ij} t_1 + C_{ij} \cdot 1 + B_{0,ij} s_0 + B_{1,ij} s_1.$$

Proof. Choose m with all monomials of x of depth $\leq m$, and expand $x = \sum_{i,j} s_i (t_i x s_j) t_j$ along the full code of depth $m + 1$ (completeness relation on both sides). For a monomial $s_\alpha t_\beta$ of x and code words i, j of length $m + 1$: $t_i s_\alpha$ vanishes unless α is a prefix of i , in which case it is $t_{i'}$ with $|i'| = m + 1 - |\alpha| \geq 1$, and symmetrically $t_\beta s_j = s_{j'}$ with $|j'| = m + 1 - |\beta| \geq 1$; the product $t_{i'} s_{j'}$ collapses, by the prefix calculus, to 0, a scalar, or a single

KOne/WindowNonnegReduction
window_nonneg_mem_stableUnits
KOne/WindowNonposReduction
window_nonpos_mem_stableUnits
KOne/WidthTwoReduction
window_zero_one_mem_stableUnits

KOne/PencilForm
exists_pencil_form
KOne/RefineLoopDischarge
pencilEntry_mem_window
codePair_expansion

letter s_z or t_z , according to the degree $|\alpha| - |\beta| \in \{-1, 0, 1\}$. Hence each corner entry $t_i x s_j$ lies in the five-dimensional scalar pencil space displayed. $\square$

We call a unit in this form a *pencil unit* over the code pair (rows, columns); the data is the quintuple of scalar matrices, and the *stack* is the vertical block matrix $\begin{pmatrix} B_0 \\ B_1 \end{pmatrix}$.

Lemma A.19 (Strict negativity). *Let u be a pencil unit over complete leaf sets (R_i) , (C_j) , and suppose the stack admits a scalar left inverse: matrices G_0, G_1 with $G_0 B_0 + G_1 B_1 = I$. Then there is N such that every corner entry of the inverse,*

$$y_{ji} = t_{C_j} u^{-1} s_{R_i},$$

lies in $W[-N, -1]$.

Proof. All y_{ji} lie in a common finite window; let d^* be the largest degree in which any y_{ji} has a nonzero component, and suppose $d^* \geq 0$. From $u u^{-1} = 1$, sandwiching and inserting the completeness relation for (C_j) ,

$$\sum_j E_{ij} y_{ji'} = \delta_{ii'} \quad (\text{all } i, i').$$

Take the component of degree $d^* + 1 \geq 1$ on both sides. On the left only the degree-+1 part of E can contribute against $y^{(d^*)}$ —components of y above d^* vanish—so

$$\sum_j (B_{0,ij} s_0 + B_{1,ij} s_1) y_{ji'}^{(d^*)} = 0.$$

Multiplying on the left by t_0 and by t_1 separates the two shifts:

$$\sum_j B_{0,ij} y_{ji'}^{(d^*)} = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \sum_j B_{1,ij} y_{ji'}^{(d^*)} = 0;$$

that is, the stack annihilates the matrix $Y = (y_{ji'}^{(d^*)})$ on the left. Applying the scalar left inverse, $Y = (G_0 B_0 + G_1 B_1) Y = 0$, contradicting the choice of d^* . Hence all components have degree ≤ -1 . $\square$

Lemma A.20 (Refinement step). *Let u be a pencil unit over (R, C) whose column j_0 is stack-free: $B_{0,ij_0} = B_{1,ij_0} = 0$ for all i . Then u is also a pencil unit over the code pair (R, C') , where C' replaces the word C_{j_0} by its two children $C_{j_0} 0, C_{j_0} 1$, with data given columnwise by*

$$(A_0, A_1, C, B_0, B_1)_{\cdot j_0 z} = (0, 0, A_{z, \cdot j_0}, [z=0] C_{\cdot j_0}, [z=1] C_{\cdot j_0}),$$

all other columns unchanged.

Proof. Insert $1 = s_0 t_0 + s_1 t_1$ before $t_{C_{j_0}}$: each term $s_{R_i} E_{ij_0} t_{C_{j_0}}$ becomes $\sum_z s_{R_i} (E_{ij_0} s_z) t_{C_{j_0} z}$, and for a stack-free entry the split identity

$$(a_0 t_0 + a_1 t_1 + c) s_z = a_z + c s_z$$

shows $E_{ij_0} s_z$ is again a pencil entry, with the A -data falling to the constant slot and the constant to the B -slot—the index shift of the Wiener–Hopf analogy. $\square$

KOne/StrictNegativePencil
entry_window_negative_of_B_
full

KOne/RefineStep
refine_column
pencilEntry_mul_s
KOne/GLVectorNormalizatio
n
exists_isUnit_matrix_col

KOne/CodeShapeSupply
exists_shallow_code
exists_deep_code

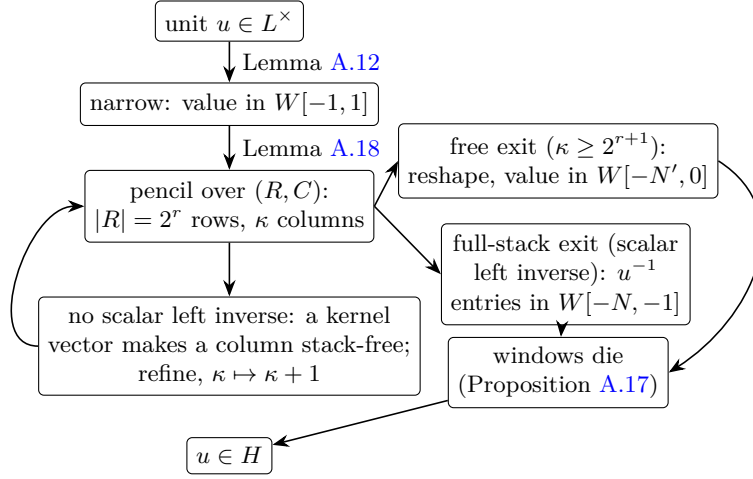


FIGURE 5. The elimination loop of Theorem A.22. Each pass either exits—shallow-versus-deep reshaping lands the unit, or its inverse, in a one-sided window—or splits one stack-free column, raising the column count; the counter $2^{r+1} - \kappa$ bounds the number of passes.

Lemma A.21 (Code supply). *For $1 \leq \kappa \leq 2^r$ there is a complete leaf set of size κ and depth $\leq r$; for $\kappa \geq 2^M$ there is one of size κ and depth $\geq M$.*

Proof. Kraft counting. Shallow: start from the full code of depth $\lceil \log_2 \kappa \rceil \leq r$ and merge sibling pairs until κ leaves remain (each merge reduces the count by one and cannot increase depth). Deep: start from the full code of depth M , of size $2^M \leq \kappa$, and split leaves (each split increases the count by one and produces words of length $\geq M$). $\square$

Figure 5 charts the elimination.

Theorem A.22 (The elimination loop). *Every pencil unit over a row code of 2^r words lies in H .*

Proof. Let u be a pencil unit over (R, C) , $|R| = 2^r$, $|C| = \kappa$. We induct on $2^{r+1} - \kappa$ (when this is ≤ 0 , the first case below applies).

Free exit ($\kappa \geq 2^{r+1}$). By Lemma A.21 choose a shallow complete code P of size 2^r and depth $\leq r$, and a deep complete code Q of size κ and depth $\geq r + 1$. Reshape u to the pair (P, Q) (Corollary A.11). Each pencil entry lies in $W[-1, 1]$, so each monomial of the reshaped value has degree at most $|P_i| + 1 - |Q_j| \leq r + 1 - (r + 1) = 0$: the reshaped unit lies in $W[-N', 0]$ for some N' , hence in H by Proposition A.17, hence $u \in H$.

Full stack. If the stack has a scalar left inverse, Lemma A.19 puts every corner entry y_{ji} of u^{-1} in $W[-N, -1]$. Expand $u^{-1} = \sum_{j,i} s_{C_j} y_{ji} t_{R_i}$ and reshape to a shallow column code of depth $\leq r + 1$ (possible: $\kappa \leq 2^{r+1}$ in this branch, or the free exit applies) and a deep row code of depth $\geq r$. Monomial

KOne/RefineLoopDischarge
pencil_free_exit
pencil_full_exit
pencil_unit_mem_pow

degrees are at most $(r+1) + (-1) - r = 0$, so $u^{-1} \in H$ by Proposition A.17, and $u \in H$.

Refine. Otherwise the stack, having no scalar left inverse, has a nonzero kernel vector v (over the field k , a matrix with trivial kernel has a left inverse). Choose an invertible scalar matrix G whose j_0 -th column is v (extend v to a basis). The code scalar $\Sigma_C(G)$ lies in H (Lemma A.9), and $u \cdot \Sigma_C(G)$ is a pencil unit over (R, C) with data multiplied columnwise by G ; its column j_0 is stack-free because v kills both B_0 and B_1 . Apply the refinement step (Lemma A.20): a pencil unit over (R, C') with $\kappa + 1$ columns. The counter $2^{r+1} - \kappa$ has dropped; the inductive hypothesis gives $u \cdot \Sigma_C(G) \in H$, hence $u \in H$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem A.2. Let $u \in L^\times$. By width reduction (Lemma A.12), $[u] = [u']$ with u' narrow; by the pencil form (Lemma A.18), u' is a pencil unit over the full code pair of depth $m+1$, a row code of 2^{m+1} words; by the elimination loop (Theorem A.22), $u' \in H$. Hence $u \in H$. $\square$

A.6. Consequences and effectivity.

Corollary A.23. *For every field k and $L = L_k(1, 2)$: $K_1(L) = 0$; $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$ for every $r \geq 2$; and $L^\times$ is perfect.*

Proof. Rank two. For $X \in \text{GL}_2(L)$, Lemma A.4 writes $EXF = \text{diag}(u, 1)$, and Theorem A.2 places the diagonal factor in $\text{EL}_2(L)$; hence $\text{GL}_2(L) = \text{EL}_2(L)$. (This is the only use of Gaussian elimination; every higher rank now follows by transport.)

Every rank, by flattening. The coefficient isomorphism $\Theta_C^{-1} : L \cong M_n(L)$ of Proposition 5.4 carries EL_p onto EL_p entrywise, and block flattening identifies $\text{EL}_p(M_q(L)) = \text{EL}_{pq}(L)$ inside $\text{GL}_{pq}(L)$ for $p \geq 2$ (the two inclusions proved in Proposition 5.8); both maps are restrictions of ring isomorphisms of the ambient matrix rings, so each transports the *equality* $\text{GL} = \text{EL}$. Starting from rank two: $\text{GL}_2(L) = \text{EL}_2(L)$ transports through $L \cong M_n(L)$ and flattening to $\text{GL}_{2n}(L) = \text{EL}_{2n}(L)$ for every n ; and for arbitrary $r \geq 2$, the same two maps with the roles of r and 2 exchanged transport $\text{GL}_{2r} = \text{EL}_{2r}$, already established, back down to $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$.

K_1 and perfectness. Since $\text{GL}_r(L) = \text{EL}_r(L)$ at every rank, every class of the stable quotient defining $K_1(L)$ is trivial: $K_1(L) = 0$. For perfectness, Θ_{C_3} restricts to a group isomorphism $\text{GL}_3(L) \cong L^\times$, and $\text{GL}_3(L) = \text{EL}_3(L)$ is perfect: by the Steinberg relation, every generator $x_{ij}(a) = [x_{il}(a), x_{lj}(1)]$ with $l \notin \{i, j\}$ is a commutator. Hence $L^\times = [L^\times, L^\times]$. $\square$

The proof of Theorem A.2 is an algorithm, and every step is effective Gaussian elimination over k : the width reduction processes one graded component per corner move; the pencil form is a change of basis at depth $m+1$; each loop pass computes a kernel vector or a left inverse of the stack; and both exits are reshapes along explicitly constructed codes followed by the window inductions, each step of which is again explicit. For a unit supported

KOne/RefineLoopDischarge
glTwo_eq_elementary_holds
glFour_eq_elementary_holds
KOne/AllRanksElementary
elementaryGroup_eq_top
glAll_eq_elementary
binaryLeavittUnits_perfect

on monomials of depth at most d , all codes involved have at most 2^{d+2} words and the loop executes at most 2^{d+1} times, giving the complexity bound of Remark 8.5: the elementary factorization of $\text{diag}(u, 1, \dots, 1)$ is computed in time polynomial in 2^d and in the number of monomials of u .

REFERENCES

- [1] G. Abrams and G. Aranda Pino, *Purely infinite simple Leavitt path algebras*, J. Pure Appl. Algebra **207** (2006), 553–563.
- [2] P. Ara, M. Brustenga, and G. Cortiñas, *K-theory of Leavitt path algebras*, Münster J. Math. **2** (2009), 5–34.
- [3] P. Ara, K. R. Goodearl, and E. Pardo, *K_0 of purely infinite simple regular rings*, K-Theory **26** (2002), 69–100.
- [4] G. Baumslag and D. Solitar, *Some two-generator one-relator non-Hopfian groups*, Bull. Amer. Math. Soc. **68** (1962), 199–201.
- [5] C. Bleak and M. Quick, *The infinite simple group V of Richard J. Thompson: presentations by permutations*, Groups Geom. Dyn. **11** (2017), 1401–1436.
- [6] J. W. Cannon, W. J. Floyd, and W. R. Parry, *Introductory notes on Richard Thompson’s groups*, Enseign. Math. (2) **42** (1996), 215–256.
- [7] G. Elek and E. Szabó, *On sofic groups*, J. Group Theory **9** (2006), 161–171.
- [8] Kivanç Ersoy, *On minimal non-sofic and ω -non-sofic groups*, arXiv:2604.19174 [math.GR], 2026.
- [9] M. Ershov and A. Jaikin-Zapirain, *Property (T) for noncommutative universal lattices*, Invent. Math. **179** (2010), 303–347.
- [10] M. Gromov, *Endomorphisms of symbolic algebraic varieties*, J. Eur. Math. Soc. (JEMS) **1** (1999), 109–197.
- [11] G. Higman, *Finitely Presented Infinite Simple Groups*, Notes on Pure Mathematics, vol. 8, Department of Pure Mathematics, Department of Mathematics, I.A.S., Australian National University, Canberra, 1974.
- [12] H. V. Khanh and V. H. Thanh, *Matrix generators for the unit groups of $L_K(1, d)$* , arXiv:2607.10351 [math.RA], 2026.
- [13] G. Kun, *On sofic approximations of Property (T) groups*, arXiv:1606.04471v5 [math.CO], 2016; revised 2019.
- [14] G. Kun and A. Thom, *Inapproximability of actions and Kazhdan’s property (T)*, arXiv:1901.03963v2 [math.GR], 2019.
- [15] W. G. Leavitt, *The module type of a ring*, Trans. Amer. Math. Soc. **103** (1962), 113–130.
- [16] V. Nekrashevych, *Cuntz–Pimsner algebras of group actions*, J. Operator Theory **52** (2004), 223–249.
- [17] E. Pardo, *The isomorphism problem for Higman–Thompson groups*, J. Algebra **344** (2011), 172–183.
- [18] V. G. Pestov, *Hyperlinear and sofic groups: a brief guide*, Bull. Symbolic Logic **14** (2008), 449–480.
- [19] Y. Shalom, *Rigidity of commensurators and irreducible lattices*, Invent. Math. **141** (2000), 1–54.
- [20] A. M. Vershik and E. I. Gordon, *Groups that are locally embeddable in the class of finite groups*, Algebra i Analiz **9** (1997), 71–97; English transl., St. Petersburg Math. J. **9** (1998), 49–67.
- [21] B. Weiss, *Sofic groups and dynamical systems*, Sankhyā Ser. A **62** (2000), 350–359.